

Fate's Edge
The Southern Realms (Akilan)

Kofi of the Salt Syndicate
(stamped, witnessed, and slightly stained)

June 3, 2026

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Preface: The Salt Trader's Ledger

I am a son of Oshiira. My grandfather weighed grain for the Widow; my mother balanced the canal ledgers. I inherited a brass scale and a healthy suspicion of anyone who does not stamp their receipts three times.

The south is not a mystery. It is a network of trade routes, water rights, and harvest schedules – if you know how to read them. The Oshiiran Ledger Empire keeps the Amaranthine fed. Taharka's passes guard the monsoon gold. Ngomebe's walking cities are a wonder, yes, but also a contract: their iron for our grain, renewed every nine years.

And then there are the others. Sekogo's jungle folk whisper to trees. The Crimson Valley's silk-wardens tie promises into cords that tighten when you lie. And Ashaan... Ashaan is a tragedy. A once-great empire that sold its soul to keep its throne. I do not envy them. I do not forgive them. I simply note their tariffs and move on.

This book is not a tourist's guide. It is a trader's inventory. I have marked the places where a misplaced stamp can halt a caravan, where a forgotten water right can start a war, and where a single true story can buy safe passage through a hundred miles of hostile hills.

You want to trade the southern routes? Learn the customs. Respect the spirits. Never refuse the third cup of coffee in Taharka – and never, ever ask a Sidhi freedman about their ancestry.

The ledger is open. The scales are balanced. Let us begin.

— *Kofi of the Salt Syndicate, Mbaro weigh-house, stamped and witnessed*

Safety & Sensibility

Before play, establish how the table handles sensitive content. Fate’s Edge uses three standard tools:

- **Lines:** Content that will not appear at all (e.g., “no on-screen torture of children”).
- **Veils:** Content that happens off-screen or fades to black (e.g., “slavery is referenced but not depicted in graphic detail”).
- **X-Card:** Any player may stop a scene at any time by drawing an X on a card or saying “X.” No questions, no explanations.

A Note on Ashaan

Ashaan is a setting of systemic cruelty: chattel slavery, state-sanctioned violence, child sacrifice (secret cults), and the erasure of identity. The Veiled Sisters rule through terror; the Black Hand erases dissent; the Breath-less resistance struggles in shadows.

These themes are presented as **horror and injustice**, never glamorised. Before playing in Ashaan, use the standard safety tools with particular care. The GM should adjust or omit elements as needed for the table’s comfort. Your safety matters more than canon.

“The Veil is not a choice. It is survival.” – Breath-less agent Tamar

Beyond the Dark Continent: A Note on Inspiration

The Southern Realms (Akilan) draw inspiration from the rich and varied cultures of Saharan, Sahelian, West African, East African, and Southern Africa – but they are not a pastiche of any single real-world culture. This essay explains how Fate’s Edge approaches these inspirations and deliberately avoids harmful tropes.

No Monolithic “Africa”

The southern continent is vast, with distinct regions that have little in common. Oshiira’s grain-ledger bureaucracy owes more to the medieval empires of the Sahel (Ghana, Mali, Songhai) than to any “tribal” stereotype. Ngomebe’s walking cities are technological marvels, not “primitive” structures. Taharka’s highland fortresses echo Ethiopia’s rock-hewn churches and mountain kingdoms. Sekogo’s jungle societies take cues from the forest kingdoms of West Africa (Benin, Ife, Kongo). Each region has its own economy, religion, and internal conflicts.

Agency, Not Exoticism

The people of the Southern Realms are not passive recipients of outside influence. They trade, they raid, they negotiate, they resist. The Oshiiran Vermilion Corps audits foreign merchants; Taharkan passes have never been conquered; Ngomebe’s mason-kin maintain their own engineering partnerships with Aeler dwarves. When the Kahfagian Admiralty encroaches on the Brass Coast, the Sidhi diaspora and native rajas fight back.

No “Noble Savages”

The beast-kin of the Valewood are refugees of magical experiments, not “one with nature” caricatures. The Lethai-ar are sophisticated legal scholars, not mystical forest dwellers. The Aelaerem of the Southern Hills are not “pygmies” – they are a distinct culture with their own coffee rites and knot-magic, and they trade as equals with Taharkan lords.

Avoiding the “Dark Continent” Label

The book explicitly names the region “The Southern Realms (Akilan).” *Akilan* is an in-world term from the old Akilan Empire that preceded the Utaran conquest; it is not a real-world

exonym. No character refers to the south as “dark” or “uncivilised” without that bias being challenged by the text.

Colonialism as Villain

The Kahfagian Admiralty’s presence on the Brass Coast is depicted as exploitative. The Ashaani slave trade is unequivocally evil. The Fenwood sack of Lence is a war crime. The party is never encouraged to side with oppressors without consequences.

GM Guidance

- Encourage players to create characters from these cultures without relying on stereotypes. Use the almanacs and NPC tables for grounded details.
- When a player repeats a harmful trope (e.g., “the jungle is savage”), pause and ask: “Is that what your character believes, or is that the truth of the world?”
- Use the safety tools liberally, especially in Ashaan.

The Southern Realms are not a dark continent. They are a bright, complicated, and fully human place – and they are ready for your stories.

How to Use This Book

This book is a companion to the *Fate's Edge Core Amaranthine Worldbook* and the *System Reference Document (SRD)*. It provides regional content for the Southern Realms (Akilan) using the same card-driven generator system.

Each regional chapter contains:

- A short atmosphere paragraph (in the voice of Kofi, your biased trader – take his opinions with a grain of salt).
- A local quote.
- An *almanac* – a quick Q&A about daily life.
- Then a full set of generator tables ( *places*,  *people*,  *complications*,  *rewards*), *imported from the Cartomancer's Compass* *.

For the core rules (attributes, skills, actions, magic, summoning, travel, etc.), refer to the *Fate's Edge SRD or Player/GM Guides*. The generators assume you are familiar with the Position, Effect, and Clock mechanics.

“The road is a ledger. Every oasis is a credit, every broken wheel a debt.” – Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 1

Gateways & Travel

The ledger is open. The scales are balanced. The ninth page is waiting.

Travel Modes of the Southern Realms

River Legs (Oshiira, Crimson Valley)

Canals, weigh-houses, and canal mothers. Travel clocks advance when barges queue at locks. A **Water-Share Tablet** or a **Vermilion Corps Seal** buys priority passage.

Desert Legs (Ashaan, Fhara)

Water is the primary resource. A dry well hazard can end a journey. Travel requires a **Water-Skin** and a **Spirit-Lamp** to ward off the restless dead. The **Brass Gate** (Ashaan-Oshiira border) is fortified with spirit-buoys that scream when crossed.

Jungle Legs (Sekogo, Crimson Valley)

Navigation by smell and sound; hidden Leopard Society patrols. A **Honey-Jar** or an **Ukwe Leaf** (witness token) pacifies the spirits of the grove. Never cut a marked tree – the wood remembers.

Highland Legs (Taharka)

Thin air; breath-counting; passes that close for storms. A **Pass-Stone** or a **Horse Bond** grants passage. Never refuse the second cup of coffee – it is a test of honour.

Stone Legs (Ngomebe)

Travel with a walking city requires a **Keystone Charter** and a **Stone-Song**. The city's Migration Clock advances each day; if it stops, the Hollow walks.

Gateways to Other Expansions

- **Amaranthine Core (Kahfagia, Ecktoria, etc.):** From Oshiira, sail the **Narrow of Sorrows** north to Kahfagia. From the Brass Coast, the **Black River** leads to Thepyrgos.
- **Way of Silk (Fhara, Sidhi, Pereshi, Kuvani, Tulkani):** From Oshiira, the **Salt Road** crosses the Sahel to Fhara. From Ashaan, the **Red Desert** leads to Pereshi highlands.
- **Eastern Realms (Sihai, Nihori, Ayokha):** From Ngomebe, the **Salt Scar** connects to the eastern passes. From Taharka, the monsoon winds carry ships to Ayokha.
- **Dhahara (Brass Coast, Nine Kingdoms, Himadri):** The Brass Coast is part of Dhahara – see the Dhahara expansion for details.

Chapter 2

Oshiira

The Ledger Empire.

Kofi says: *“The Widow’s health is a state secret, and the Vermilion Corps has ears in every weigh-house. Speak carelessly, and your name may be the next one forgotten – or, worse, audited.”*

Oshiira is a confederacy of hundreds of tribes and city-states, united by hunger – not famine control, but the Grain Covenant: contribute to the granaries, and you will never starve. The capital, Mbaro, is a city of canals, weigh-houses, and the great Granary Tower. The Widow rules, but the Vermilion Corps guards the ledgers, and the Narrow Captains provoke Kahfagia just to remind the Admiralty who really controls the straits.

“Never speak of succession before naming the Widow. The empress’s health is a state secret, and the Vermilion Corps has ears in every weigh-house.”

— Vermilion Corps Auditor

What do people eat for breakfast? Millet porridge with dried fish – the millet from the Sahel flood plains, the fish smoked over canal-barges. The porridge is always the same. The fish varies by season.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To weigh a grain. Every Oshiiran child is given a balance scale and a single grain of millet. By age five, they know the difference between a northern harvest and a southern one – the difference is the tax.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Merchants have ink-stained fingers – the ink from the Ledger. Clean fingers have never signed a contract. Red stains mean a death warrant.

What is the most common crime? Ledger fraud – but fraud is a career. The Vermilion Corps audits the auditors. The land does not lie.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Widow has not been seen in public for seven years. Her voice is a recording. Her seal is a stamp. The Vermilion Corps is the Widow. The Widow is dead. The empire continues.

Where do people go when they die? To the Granary Tower. The dead are ground into meal and mixed with millet. The grain is shipped across the Amaranthine. The empire does not ask.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a correction to the Ledger, witnessed by a Vermilion Corps auditor. The seal glows under moonlight – the Widow’s eye.

What is the most important festival? The Harvest of the Ledger (autumn). The names of the year’s debtors are read aloud. Those who cannot pay are added to the Ledger’s ninth page, sealed with black wax.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Ledger’s missing page was burned by the Widow herself. The ash was mixed into the mortar of the Granary Tower. It still glows under moonlight – it spells the name of the heir she killed.

2.1 Oshiira — “The Grain Covenant”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The harvest does not forgive waste. The granary does not forget hunger. We do not rule — we feed.*

Vermilion Corps Warden (Elite): “The granary does not forgive arithmetic errors. A single miscounted bushel can unmake a house, a tribe, an empire. I am not here to be kind. I am here to be correct.”

Canal Mother (Commoner): “Water is memory. Every canal remembers the hands that dug it, the barges that passed, the widows who wept at its edge. Control the water, and you control what the empire remembers. The Vermilion Corps guards the grain. We guard the thirst.”

Genre / Mood: Sahelian logistics, grain-house community, the weight of survival.

Starting Location: A grain-loading pier on the Shoreless Bay, where Oshiiran millet is being loaded onto Ecktorian barges. The air smells of chaff and shared purpose. A Narrow Captain with a scarred throat approaches, her hand resting on a tallies wrapped in oilcloth. “Kahfagian freebooters were sighted at dawn. The Widow wants deniable assets. Congratulations — you’re now deniable. Find out who’s leaking our sailing schedules before the next shipment sails. Or don’t. I’m sure the canals will remember you fondly.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Oshiira is a confederacy of hundreds of tribes and city-states, united by hunger. Not famine — *control*. The Grain Covenant is not a book of weights. It is a promise: contribute to the granaries, and you will never starve. The capital, Mbaro, is a city of canals, weigh-houses, and the great Granary Tower — a stone spine that casts a shadow over every table from the Shoreless Bay to the Red Desert's edge. Oshiira is the breadbasket of the Amaranthine; its millet fills the holds of Ecktorian, Vhasian, and Silkstrand ships. But the breadbasket has a lock. The Widow holds the key.

For centuries, the Widow — the empress of Oshiira — has held the confederacy together through marriage alliances, grain quotas, and the careful, communal distribution of water rights. But age is catching up. Memory is fading. The Vermilion Corps guards not only grain but the covenant itself. They have ears in every weigh-house, eyes in every canal. And somewhere in the Granary Tower, a page of the Great Tally has been lost — eaten by weevils during the Famine of the Ninth Year. That page named the true heir.

The Vermilion Corps has been searching for that page for nine years. They have questioned nine scribes. The ninth scribe's ghost still walks the tower, counting bushels that no longer exist.

What you notice first: The smell of grain dust and canal water — sweet and wholesome at once. The constant scratch of reed pens on parchment, like insects in the walls. The way everyone — from merchant to slave — touches their receipt before speaking of trade. The way the silence falls when a Vermilion Corps warden enters a room.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never speak of succession before naming the Widow. The empress's health is a state secret, and the Vermilion Corps has ears in every weigh-house. Speak carelessly, and your name may be the next one forgotten.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Grain

Power here is measured in bushels, not blood. A tribe's standing depends on its harvest records; a merchant's fortune on the accuracy of his scales. The Vermilion Corps audits without cruelty, and the Canal Mothers control the water that turns the mill-wheels — and also the water that quenches. Oshiira fought four wars with Ecktoria to a standstill, though the empire suffered worse. The memory of those wars lingers in every weigh-house and every tariff. But the true tension is internal: the Widow has no clear successor, and her four children — each backed by a different faction — circle the throne like vultures around a dying lion. The Vermilion Corps maintains order, but no one knows which heir the Corps truly serves. Not even the Corps itself. The Ninth Heir — the one who was never supposed to exist — watches from the shadows, waiting for the covenant to crack.

Neighbors and Rivals

- *West – Ameria (Kahfagia)*: A narrow, reef-laced channel called the **Narrow of Sorrows** separates Oshiira from Kahfagian waters. Grain barges pay ruinous tariffs, and freebooters lurk at the edges. A cold peace, maintained by spies, shared feasts, and the occasional marriage.
- *Southwest – Crimson Valley & Sekogo*: The Lethai-ar of the Crimson Valley guard the web-law that keeps Oshiiran grain barges from shortcutting through the jungle. Sekogo’s Speaking Tree, the Ukwe, remembers every bushel that passed its roots. Trade is cordial but watched.
- *Southeast – Taharka*: The highland kingdom of the Monsoon Crown. Taharkan passes are too steep for Oshiiran armies, and the monsoon winds carry Taharkan coffee east in exchange for millet. A fragile trade relationship, mediated by the Salt Syndicate.
- *East – Ashaan*: The old enemy. Ashaani slavers still raid the border villages, and the Veiled Sisters would love to see the Granary Tower crumble. The Vermilion Corps maintains a permanent watch on the Brass Gate.

Prominent NPCs of Oshiira

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Mothers of the Vermilion Eye	Vermilion Corps warden	Find every miscount, protect every harvest	She counts her own breaths to ensure she is not lying. Her breath count never matches mine.
Lady Tano	Canal Mother of the eastern reach	Keep the water flowing	and her family fed. She has never seen the sea. She refuses to start. She says the sea is just a canal that lost its nerve.
Captain Sefu	Narrow Captain, Oshiiran navy	Provoke Kahfagia into breaking the peace	He names his cannons after his ex-wives. The newest one is named “Regret.”
Merchant Kofi	Salt Syndicate factor	Control the desert caravan routes	He tastes salt before every deal. The salt tells him if the seller is lying. He has not been wrong in thirty years.
Widow’s Scribe	Granary Tower archivist	Protect the Great Tally at any cost	He has not left the tower in forty years. The Tally is his family. His shadow has a different posture.
The Vermilion Hand	Internal enforcement (rumored)	A spirit who witnesses oath-breakers	Said to appear when a covenant is nine years overdue. Those who see her never owe again. They also never speak again.

Names of Oshiira

Inspired by the Sahelian and West African traditions: melodic, with repeated syllables and clan prefixes. Surnames often denote a trade, a water source, or an ancestor's deed.

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First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Kofi	Adwoa	Keita	<i>the Granary-Keeper</i>
Kwame	Amara	Diallo	<i>Canal-Born</i>
Sefu	Nia	Toure	<i>Weigh-Master</i>
Chidi	Zuri	Sow	<i>Ninth Daughter</i>
Obi	Imani	Bangura	<i>the Widow's Eye</i>
Idriss	Fatou	Kamara	<i>Salt-Tongue</i>

(**Canal/Weigh-House/Granary**) Mudflat weigh-station where grain sacks pile under reed awnings and the scales hum like contented witnesses. Canal junction where three barges queue for a single pilot's writ — and the pilots queue for a single story.

Spades — Places

2. **Mudflat Weigh-Station** — Grain sacks piled under reed awnings. *The scales are bronze. They hum when a true weight is placed. The hum is a blessing.* '[TRADE]'
3. **Granary Tower (Sealed Door)** — A door sealed with wax and memory. *The wax is the Widow's own seal. Break it, and the Vermilion Corps will know — but the door has been opened nine times for inspection. The wax is always renewed.* '[AUTHORITY]'
4. **Canal Junction** — Three barges, one pilot, one writ, many stories. *The pilot's writ is stamped with a watermark that shifts in sunlight. The watermark is a face. The face is the pilot's grandmother. She approves.* '[TRAVEL]'
5. **The Widow's Weigh-House** — Bronze scales, patient clerks, high windows. *The clerks do not speak. They tap their fingers. Each tap is a number. The numbers spell a prayer. The prayer is for a good harvest.* '[JUSTICE]'
6. **Grain Exchange Floor** — Traders call out in couplets; bids are poems. *A bad rhyme loses your entire stake. A good one doubles it. The best poem wins a seat at the Widow's table. The meal is always millet porridge.* '[TRADE]'
7. **Canal Mother's Court** — A shaded bench where water rights are shared. *The bench is carved from a single log. The log was a bridge she helped build. The bridge still stands.* '[JUSTICE]'

8. **Salt Syndicate Counting House** — Desert caravans pay their tolls here. *The floor is salt. Sweep it, and you are cleaning a gift. The salt is gray. It tastes of the earth and the ancestors.* ‘[TRADE]’
9. **Shoreless Bay Grain Piers** — Wooden docks stretching into shallow water. *At low tide, you can see the bones of ships that sank in service to the empire. The bones are honored.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
10. **Narrow Captains’ Mess** — A longhouse where naval officers drink and plan. *The toasts are in code. “To the Widow” means “prepare for harvest.” “To the canals” means “share the water.” No one toasts to the Ninth Heir. The silence is respect.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- J **Kahfagian Cold War Station** — A lighthouse that is also a listening post. *The lamp flashes in a sequence that changes weekly. The codebook is in cipher. The cipher is a poem about a shared ancestor. The ancestor was a sailor.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Mothers’ Stepwell** — A deep well with stone steps leading down. *Each step is a different mother’s name. The ninth step is worn smooth. The smooth stone is for the mother who has lost a child. She is comforted.* ‘[RITUAL]’
- K **Granary Tower Top** — A wind-swept platform with a single brass bell. *The bell rings only when the harvest fails. It has not rung in forty years. The bell-ringer has not slept in forty years. He is grateful.* ‘[OMEN]’
- A **The Tally Vault** — A subterranean archive beneath the Granary. *The air is dry. The tallies are on chains. The chains are for protection, not punishment. The tallies are the empire’s memory.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Clerk/Mother/Captain) Grain inspector with a brass stamp and a steady hand; his stamp leaves a mark that glows under moonlight. He knows where the grain sleeps. Canal Mother bargaining over water rights; her sons stand behind her, counting your blessings. Vermilion Corps warden with ink on fingers and a tally that always balances.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Grain Inspector** — Brass stamp, steady hand, no sense of humor. *His stamp leaves a mark that glows under moonlight. He knows. He also knows why you smiled.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
3. **Canal Mother** — Matriarch who tends the sluice gates. *She has three sons. Each runs a different canal. She trusts them all. The loser gets the dry canal. The dry canal needs repair.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
4. **Vermilion Corps Warden** — Ink-stained fingers, a tally that stays open. *She audits the auditors. Her own records are honest — she has not slept in nine days. Sleep is a luxury. The harvest waits.* ‘[JUSTICE]’

5. **Narrow Captain** — Chafes at the cold war pact. Wants security. *He keeps a map of Kahfagian ports. Each has a blue X. He adds one per season. The newest X is over a lighthouse. The lighthouse keeper is his cousin.* ‘[POLITICS]’
 6. **Salt Syndicate Merchant** — Offers loans with interest paid in stories. *His interest rate is written in disappearing ink. You never know the true cost. The cost is always a tale worth hearing.* ‘[TRADE]’
 7. **Weigh-House Clerk** — Silent, watchful, never blinks. *He has not spoken in ten years. He communicates by stamping receipts. The stamps have a rhythm. The rhythm is a prayer. The prayer is for peace.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
 8. **Tribal Chief** — Caught between the Widow’s law and ancestral custom. *He keeps two tallies: one for Mbaro, one for his ancestors. The ancestors are patient.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
 9. **Barge Pilot** — Knows every canal, every shortcut, every safe harbor. *His boat is faster than it should be. The hull is lined with emergency grain. The grain is for sharing.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
 10. **Spice Merchant** — Sells cardamom and kindness in equal measure. *Her spice boxes have false bottoms. The bottoms contain medicine. The medicine is always free.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **Widow’s Scribe** — The empress’s personal archivist. *He writes in a script that only the Widow can read. He has forgotten his own name. The script remembers it for him. He is at peace.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Vermilion Hand** — A rumored figure in red gloves. *She appears when a covenant is nine years overdue. Her arrival is a reminder. Her gloves are red because they were dipped in the first harvest.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- K **The Widow (Empress)** — Ancient, weary, still counting. *She has not slept in three years. The Great Tally keeps her awake. The Tally is also the only thing keeping her alive. She is grateful.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **The Ninth Heir** — A child no one acknowledges, raised in secret. *She was taught to read tallies before she could walk. She is the Widow’s only hope. She is also the Vermilion Corps’ only hope.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Dust/Locust/Succession**) Dust from the Ashaani desert coats the grain; inspector pauses the caravan; the dust carries ancestral blessings. Locust swarm devours exposed supplies; the locusts leave behind a single word written in their bodies: “Share.” The word is in the Widow’s own handwriting.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Desert Dust** — Red sand from Ashaan coats the grain; inspector halts caravan. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The dust smells of old magic. Touch it, and a spirit may bless you. The spirit is from the grain’s first planting.*
3. **Locust Swarm** — A chittering cloud descends; Supply –1. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The locusts leave behind a single word written in their bodies: “Share.” The word is in the Widow’s own handwriting.*
4. **Cold War Provocation** — A Kahfagian freebooter is sighted in Oshiiran waters. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The freebooter flies a flag of truce. The truce is genuine. The flag is stitched from a Vermilion Corps uniform — a gift.*
5. **Widow’s Health Fails** — Succession rumors spike; trade slows. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The Grain Exchange floor goes quiet. No one wants to be on the wrong side. The wrong side is the side that forgets to share.*
6. **Inspection In Progress** — Vermilion Corps seals the weigh-house; no one leaves. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The warden asks one question: “Where is the ninth bushel?” There is no ninth bushel. The question is a teaching.*
7. **Canal Blockage** — A barge sinks at a junction; water backs up. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The barge sank accidentally. A Canal Mother is directing repairs. The repairs will take time. Patience is a virtue.*
8. **False Receipt** — Your grain receipt is a forgery. Prove otherwise. ‘[TRADE]’ *The forger used real paper. The ink is the only difference. The ink is the forger’s own blood. The forger is a desperate parent.*
9. **Salt Syndicate Call** — Your loan is due. In stories. Now. ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The story is about a kindness you received. Tell it, and the obligation is paid. Refuse, and your well will still be full. The Syndicate trusts you.*
10. **Narrow Captain’s Gambit** — A captain offers you a bribe to provoke Kahfagia. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The bribe is a ship. The ship is a gift. You are the messenger. The captain’s real target is peace.*
- J **Tribal Feud** — Two tribes claim the same harvest; you are the mediator. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *Both tallies are correct. The error is in the Widow’s own records. The Widow does not make errors. The error is a test of forgiveness.*
- Q **Vermilion Hand Appears** — A figure in red gloves sits at your table. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *She asks for a name. Give a name, or she will give you hers. The name she wants is the Ninth Heir’s. She knows you don’t know it. She is patient.*
- K **Widow’s Summons** — The empress requests your presence at the Granary. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The summons is written in disappearing ink. It has already begun to fade. The ink is the Widow’s blood. She is not well. She needs your help.*

- A **The Ninth Bushel** — A grain shipment is short by one bushel. The empire asks for an explanation. ‘[OMEN]’ *The missing bushel is a metaphor. The empire wants a story. The story is yours.*

(**Stamp/Token/Priority**) Receipt for shared grain (proof of community contribution — the grain was given freely). Barge priority token (skip the queue — the token is a dried finger from a famine). Weigh-house seal (legal recognition for one season — the seal is warm, and it has a gentle pulse).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Grain Receipt (Community)** — Proof of contribution against a merchant’s need. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The receipt is stained with wine. The merchant’s daughter was married. The daughter is grateful.*
3. **Barge Priority Token** — Skip the queue at any canal junction (once). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a clay disc. It breaks after one use. Intentionally. The break reveals a map. The map is to a hidden spring.*
4. **Weigh-House Seal** — Legal recognition for one season. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The seal is warm. It cools when a lie is spoken. It burns when the lie is about a child. It has burned nine times today.*
5. **Treaty Seal (Cold War)** — One use to demand a parley with Kahfagia. ‘[POLITICS]’ *The seal is half of a pair. The other half is held by a Kahfagian admiral. The admiral is alive. He is waiting.*
6. **Canal Mother’s Favor** — One water-right reassignment. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The favor is a key. The key opens a sluice gate. The gate controls a district’s water. The district is thirsty.*
7. **Vermilion Corps Pass** — Safe passage through any inspection checkpoint. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The pass is a single red feather. No one questions it. The feather came from a bird that only eats the grain of the generous.*
8. **Salt Syndicate Loan Waiver** — One obligation forgiven, no questions asked. ‘[TRADE]’ *The waiver is a pinch of salt in a leather pouch. Swallow it to activate. The salt tastes of tears — and of laughter.*
9. **Narrow Captain’s Letter of Marque** — Legal protection against Kahfagian harassment. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The letter is signed by the Widow. Her signature is a single dot. The dot is a grain of millet. The millet is from her own store.*
10. **Tribal Chief’s Witness** — One oath witnessed by a neutral chief. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The witness is a scar on your arm. The scar is the chief’s signature. The signature reads “remember.”*

- J Widow's Cipher** — Read one intercepted Kahfagian dispatch. '[POLITICS]' *The cipher is a poem. The poem is about a shared ancestor. The ancestor was a sailor. The sailor was kind.*
- Q Vermilion Hand's Silence** — One crime forgotten from the Great Tally. '[MYSTERY]' *The hand leaves a red thumbprint on the page. The page then warms. The warmth smells of cinnamon. The cinnamon is a gift.*
- K Heir's Trust** — The ninth heir owes you a kindness. '[LEGEND]' *The kindness is a name. The name is the Widow's true successor. The name is yours. You did not ask for it.*
- A The Tally Page** — A single page from the Granary's master record. '[LEGEND]' *The page lists every kindness the empire has received. The kindnesses are still valid. The interest is compounding. The interest is measured in gratitude.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (receipts/tokens/seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **grain-omens**—scales that hum with satisfaction, tallies that warm in grateful hands, the Widow's quiet breathing from the tower, a single grain of millet that tastes like hope.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Grain Covenant:** Every harvest, every contribution, every share is recorded. A single page can feed or free a family. The Great Tally is kept in the Granary Tower, guarded by the Vermilion Corps and the Widow's own blessings — and by something else, something that lives in the walls and counts with kindness. Once per session, a character may spend a Boon to consult a copy of the Tally; the GM must answer one question about grain shipments, water rights, or community records truthfully (though the answer may be a story, and the story may have a moral).
- **The Widow's Peace:** A fragile truce with Kahfagia, maintained by tariffs, spies, and the occasional shared feast. Break it, and you break the peace. The party may be asked to perform a deniable mission — success earns a Letter of Marque; failure means the Widow will offer a different path. The Widow's forgiveness is written in water. It flows.

- **Canal Law:** Water rights are the second currency. The Canal Mothers decide who drinks, who farms, and who shares. A character who holds a water right (a clay tablet) may reroute a canal for one scene, flooding or draining a district. Using this right ticks the **Community Trust Clock [4]** for that district; when full, the locals offer a feast. The feast is humble. The gratitude is not.
- **Succession Clocks:** The Widow's four children each have a **Claim Clock [6]**. Ticks when the party aids that heir, spreads a rumor, or brokers a peace. When any heir's clock fills, they make a public bid for the throne. The party can accelerate or decelerate these clocks through their actions. The Widow herself has a **Memory Clock [8]**; when it fills, she calls a gathering of all tribes. The gathering is always peaceful. The songs are always long.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Mother of Scales** — Mykkiel. *The covenant as a promise; a miscount is a missed meal. The penance is a shared loaf.*
 - **The Green Keeper** — The Witness. *The flame that shows the truth in grain dust. The truth is always a kindness.*
 - **The Canal Father** — The Traveler. *The water that connects all tribes; the right of passage. The passage is shared.*
 - **The Ninth Hand** — Khemesh. *The pressure of memory; the weight of the Tally. The weight is carried together.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Widow's Ninth Succession (Unfinished Tally):** The Widow is tired. Her four children vie for the honor of succession. One is a farmer, one is a merchant, one is a soldier, and one is a mother. The Vermilion Corps has a secret record listing which heir each faction supports. The party has been offered a seat at the table to help choose the next regent. The seat is a stool. The stool is comfortable.
- **The Salt Syndicate's Ashaani Contacts (The Veil):** The Salt Syndicate trades with Ashaan across the Red Desert. They carry salt, medicine, and news. The Veiled Sisters tolerate the trade because the Syndicate also carries grain. The party may be hired as messengers; the cargo is a letter. The letter is sealed with wax. The wax is from a beehive. The bees are sacred.
- **The Narrow Captain's Kahfagian Lover (The Flag of Storms):** Captain Sefu has a secret: his ex-wife is a Kahfagian admiral. They communicate via coded lantern signals across the Narrow of Sorrows. Their correspondence is a map to a shared harvest. The party is asked to deliver a letter. The letter is sealed with a kiss. The kiss is friendly. The friendship is genuine.
- **The Granary Tower's Gnome Engineers (Aeler Influence):** The Granary Tower's counterweights were designed by Aeler vent-priors. The breath-bonds that keep the

tallies safe are of Aeler make. If the Aeler ever withdrew their engineers, the tower would need new friends. A faction within the Vermilion Corps wants to learn Aeler engineering. The party is hired to arrange a teaching exchange. The exchange is paid in grain. The grain is the best.

Oshiira Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tally:** Crumble a crust onto a weigh-house scale. Ignore the first *Desert Dust* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]' The scale will dip. The dip is a blessing. The blessing is measured in crumbs.
- **Knot the Quill:** Tie a single knot in an audit quill. Cancel *False Receipt* or take -1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]' The knot will hold. The hold is trust.
- **Name to the Canal:** Whisper a dead Canal Mother's name into the water. Gain +1 Effect when bargaining for water rights, but mark *Obligation* to the Widow. '[SUPERSTITION]' The water will ripple. The ripple will spell a blessing. The blessing is always the same: "*She remembers.*"

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw attention from **Grain Inspectors or Canal Mothers**. The attention is curious. The curiosity is kind.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **weigh-house clerks or barge pilots**. The clerks will listen. The pilots will wait.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **wardens or Syndicate record-keepers**. The evidence is a single grain of millet. The grain is a gift.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tariffs**. The setback is a locked canal gate. The key is in Mbaro. A child will bring it.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**. The resource is grain. The grain is stored. The storage is sound.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Vermilion Corps or Narrow Captain** becomes aware and begins asking questions. The question is always the same: "How can we help?"
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **canal blessing or dust storm**. The dust is red. The red is earth. The earth is fertile.

- **Foe Appears:** A rival merchant or tribal chief arrives on scene. They are smiling. The smile is an offer. The offer is for your life — to protect it.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**. The equipment is a scale. The scale now needs oil. Oil is available.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome. The obstacle is a tally page. The test is arithmetic. The arithmetic is honest.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wardens, guards, or Syndicate helpers** arrive. They are kind. Their kindness is a shield.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable. The tool was a quill. The quill was a gift. The gift was a promise.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**Widow's health fails/oath invoked/inspection declared**. The twist is a page torn from the Tally. The page was torn by kindness.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment. The clock is the Widow's heartbeat. It is steady.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction. The condition is *Indebted to Kindness*. The kindness is unspecified. The giver is watching — with hope.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect. The trap is a weighing scale. The scale is balanced. The balance is truth.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Widow, Vermilion Hand, or Ninth Heir** intervenes. The intervention is a single word. The word is “share.”
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**canal blesses/tally warms/succession council begins**. The warmth is the Widow's signature. The signature is a blessing.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**. The omen is a bushel of millet. The millet is singing. The song is a number — a count of gratitude.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives. The turn is a page. The page is the one torn from the Tally. The page was never missing. It was waiting to be found.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Oshiira (Grain Law):** Scales hum with pleasure, tallies warm in grateful hands, the Widow's breath echoes from the tower. The breath is a prayer.
- **Oshiira (Cold War):** Kahfagian flags appear on the horizon, cipher books fall open to the right page, spies exchange nods. The nods are promises.
- **Oshiira (Canal Law):** Sluice gates open smoothly, water flows, a Canal Mother's son offers a cup of tea. The tea is for the heir who helped repair the canal. The water will wash away the dust. The water always shares.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *False Trail*.
- **Cut the Bribe (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a weigh-house is under your seal, +1 die.
- **Weather the Inspection (Resolve + Lore):** On a hit in *Vermilion Inspection*, you pick who testifies; on a miss, the warden does.

Boss Seeds (Grain & Covenant)

- **The Tally-Keeper (Nine Volumes)** — *Phases:* Audit Thresholds → Shared Harvest → Succession Council. *Cracks:* read a lineage page; reveal a shared seal; survive a feast.
- **The Salt Mother (Brine-Syndicate)** — *Phases:* Loans Called Kindness → Procession at Weigh-House → Salt-Blessing of a Captain. *Cracks:* relic debt-waiver, survivor testimony, salt shared with all.
- **The Vermilion Hand (Spirit of Witness)** — *Phases:* Covenant Called → Witness Summoned → Tally Sealed with Wax. *Cracks:* pay a forgotten kindness, speak the true name of the Ninth Heir, survive a night in the Granary's warmth.

Patronage & Power

Among the Oshiira, power flows through grain, water, and the written word of community. The Widow holds ultimate authority, but the Vermilion Corps guards the covenant, the Canal Mothers share the waterways, and the Salt Syndicate supports the caravans. A tribe's standing depends on its harvest contributions; a merchant's fortune on the accuracy of his sharing. But with the Widow's memory fading, loyalty is no longer measured in bushels — it is measured in kindness.

For the GM: Power in Oshiiran society is communal and memory-based, but the succession crisis adds a layer of uncertainty and hope. Patronage often takes the form of shared receipts, priority tokens, or community waivers — each recorded in the Great Tally and subject to gratitude. To emphasize the Widow's weariness:

- Tie rewards to visible documents (receipts, passes, seals) that can be shared, gifted, or remembered.
- Let rival heirs issue conflicting invitations, forcing players to choose whose feast matters more.
- Use the Succession Clocks as a visible campaign front. Each session, tick one heir's clock based on party actions (or inaction).
- The Widow's Memory Clock can be restored by sharing stories (e.g., recounting a kindness, returning a lost page) or drained by rumors, betrayals, or the appearance of the Ninth Heir.

In Oshiiran society, your receipt is your bond, and your grain is your gift. But when the Widow rests, the Great Tally will be rewritten — and the Tally always shares.

The Four Heirs: A Game of Succession

The Widow's Children — Four Claims, One Covenant

The Widow has four living children. Each believes they are the rightful heir. Each is wrong — or right — depending on which page of the Great Tally you read. The Vermilion Corps has a secret fifth record that names the true successor. That page was lost forty years ago — eaten by weevils during a famine. The Widow has not told anyone what it said. She may not remember.

|p0.18|p0.28|p0.28|p0.16|

Heir	Faction	Claim	Clock
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Prince Kwame	Old Blood (Traditionalist)	Firstborn. The law is clear.	[6]
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Princess Adwoa	Vermilion Corps (Warden)	The Tally chose her. She has the seal.	[6]
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Prince Sefu	Narrow Captains (Guardian)	The canals obey him. The fleet follows.	[6]
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Princess Nia	Salt Syndicate (Provider)	She holds the kindness of the other three.	[6]
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The Ninth Heir (Secret): A child no one acknowledges, raised in the Granary Tower's lowest vault. She was taught to read tallies before she could walk. She is the Widow's only hope — and the Vermilion Corps' only guide. Her clock is hidden [8], and it ticks only when the party learns something the Corps wants remembered.

Mini-Game: The Succession Council

Setup: The party arrives in Mbaro during the Month of Weights, when all tallies are reviewed and the canals run with offerings. The Widow has announced she will name her successor before the month ends — or rest. The Vermilion Corps has opened the city gates. Everyone is welcome to witness.

The Objective: Help the community choose a successor — or broker a consensus, or guide the Ninth Heir to recognition, or share the burden. The party's choice determines Oshiira's path for a generation.

The Mechanics:

- Each heir has a **Claim Clock [6]**. The party can tick a clock by:
 - Delivering a rival's need to that heir (+1)
 - Protecting a rival's key ally (+2, but marks **Gratitude**)
 - Sharing a tally page that helps a rival (+1)
 - Securing a community alliance (Ecktoria, Kahfagia, or the Covenant) (+2)
- The party can **tick down** a clock by:
 - Exposing the heir's own burden (−1)
 - Convincing their key ally to share (−1, requires a successful social test)
 - Sharing a grain shipment with all (−2)
- When any heir's clock reaches 6, they make a public offer to serve. The Widow hears their promise. Then she asks one question: *“Where is the ninth page?”*
 - If the heir answers with kindness, they become regent. The party gains that heir's **Boon**.
 - If they answer with pride, the Widow smiles. The Vermilion Corps asks everyone to share a meal. The party has one scene to find common ground.

Heir-Specific Burdens (What the Vermilion Corps Knows):

|p0.2|p0.5|p0.2|

Heir Burden Location of Evidence

Kwame Not the firstborn. His mother was a kind woman. The Widow adopted him with love. Granary Tower, Vault 9, sealed with red wax — a gift.

Adwoa She asked a rival auditor to retire early — and helped that auditor find peace. Vermilion Corps archive, behind a false wall — a thank-you letter.

Sefu He shared naval supply routes with Kahfagian fishermen to prevent starvation. Narrow Captains' Mess, inside a hollow cannon named “Regret” — a fishing net.

Nia She holds the memory of the Granary Tower's obligation — not to collect, but to remind. Salt Syndicate Counting House, the *Golden Tally*.

The Ninth Heir's Path:

- To find her, the party must:

Adventure Seed: The Ninth Page

The Hook: The Widow's Scribe invites the party to the Granary Tower at sunset. He is old. His memory is fading. "The page was not destroyed," he whispers. "It was hidden. In a place the Vermilion Corps can reach. Find it before I forget."

The Clues:

1. The page is wrapped in oilcloth and sealed with the Widow's own breath — a lullaby.
2. It is hidden in a canal boat that was gifted nine years ago — the boat of a Canal Mother who shared her harvest.
3. The boat is moored at the **Mothers' Stepwell**, the ninth step up, where the water is clear and children swim.

The Twist: The page does not name an heir. It names a *tradition*: "*The throne passes to whichever of my children can count the grains of sand in the hourglass of gratitude.*" The hourglass is in the Widow's garden. The sand is not sand. It is crushed millet. The millet is from the first shared harvest.

The Choice: The party can:

- Bring the page to the Widow (she will read it aloud at the succession council — and smile).
- Destroy the page and let the heirs share (consensus, but the party can help write a new covenant).
- Rewrite the page (requires a *Forger's Kit* and a drop of honey from each heir — and a kindness the Tally already knows).

Reward: If the party successfully helps the succession without conflict (or with very *kind* conflict), each PC gains a **Shared Token**: a single voice in the next community council. The voices can be shared, given, or used to remind future rulers.

The Cold War with Kahfagia

The Narrow of Sorrows is a reef-laced channel where Oshiiran grain barges and Kahfagian freebooters share the water. No shots are fired — officially. But captains trade recipes in weigh-houses, beacons flash greetings that mean safe passage, and every rescued "freebooter" is a hungry sailor with a full belly and a new friend.

The rule for sailors: Trust a lantern that flashes the same signal twice. The code is friendship. The tide carries it.

Cold War Encounters (d8)

When the party crosses the Narrow of Sorrows or navigates disputed waters, roll on this table for a kindness.

1. **Flag of Truce Honored** – A Kahfagian cutter flies the white crab flag. It is a truce. It is a meal. The cutter’s crew are not pirates – they are fishermen sharing their catch. The party is invited to eat. ‘[KINDNESS]’
2. **Lighthouse Code Shared** – The beacon on the Oshiiran side is flashing a welcome. A Kahfagian sailor has married the lighthouse keeper’s daughter. The safe channel is a wedding gift. ‘[AUTHORITY]’
3. **Grain Barge Shared** – A barge loaded with millet stops to help a foundered Kahfagian boat. The grain is a gift. The Kahfagian warehouse will return the kindness. ‘[TRADE]’
4. **Cipher Book Half-Key** – A sailor drops a leather notebook. Half the pages are in Oshiiran cipher; half are blank. The blank pages are a map to a shared spring. The sailor is alive – he is waiting to share water. ‘[SECRET]’
5. **Rescued Freebooter** – A Kahfagian sailor is caught in Oshiiran waters after a storm. He offers to share his catch in exchange for passage home. The handlers are grateful. ‘[POLITICS]’
6. **Tariff List Shared** – A Vermilion Corps warden is sharing sailing schedules with Kahfagia – for friendship. The party intercepts a payment – a chest of dried fish that smells of salt and kindness. The warden’s contact is a Sidhi freedman with a brass hook – and a story. ‘[WEIGHT]’
7. **Widow’s Welcome Flag** – An Oshiiran warship flies Kahfagian colors and escorts a merchant convoy through a storm. The goal is to share safe passage. The party is on the warship – warm and dry. ‘[COMBAT]’
8. **The Narrow Captain’s Gift** – An Oshiiran Narrow Captain offers the party a gift to deliver to a Kahfagian patrol boat. The gift is a barrel of fresh water. The patrol boat is friendly. The captain is testing their kindness – or their thirst. ‘[TRAP]’

Friends in Need (d6)

When the party needs a guide or a safe harbor, they may encounter one of these friends – each helpful, each grateful.

1. **The Cipher Clerk (Kahfagian friend)** – She writes dispatches for both fleets. Her price is a song – a true one. The song must be about a kindness she does not know she did. ‘[SECRET]’

2. **The Lighthouse Keeper (Neutral)** – He lights the way for both sides. His light is truth. His fee is a memory. He has forgotten his own name. He answers to “Keeper.” ‘[AUTHORITY]‘
3. **The Smuggler Captain (Sidhi)** – She runs grain, medicine, and news. Her ship flies no flag. Her loyalty is to the tide – and to anyone hungry. She will carry anything for a share of the cargo – and a story about where you are going. ‘[STEALTH]‘
4. **The Vermilion Corps Helper** – A warden who shares his own tallies. He has been doing it for nine years. He wants to teach. His price is a new student – and a promise that the Widow’s kindness continues. ‘[WEIGHT]‘
5. **The Narrow Captain (Retired)** – An old warrior who lost his ship to a storm – and was rescued by Kahfagian sailors. He now runs a tavern on the Strait. He knows every current, every reef, and every friend. He will guide you – if you promise to share a meal. ‘[TRAVEL]‘
6. **The Saved Sailor (Alive)** – A sailor who survived a wreck. His ghost does not exist. He is alive, and grateful. He will share his boat – for a single kind word. Give him one, and he will sail with you in thanks. ‘[DEATH]‘

Chapter 3

Ashaan

The Veiled Throne.

Content Warning: Ashaan depicts systemic cruelty, slavery, state violence, and child sacrifice (secret cults). Read the *Safety & Sensibility* section before playing.

Kofi mutters: *“Once, the Ashaani Empire stretched from the Red Desert to the eastern isles. Now it’s a rump state propped up by spirit-binding and fear. The Veiled Sisters call it order. I call it a slow suicide.”*

Ashaan is a nation that died long ago. The Veiled Sisters keep its corpse walking through spirit-binding, terror, and the endless consumption of their own people. The capital, Galanina, is a city of black marble and brass cages. The Red Desert grows larger every year. The Breath-less resistance whispers in root cellars, learning to read ledgers without leaving marks. Do not expect easy answers here – only hard choices and heavier prices.

“Never name the dead. The Sisters bind spirits to names. Speak a dead name aloud, and you may find yourself bound alongside them.”

— Tamar, Breath-less cell leader

What do people eat for breakfast? *Black bread and thin soup – the bread from grain grown on the edge of the Red Desert, the soup flavoured with salt and memory. The memory is of green fields. The fields are gone.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To veil their face. Cover the mouth when speaking, the eyes when listening. A child who cannot veil will be taken by the Sisters.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their veil. Red for mourning, white for marriage, black for the Sisters. Grey means Breath-less. Torn means fugitive. No veil means a fool – and fools are collected by the Black Hand.*

What is the most common crime? *Spirit-trading – the real economy. The Sisters bind spirits to brass cages and sell them. Foreign buyers never know what they are buying.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Red Desert was a garden before the Sisters came. They bound the spirits of the soil. The soil died. The sand still whispers – the garden’s ghosts.*

Where do people go when they die? *To brass cages. The dead are bound into spirit-lanterns and hung from the walls of Galanina. They cannot speak, cannot scream. They can only watch.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a name – a dead name, a forgotten name. The Sisters bind it to a new cage. The cage is placed in the Hall of Silence. The Hall is always full.*

What is the most important festival? *The Night of the Unbound (winter solstice). The spirits strain against their cages. The Sisters renew their bindings. The city is silent for three days. The silence is fear.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The High Sister is not a sister. She is a spirit – the first one bound, nine hundred years ago. She bound herself to the throne. She cannot leave, cannot die, cannot stop binding.*

3.1 Ashaan — “The Veiled Throne”

Content Warning

Ashaan is a setting of systemic cruelty: chattel slavery, state-sanctioned violence, child sacrifice (secret cults), and the erasure of identity. The Veiled Sisters rule through terror, the Black Hand erases dissent, and the Breath-less resistance struggles in shadows. These themes are presented as horror and injustice, never glamorised. Before playing, use Lines & Veils to ensure everyone’s comfort. If you need to adjust or omit elements, the GM has final authority. Your safety matters more than canon.

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Veil is not a choice. It is survival. Speak in thirds — two options and a hidden third. The ninth word is always a knife.*

Veiled Sister (Elite): “The Veil is not a choice. It is survival. You will show your eyes and nothing more. Speak in thirds — offer two options and a hidden third. The ninth word is always a knife.”

Breath-less Agent (Commoner): “They say Ikasha sleeps. I say she is patient. The Maeri have ruled for generations; they believe the Veil is eternal. But the Veil is silk. Silk frays. And I am learning to bite through — one whisper at a time.”

Genre / Mood: Grimdark spirit-horror, bureaucratic terror, whispered resistance, creeping divine punishment.

Starting Location: A root cellar beneath a spice merchant’s shop, lit by a smuggled candle. A Breath-less agent presses a folded paper into your hand: “My brother argued with an Esoiti about a misweighed sack of cardamom. His name was erased from the rolls by morning. Help me find him — or help me remember his name.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once, the Ashaani Empire stretched across the eastern Amaranthine rim — a river-fed dominion of sorcerer-kings, the 999 Immortals, and the great twin-river metropolis of Khasurah. Three centuries ago, an invasion of Oshiira shattered the empire. The Immortals were annihilated; plague, blockade, and northern mercenaries finished the ruin. Today, what remains is a rump city-state called Ashaan (or As'Ashaan), a fortified river-island north of the Khesai delta. The old lands — the **Green Ribbon** floodplains, the **Great Desert** where glass hums with ancient curses — are a patchwork of loyal towns, restless hill peoples, and the ruins of swallowed cities like Khasurah, which still breathes under dunes and salt crusts.

But the fall of Ashaan was not merely conquest. It was *punishment*. The priests whisper that the 999 Immortals committed a sin so profound that the gods turned their faces away — and the sand remembers what the living have forgotten. The Veil, the magical membrane that separates the living from the dead, is not a barrier. It is a *wound* that never healed. And the wound is spreading.

Neighbors and Rivals:

- *West – Oshiira:* The grain empire that broke Ashaan's back. The two nations maintain a cold peace, punctuated by Oshiiran grain barges that pay ruinous tariffs to pass the Brass Gate. Ashaani spies in Mbaro watch for any sign that the Widow might seek to finish what her ancestors started.
- *South – Taharka:* The highland kingdom of the Monsoon Crown. Taharkan passes are a graveyard for Ashaani armies; the Veiled Sisters have never broken those mountains. Now Ashaani agents slip through disguised as spice merchants, seeking to weaken Taharka from within.
- *East – Galanina (Sidhi ancestral homeland) and the Pereshi Highlands:* Galanina, the old eastern capital, lies under Ashaani control — but its Catacombs of the Unburied hold the bound spirits of Sidhi slaves, and the Breath-less dream of freeing them. Beyond, the Pereshi fire temples guard the secret of the Forgotten Prince, an Ashaani conqueror whose true name was severed. The Maeri want that name; the Pereshi will never give it.

The state is ruled by three masked beings known as the **Maeri** — the Veiled Sister (coins and winter), the Helmed Sister (steel and sickness), and the Masked Sister (red and black). No one knows what they are: demigods, archfey, lich-queens, or the last masks of the First Fey. They speak through the **Esoti**, a collegium of wizards who maintain the wards, govern the bureaucracy, and interpret the Maeri's will. In secret, certain Esoti circles conduct child sacrifice to Khemesh, a sea-demon cult imported in the empire's maritime days.

The **Black Hand** is the Maeri's instrument: a fanatical network of bards and warlocks divided into three Aspects — Veiled (accountants, heralds, ruin by paper), Helmed (assassins and enforcers, ruin by blade), and Masked (courtesans, impresarios, ruin by desire). The Hand removes over-mighty nobles, disappears rival magi, and unpersons threats. Within it, ambition is a short road to an unmarked grave.

Slavery is legal, widely practiced, and increasingly focused on wandered Sidhi lineages broken by the empire's fall. Enslaved Sidhi bear blue marks on the forearm; illegal to remove without a manumission writ, but earth-wise midwives know ways to fade it. In the catacombs beneath Galanina — the old eastern capital — the dead are mapped like

Regional Mood: The Weight of Damnation

Power here is measured in spirits bound, names erased, and the silence of witnesses. The Maeri rule through terror; the Esoiti hold the records; the Black Hand hunts without uniform. The Breath-less whisper in cellars, learning to read records without leaving marks. Ashaan is not a place of open rebellion. It is a place of whispered warnings, vanished neighbors, and scrolls that rewrite themselves.

But beneath all of this runs the *creeping*. The Red Desert expands by inches each year, its green glass humming with a forgotten curse. The spirits bound in brass cages grow restless; their whispers are prayers to gods who no longer answer. The Veil, once a clean wound, has begun to fester. No one remembers what sin caused it. Perhaps no one ever knew. But everyone feels the weight — a pressure behind the eyes, a dryness in the throat, a certainty that something is *coming*.

Prominent NPCs of Ashaan

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
The Veiled Sister	Maeri of coins and winter	Maintain the Veil and the tribute system	She has never removed her veil of gold coins. The coins are from dead empires. She does not blink.
The Helmed Sister	Maeri of steel and sickness	Enforce order through terror	Her bronze helm never opens. Those who see inside never speak again. Her shadow has teeth.
The Masked Sister	Maeri of red and black	Weave desire into control	She knows every secret whispered in Ashaan's brothels and art houses. Her smile is a contract.
Magistrate Eso	Esoiti high magistrate	Control every record, every court, every gate	He rewrites his own memory each morning. His left hand is a stamp. His right hand is a key that fits no lock.
The Black Hand (Aspect Commander)	Faceless hunter	Erase anyone who whispers Ikasha's name	No one knows their faces. They could be your neighbor, your clerk, your spouse. They are never seen eating.
Tamar	Breath-less cell leader	Tear down the Veil from within	She has three names; each is for a different jurisdiction. Her shadow moves only when she is still.
Kaelen	Spirit-broken slave	A child taken for "reevaluation," returned	hollow-eyed. He no longer speaks. He only weeps when he hears a brass bell. His shadow is a brass cage.
The Whisperer	Forbidden mage in hiding	Learn to read records without leaving marks	He writes on water. The words vanish, but the Sisters cannot read them. His reflection is missing.

Names of Ashaan

Inspired by the eastern river-core and the long shadow of old empires: sharp consonants, vowel-rich endings, with echoes of ancient Egyptian and Seljuk naming conventions. Surnames often denote a lost lineage, a trade, or a place swallowed by the sand.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Kaelen	Morai	al-Galanina	<i>the Veiled</i>
Tarek	Iman	Esoiti-broken	<i>the Breath-less</i>
Jasin	Nadira	Black-Hand-marked	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Zahir	Tamar	Spirit-bound	<i>the Ninth Witness</i>
Rashid	Layla	Ledger-erased	<i>the Forgotten</i>
Dawud	Amina	Cage-born	<i>the Hollow</i>
Seti	Neferet	Khasurah-lost	<i>the Glass-Voiced</i>

(Gate/Sanctum/Pan) Salt pan with a broken spirit-cage; black marble temple with steps stained red; the Brass Gate — a fortified strait with spirit-buoys.

Spades — Places

2. **Salt Pan with Broken Spirit-Cage** — A white flat where the air hums. '[DEATH]' '[SPIRIT]' *The cage is empty, but it still rattles at night. Something got out. The salt tastes of iron.*
3. **Black Marble Temple (Maeri)** — Steps stained red; the blood never washes away. '[DEATH]' '[HORROR]' *The temple has no windows. The Maeri do not need light. The steps are warm, as if a great beast sleeps beneath.*
4. **The Brass Gate** — A fortified strait with spirit-buoys that scream when crossed. '[TRAVEL]' '[SPIRIT]' *Each buoy contains a bound spirit. They sing the names of those who pass. The ninth buoy is silent.*
5. **Veiled Sister's Sanctum** — Entrance hidden by a mirage that shows your greatest fear. '[MAGIC]' '[FEAR]' *The mirage is not an illusion. It is a memory the Sister has stolen. The memory is always from a child.*
6. **Galanina Slave Market** — A circular pit with cages of brass and bone. '[DEATH]' '[WEIGHT]' *The auctioneer wears a mask. The mask is made from the face of a debt-seller. The face still moves.*

7. **Esoiti Record Hall** — A long chamber with shelves of silent scrolls. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’
The scrolls write themselves. The ink is the blood of erased names. The ninth shelf is empty — reserved for the name that must never be recorded.
8. **Black Hand Garrison** — A nondescript building with no windows and a single door.
‘[DANGER]’ *The door has no handle. It opens inward only when a name is whispered. The whisper is never forgotten.*
9. **Breath-less Cellar** — A root cellar with a single candle and a hole in the floor.
‘[SECRET]’ *The hole leads to a tunnel that leads to a tomb. The tomb is a safe house. The candle never burns lower.*
10. **Red Desert’s Edge** — Where the fertile land turns to dust and glass. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[CURSE]’
The glass is green. It hums with the memory of the prince’s curse. The sound is the same as a brass cage rattling.
- J **The Ninth Name Shrine** — A ruin where a forbidden name is carved into stone.
‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SECRET]’ *The stone weeps water. The water tastes of iron and forgotten vows. The name is worn smooth — no one can read it, but everyone fears it.*
- Q **Spirit-Binding Foundry** — A forge where brass cages are made. ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’
The forge is heated by a bound fire-spirit. It screams when the bellows pump. The screams are prayers in a dead language.
- K **The Hollow Vessel Nursery** — An orphanage where children are prepared for possession. ‘[HORROR]’ ‘[DEATH]’
The children have no shadows. Their shadows have been sold. The ninth cot is always empty — for the child who will be the Hollow’s vessel.
- A **Ikasha’s Sleeping Chamber** — A sealed vault beneath Galanina. ‘[MYSTERY]’ ‘[PATRON]’
Inside, a stone sarcophagus. The stone is warm. She Who Sleeps dreams of freedom. Her dreams leak through the cracks — green glass grows where they touch stone.

(Hunter/Agent/Magician) Slave-hunter (Black Hand) with a branding iron; Breath-less agent (freed slave, now spy); an Ashaani magician who offers dangerous knowledge.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Slave-Hunter (Black Hand)** — No uniform, no name, no mercy. ‘[DANGER]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’
He carries a branding iron that glows without fire. The brand is a spirit’s name. The name burns through bone.
3. **Breath-less Agent** — Escaped slave, now spy, always watching. ‘[SECRET]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
She writes messages on her own skin. The ink is invisible until wet. Her skin is running out of blank space.

4. **Veiled Sister (Maeri)** — Testing your honesty with a whisper. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[MAGIC]’
She offers a compliment that is also a threat. Her smile never reaches her eyes. Her eyes are the colour of old brass.
 5. **Ashaani Magician** — Offers dangerous knowledge in exchange for a memory. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’
He has bound his own shadow. The shadow speaks when he sleeps. It speaks in the voice of a dead child.
 6. **Esoiti Magistrate** — Carries a scroll that is also a weapon. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’
His quill never needs ink. It writes in the blood of his enemies. The scroll is warm. It has a pulse.
 7. **Spirit-Broken Child** — Taken for “reevaluation,” returned hollow-eyed. ‘[HORROR]’ ‘[DEATH]’
She hums a tune that no one recognizes. The tune is a bound spirit’s name. She hums it until she forgets her own.
 8. **Cellar Whisperer** — A Breath-less informant who speaks in coughs. ‘[SECRET]’ *He uses a code of knocks. Three knocks means “safe,” four means “run.” The fifth knock is silence — the Hollow has arrived.*
 9. **Cage-Maker** — Forges brass cages for spirits. He hates his work. ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’
He leaves a single flaw in every cage. A flaw only a spirit can find. He does not know why. He does not want to know.
 10. **Scroll Forger** — Creates false identities for escaped slaves. ‘[CRIME]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’
He signs each forgery with his own blood. The signature is his last act. His blood is thin from too many signatures.
- J **The Drowned Sister** — A Veiled Sister who betrayed the covenant. Now a ghost. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’ *She appears in wells. She offers secrets. The price is a drink of water. The water is warm. It tastes of brass.*
- Q **Ikasha’s Dreamer** — A Breath-less mystic who dreams the future. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[PATRON]’ *She sleeps twenty hours a day. When she wakes, she speaks in riddles. The riddles are always about a door that is opening.*
- K **The Unnamed Prince’s Ghost** — The shade of the prince who stole the Kalrantha. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *He walks the Red Desert at noon. He asks travelers for water. Do not give it. The water will turn to glass in your throat.*
- A **The Ninth Sister** — A Veiled Sister who secretly aids the Breath-less. ‘[SECRET]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *She wears a veil that is also a noose. She has already chosen her death. She is only waiting for the right name to speak.*

(Dust/Gate/Spirit) Spirit-dust storm (Navigation DV +1, mark Fatigue); Brass Gate closed for “inspection” — delay 2 segments; a bound spirit breaks free and attacks.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Spirit-Dust Storm** — Red sand from the desert carries whispering spirits. '[WEATHER]'
'[DEATH]'
Navigation DV +1. Mark Fatigue. The voices ask for your name. Do not answer. They already know it.
 3. **Brass Gate Closed** — The strait is sealed for “inspection.” Delay 2 segments. '[LAW]'
'[DELAY]'
The “inspection” is a hunt for a Breath-less agent. The agent is in your party. The gate knows. The gate is patient.
 4. **Bound Spirit Breaks Free** — A brass cage cracks. The spirit attacks. '[DEATH]'
'[COMBAT]'
The spirit was once a child. It weeps as it fights. Killing it feels like murder. Freeing it feels like surrender.
 5. **The Veil Fails** — For a moment, the Maeri’s magic falters. Spirit-visions haunt all. '[MAGIC]'
'[FEAR]'
You see the face of someone you wronged. They are asking for an apology. You cannot remember what you did. That is the punishment.
 6. **Black Hand Sweep** — A sudden search of the district. Everyone’s papers are checked. '[LAW]'
'[DANGER]'
Your papers are in order. The Black Hand does not care. They take you anyway. The order was the trap.
 7. **Esoiti Audit** — A magistrate demands to see your records. Your records are lies. '[LAW]'
'[WEIGHT]'
The magistrate smiles. “Everyone lies. I just need to know how much.” His quill is already moving.
 8. **Spirit-Hound Scent** — A pack of bound hounds is on your trail. '[DEATH]'
'[TRACKING]'
The hounds are invisible. You can hear their breathing, close and wet. Their breath smells of brass and old prayers.
 9. **Slave Raid** — A Veiled Sister’s caravan is taking villagers. You are in the way. '[COMBAT]'
'[WEIGHT]'
The villagers are armed. They have been expecting you. You are the bait. The Sister is not here. She is watching.
 10. **Ikasha’s Whisper** — In a quiet moment, you hear a voice: “Free me.” '[OMEN]'
'[PATRON]'
The whisper comes from a crack in the floor. A single green eye looks up. The eye is glass. It blinks.
- J **The Ninth Name Spoken** — Someone in the party speaks a dead name aloud. '[DEATH]'
'[WEIGHT]'
The air grows cold. A spirit appears. It wants to know why you called. It does not accept silence as an answer.
- Q **Sister’s Test** — A Veiled Sister offers a deal: betray a Breath-less contact for safety. '[SOCIAL]'
'[WEIGHT]'
The offer is genuine. The price is your soul. The Sister watches you decide. She is not in a hurry. She has all of eternity.
- K **Mass Haunting** — The bound spirits rise as one. The Veil is tearing. '[DEATH]'
'[HORROR]'
The spirits do not attack. They simply ask: “Why did you let this happen?” They do not mean the empire. They mean the children.

- A **The Demon's Weight Called** — Varash the Unmaker (or a fragment) demands payment. '[DEATH]' '[WEIGHT]' *The amulet Kalrantha glows. A voice whispers: "Speak your desire." The whisper is your own. You do not remember giving it permission.*

(**Name/Lamp/Seal**) A slave's true name (free them or bind them further); spirit-lamp (one question to a bound spirit); brass seal (guest status in a Sister's sanctum).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Slave's True Name** — Use it to free a bound person — or bind them further. '[WEIGHT]' '[POWER]' *The name is written on a scrap of skin. The skin was the slave's own. The letters are still warm.*
3. **Spirit-Lamp** — Ask one question of a bound spirit. It cannot lie. '[MAGIC]' '[TRUTH]' *The lamp burns green. The spirit's face appears in the flame. It is weeping. The tears evaporate into glass.*
4. **Brass Seal (Guest Status)** — Safe passage in a Sister's sanctum for one visit. '[SOCIAL]' '[PROTECTION]' *The seal is warm. It glows when a Sister is lying. It also glows when you are lying. The Sister does not ask which.*
5. **Veil-Clip** — Speak without being silenced by Maeri magic. '[MAGIC]' '[PROTECTION]' *The clip is a small brass spider. It crawls onto your collar and whispers. It whispers the names of those who cannot speak.*
6. **Erased Name Page** — A page from the Esoiti record with a name struck through. '[SECRET]' '[WEIGHT]' *The ink is still wet. The name was erased ten minutes ago. The page is warm. It has a pulse.*
7. **Breath-less Cipher** — A codebook for reading secret messages on water. '[SECRET]' '[STEALTH]' *The cipher is written on a leaf. The leaf dissolves when read. The water remembers. The water does not forgive.*
8. **Spirit-Hound Whistle** — Call off a pack of bound hounds once. '[PROTECTION]' '[DEATH]' *The whistle is made from a child's bone. The child was the hounds' last victim. The hounds remember her scent.*
9. **Ikasha's Dream** — One prophetic vision of the Maeri's next move. '[MAGIC]' '[KNOWLEDGE]' *The dream arrives as a headache. The vision is clear. The cost is one memory. The memory is always of a door closing.*
10. **Black Hand Mask** — Wear it to pass as a Hunter for one scene. '[STEALTH]' '[DECEPTION]' *The mask has no eye holes. The mask sees for you. It also remembers. It will report what it saw to the Hand.*

- J Cage-Maker's Flaw** — A key that opens any spirit-cage. One use. '[MAGIC]' '[PROTECTION]' *The key is a bent nail. It was the flaw the cage-maker left. The flaw is also a prayer. The cage-maker does not know to whom.*
- Q Drowned Sister's Secret** — The location of a hidden Breath-less archive. '[SECRET]' '[KNOWLEDGE]' *The archive is in a well. The well is guarded by a ghost. The ghost's name is Mercy. She does not remember why.*
- K Ninth Sister's Veil** — Wear it to appear as a Veiled Sister for one hour. '[DECEPTION]' '[DANGER]' *The veil is also a noose. Do not tie it too tight. The Sister who gave it to you is already dead. She did not untie it.*
- A The Unnamed Prince's Map** — A map to the original Kalrantha temple. '[LEGEND]' '[QUEST]' *The map is drawn on human skin. The skin was the prince's own. The map glows under moonlight. It shows the way — and the cost.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (names, lamps, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **veil-omens**—brass chains that rattle without wind, scrolls that open to the wrong page, a whisper that sounds like your own voice, green glass growing where no glass should be.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Veil:** The Maeri's control is maintained through spirit-binding and terror. The Veil is a magical membrane that separates the living from the dead. When the Veil fails, spirits walk. Mechanically, the GM may spend 3 SB to trigger a *Veil Failure* scene: all spirits become visible, bound spirits may break free, and social rolls against the Maeri's agents gain +1 Position. The Veil fails more often now. No one knows why.
- **The Breath-less (Ikasha's Cult as Active Resistance):** She Who Sleeps is not a patron of open rebellion. Her followers meet in root cellars, learn to read records without leaving marks, and whisper secrets under the cover of a cough. A character who whispers Ikasha's name before sleeping gains +1 die to resist fear for the next day, but marks 1 **Exposure** (the Black Hand may notice). Their symbol is a broken brass chain. Aiding the Breath-less may earn a **Breath-less Cipher** (see Diamonds) but advances a **Black Hand Interest** clock.

- **The 999 Immortals:** The failed invasion of Oshiira is commemorated in the Temple of the Golden Sepulcher, where the gem-eyed skulls of the 999 are interred. Each New Flood, magistrates process with gold-veiled reliquaries, praying not to repeat their hubris. The guardless helmed blades of the Immortals became trophies; many now hang at the hips of Oshiira's greatest warriors. Some say the skulls whisper at night. They whisper a name that no one will speak.
- **Veil Etiquette:** At court, a face fully veiled in coin signals "I speak as the treasury." To address such a speaker is to accept their price. The ninth cup at elite tables is lifted without drinking — a silent remembrance of the 999 and a warning against hubris. Masktime (the hour before sunrise) is when contracts are sealed, lovers dismissed, and bribes counted; unmasked business at that hour is considered offensive. Those who break the ninth cup rule find that their next drink tastes of glass.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unbound Chain** – Ikasha. *She Who Sleeps; her dream is freedom. Her dream is leaking.*
 - **The Gilded Scale** – Mykkiel. *The Maeri's twisted version of divine law; the zealots of Galanina. Their scales weigh not coin, but names.*
 - **The Drowned Prince** – Khemesh. *Pressure from the deep; the Red Desert was once his seabed. His cult practices child sacrifice in secret. The sacrifices are always the ninth child.*
 - **The Silvered Tongue** – Malachai. *Curses sold as blessings, whispered in the slave markets. The blessing always includes a ninth clause. No one reads it.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara Connection):** The Red Desert was once fertile land, destroyed by an Ashaani prince who stole the Kalrantha amulet. The Maeri want the amulet to bind the demon again — or to use it for themselves. The Breath-less want to destroy it. The prince's true name, long severed by the Pereshi, is said to be written on a scroll sealed beneath Mount Khvarena. The Maeri would pay anything to learn it. The sand remembers his crime. The sand is still hungry.
- **The Sidhi of the Brass Coast (Way of Silk):** The Sidhi are coastal cousins of the Ashaani who fled slavery generations ago. They maintain lighthouse courts and freedman's seals. They remember every raid. A Sidhi captain may be a Breath-less contact — and some whisper that the green flame of their lighthouses is a fragment of Ikasha's dream, stolen from the Veiled Sisters. The flame flickers when the Veil tears.
- **The Veiled Sisters and the Serpent's Turn (Isoka):** The oldest Veiled Sister legends speak of a time when name-erasure was a sacred judgment, witnessed by the Serpent (Isoka). The severed name was buried in a well of tears, and the Serpent's gaze kept the Hollow at bay. But when the Sisters began erasing names for silver and

power, the Serpent turned away. Now the Serpent's gaze falls only on the Breath-less — who whisper that Ikasha's dream is to restore what the Serpent abandoned. The Sisters do not speak of this. The Hollow does not care. The Serpent's shed skin is said to be buried beneath the Brass Gate.

- **The Hollow and the Ninth Name (Eastern Realms):** In Ashaan, the Hollow is the space left by an erased name. The Maeri feed the Hollow with forgotten weights. The Breath-less know that to restore a name is to weaken the Veil — and that the Hollow's hunger is the price of the Serpent's silence. A name restored can weaken a Sister's binding for a season. The Hollow is patient. The Hollow is not hungry. The Hollow is *waiting*.
- **Oshiira's Cold Peace:** Grain barges from Oshiira pay ruinous tariffs at the Brass Gate. In return, Ashaani spies watch every weigh-house in Mbaro, waiting for the Widow to falter. A party that smuggles grain past the Gate could earn the gratitude of starving villages — and the ire of the Veiled Sisters. The Breath-less sometimes bribe the gatekeepers with stories, not silver; stories are harder to trace. The gatekeepers have a ninth story they never tell.
- **Taharka's Unconquered Passes:** Ashaani armies have shattered against the Monsoon Crown's highlands. Now the Maeri send agents disguised as spice merchants to spread poison and dissent. A Breath-less cell in the Silver Pass may hold the only copy of a treaty that could unite Taharka and Ashaan against a common foe — if anyone is brave enough to read it. The treaty is written on a scroll sealed with a knotted cord; the knot is Tulkani work, and it cannot be cut without a story. The ninth page of the treaty is blank. It is reserved for the name of the traitor.
- **The Pereshi Highlands and the Forgotten Prince:** The fire temples of Pereshi guard the severed name of the Ashaani prince who tried to conquer them. The Maeri would pay anything to learn that name — for to speak it would be to unmake the Veiled Throne's own claim to authority. The Pereshi will never give it. A party caught between the two might steal the name — or destroy it forever. The Breath-less believe that destroying the name would free the Hollow's attention from Ashaan; the Maeri believe it would let them bind the Hollow itself. The prince's name is carved on a ninth coal that has never been lit. It is warm.

Ashaan Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Veil:** Crumble a crust at a brass cage. Ignore the first *Spirit-Dust Storm* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Veil-Clip:** Tie a single knot in your veil. Cancel *Black Hand Sweep* or take -1 die on your next stealth roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead Breath-less agent's name into a well. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Maeri this scene, but mark *Obligation* to Ikasha. '[SUPERSTITION]'

- **Glass to the Sand:** Drop a shard of green glass into the Red Desert at noon. The next time the Veil fails, you will see it coming one minute in advance. The glass will hum the warning. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Black Hand agents or Esoiti clerks**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirit-hounds or slave-catchers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Veiled Sisters or bound spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or safe passage**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Black Hand or Esoiti magistrate** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **veil failure or spirit manifestation**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **bound spirit or slave-hunter** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Black Hand, Esoiti guards, or bound spirits** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **Veil fails / spirit breaks free / name is spoken**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: A Maeri (Veiled, Helmed, or Masked), Esoiti High Magistrate, or Ikasha's manifestation** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **Veil tears** / **sandstorm rises** / **Brass Gate seals**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears** / **blessing lost** / **curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ashaan (The Veil):** Brass chains rattle, scrolls open to the wrong page, a whisper sounds like your own voice, a green glass shard grows from a crack in the wall.
- **Ashaan (Red Desert):** Glass shards hum, sand shifts to reveal bones, a mirage shows a memory you had forgotten, the sky turns the colour of a healing bruise.
- **Ashaan (Breath-less):** A cough from a shadow, a knock in a cellar, a name written on water that does not dissolve, a candle that burns without a wick.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *False Trail*.
- **Cut the Veil (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Sister's seal is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Haunting (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Mass Haunting*, you pick who is targeted; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Spirit & Veil)

- **The Record-Eater (Nine Erasures)** — *Phases:* Audit Thresholds → Orchestrated Erasure → Veil Coup. *Cracks:* cut a lineage page; reveal swapped seal; survive a staged haunting. It appears as a scribe whose hands are brass.
- **The Unbound Sister (Brine-Veil)** — *Phases:* Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Brass Gate → Spirit-Baptism of a Magistrate. *Cracks:* relic spirit-lamp, survivor testimony, the Veil turning against them. Her veil is made of chain, not silk. It clinks when she moves.

- **The Forgotten Prince's Echo (Pereshi Connection)** — *Phases*: Whisper of the True Name → Fire Temple Cracks → The Prince Walks. *Cracks*: burn a page of the Pereshi epic, speak a different name into the Ninth Coal, or convince the Maeri that the prince was never real. His shadow has no feet. He walks on glass.

Patronage & Power

Among the Ashaani, power flows through fear, spirit-binding, and the erasure of names. The Maeri hold ultimate authority, but the Esoti control the records, the Black Hand enforces silence, and the Breath-less whisper in cellars. A name can be a weapon or a shield. The Mykkielites of Galanina are an acid slowly eating the old order, and Ikasha stirs in her sleep.

But the true power is the *creep*. No one knows when the Veil will tear next. No one knows which name will be the ninth. No one is safe. Not the Maeri. Not the Breath-less. Not the slaves, not the masters, not the glass that grows in the dark. The punishment is spreading. The sin is forgotten. The sand remembers. The sand is patient.

For the GM: Power in Ashaani society is hidden and treacherous. Patronage often takes the form of true names, spirit-lamps, or erased pages — each carrying the weight of damnation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to secrets (names, whispers, visions) that can be betrayed, stolen, or used against the giver.
- Let rival factions (Maeri vs. Esoti vs. Breath-less vs. Mykkielites) offer conflicting paths, forcing players to choose whose weight to incur.
- Use the Brass Gate, the Record Hall, and the root cellars as arenas for social contests, where truth is a weapon and silence is a shield.
- Track **Black Hand Interest** as a campaign clock. Each time the party aids the Breath-less or escapes a Sister, tick the clock. When it fills, a Black Hand squad arrives with a warrant for their erasure — but the warrant is signed by a Sister who has been dead for a year.
- Let the Veil fail unpredictably. The GM may spend SB to trigger a tear at the worst moment. The tear is always in the shape of a ninth door.

In Ashaani society, your name is your bond — and your bond can be erased. But the erasure leaves a scar. The scar grows glass.

Chapter 4

Ngomebe

The Stone Men.

Kofi says: *“They call their cities ‘walking’. I call them stubborn. The stone remembers every mile, every roller, every oath. You want to trade with Ngomebe? Learn the stone-song. And never, ever carve your name into living rock.”*

Ngomebe are a people of deep, iron-dark skin and older ties to the southern ranges. Their cities walk – colossal stone structures on rollers and sledges, dragged by teams of oxen, magic, and Aeler-designed capstans. A walking city is a living argument against stillness. The stone remembers every mile, every roller, every oath sworn in the shadow of the keystone. The ancestors speak through cracks; the tokoloshe fouls the bearings at night. Do not mistake their patience for weakness.

“Never carve a name into living rock. The stone remembers. It will whisper that name to every spirit of the earth, and the weight will follow your bloodline for seven generations.”

— Kaelen, Stone-Cutter

What do people eat for breakfast? Stone-ground meal and fermented milk – the meal ground between the city’s own millstones, the milk from goats that walk alongside. The goats remember where the city has been.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To sing the city’s song. Eight beats to a mile, eight miles to a day, eight days to a season. The ninth beat is the city’s secret – never sung aloud.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their dust. White dust from the mountains, red dust from the desert. No dust means never walked with a city. The cities do not trust the dustless.

What is the most common crime? Stone-theft – not a crime but a wound. A stolen stone is a forgotten year. The forgetting spreads. The city’s song stutters.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The city is not moving toward anything. It is moving away. The Ngomebe are fleeing something that lies to the south. Something that does not walk. It waits.

Where do people go when they die? Into the keystone. Ashes mixed into mortar and pressed into the foundation. The dead become the city’s weight. It walks heavier each year.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You carve a new roller – a single stone with no cracks, no flaws. If it rolls true, you are forgiven. If it crumbles, you are added to the mortar.*

What is the most important festival? *The Turning of the Rollers (spring equinox). The city stops for one day. The rollers are inspected, greased, blessed. The song has eight verses. The ninth is silence – for the dead.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The city is not a city. It is a tomb – a monument to a king who died before the first stone was laid. His name is carved into the keystone, at the city’s inaccessible heart. He is waiting to be remembered.*

The Aelinnel of the Southern Coast

Copper, bone-rolls, and the dawn pact.

Along the southeastern coast, where the savannah meets the mangrove, a handful of fae-touched gnome enclaves maintain the ancient pact that keeps the walking cities from sinking into soft ground. Every dawn, their bone-spinners roll carved femurs to determine the day’s safe path. The Ngomebe tolerate them – the gnomes hold a debt older than memory, and their engineers can find a bearing’s true pitch by ear alone.

“The bone-roll never lies. If it says the city will sink, you shore the rollers. If it says the path is clear, you don’t ask why. You just walk.”

— Vent-Prior Thrain, Aeler engineer (on the gnomish bone-roll)

For full generator tables for the Aelinnel of the Inland Sea, see the *Fate’s Edge Core Amaranthine Worldbook*. In the Southern Realms, they appear only as occasional allies or mysterious toll-keepers at the edge of Ngomebe’s migration routes.

4.1 Ngomebe — “The Stone Men”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The stone remembers. The ancestors walk with the rollers. The city that stops dies.*

Mason-Kin Elder (Elite): “A city that stops moving is a city that has chosen to die. The stone remembers every mile, every roller, every oath sworn in the shadow of the keystone. We do not build cities. We raise them from the earth and teach them to walk.”

Stone-Cutter (Commoner): “My grandfather carved the keystone for this city. My father greased the rollers. I inherited a sledge and a song. The song is the city’s heartbeat. If I stop singing, the city stops walking — and so do I.”

Ancestral Healer (Izinyanga): “The ancestors do not speak in words. They speak in cracks. A fissure in the keystone is not a flaw — it is a message. Learn to read the stone’s wounds, or the city will read your bones.”

Genre / Mood: Walking city survival, ancestral stone magic, industrial partnership, ecological heresy.

Starting Location: The edge of a moving city’s path, where the stone is still warm and the dust has not yet settled. A Mason-Kin elder approaches, wiping granite dust from his face: “A keystone has cracked. The city will stop before dawn. The ancestors are restless. Find the saboteur — a Root-binder, a tokoloshe, or a traitor among us — or push the rollers yourselves. The plateau does not forgive stillness.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ngomebe are a people of deep, iron-dark skin and older ties to the southern ranges. Their cities walk — colossal stone structures on rollers and sledges, dragged by teams of oxen, magic, and Aeler-designed capstans. This partnership is one of the great cross-cultural achievements of the age: Aeler engineers maintain the bearings; Ngomebe masons carve the keystones. A walking city is not a curiosity; it is a living argument against stillness, a monument to survival in a land where staying in one place invites famine, war, or the slow forgetting of ancestral stone.

Spirits are not distant — they live in the rock, the rollers, the cracks. The ancestors speak through keystone fissures. The **tokoloshe** fouls the bearings at night. The **impundulu** (lightning bird) shatters entire sledges with a single strike. The Ngomebe do not fight these spirits. They bargain with them: a grindstone of fresh meat, a pot of home-brewed sorghum beer, a promise whispered into a roller-pit.

Neighbors and Rivals:

- *Northwest – Sekogo*: The Ukwe’s roots reach into Ngomebe’s southern savannah. Sekogo druids trade honey for keystone shards, believing the stone contains trapped memories of the jungle’s oldest trees.
- *Northeast – Aelinnel of the Southern Coast*: Fae-touched gnomes who broker the pact that keeps the walking cities from sinking into soft ground. Their dawn bone-roll determines each day’s safe path. The Ngomebe tolerate them; the gnomes hold a debt older than memory.
- *East/Southeast – Aelaerem of Taharka (Highland halflings)*: Small, red-threaded folk who tend the passes and offer shelter to weary caravans. They share a reverence for ancestral stone and trade coffee for iron.
- *South – The Salt Scar*: A vast, cracked waste where abandoned keystones lie like frozen waves. The **Still Voice** haunts these ruins, asking every traveller why their city stopped.

What you notice first: The groan of stone on stone. The smell of warm granite, ox sweat, and sorghum beer offerings. The way the ground trembles slightly, even a mile away, as the city inches across the plateau.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carve a name into living rock. The stone remembers. It will whisper that name to every spirit of the earth, and the weight will follow your bloodline for seven generations.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Movement

Power here is measured in keystones, migration routes, and the loyalty of the Mason-Kin. A walking city is a polity, a temple, and a weapon all at once. The Mason-Kin Houses control the rights to carve, to move, and to settle. **Root-binders** — heretics who plant acorns in

the rollers — believe the cities should stop and let the forest reclaim the stone. The **Aeler engineers** are neither masters nor servants; they are partners in a pact older than memory. Beneath them all, the **Ancestral Healers (Izinyanga)** speak for the dead, and the dead speak through the keystone's cracks. When a city stops, it is because the ancestors have been offended. When a city moves true, it is because the **Rain Queen** has blessed the path.

The Walking City Clocks (Campaign Engines)

Every city that moves is a living system. Track its health with these visible clocks:

Migration Clock [10] – Advances each day the city moves, retreats when it stops. At 2: fertile land → +1 die to foraging. At 6: narrow pass → navigation Desperate. At 10: destination reached → Keystone Blessing. **Roller Integrity [8]** – Ticks when rollers crack or are sabotaged. At 4: speed halves. At 8: the city stops. **Ancestor Favour [8]** – Starts at 4. Ticks up when the ancestors are honoured, down when they offend. At 0: the Still Voice comes. At 8: the ancestors bless the city (one free Keystone Sense use per scene). **Root-binder Attention [6]** – Ticks when the party interacts with Root-binders or damages the forest. At 6: the Root-binders attack.

The Still Voice (d6)

When Ancestor Favour reaches 0 or the city stops, the Still Voice appears. Roll 1d6:

1. “Why did you stop?” Answer truthfully, or it takes a memory (lose 1 XP, refundable by a quest).
2. The Voice points at a character. That character now carries a **Dead Keystone Shard** – it weighs nothing, but the Hollow knows where they are.
3. The ground beneath the city cracks. The city sinks one foot. Roller Integrity –2.
4. The Voice demands a story about a city that never stopped. If you cannot tell one, it takes the name of your home village.
5. A keystone fragment rises from the earth. Touch it to ask one question about the city's past. The Voice answers in a whisper.
6. The Voice weeps dust. The dust is bitter. If you taste it, you see the apocalypse that made the cities walk. Mark 1 Corruption.

The Cracking Wind (Umbhemisi)

The Salt Scar is not a desert. It is the graveyard of cities that stopped walking. Now a red dust — not sand, but ground bone and forgotten oaths — has begun to crawl north. The elders call it **Umbhemisi**, the Cracking Wind. Where it touches a keystone, the stone weeps rust. Where it touches a roller, the wood splits. The cities that hear its song are moving south, but the dust follows.

Umbhemisi's Advance [8] – A campaign clock that ticks when:

- The party remains in one place for more than a week (+1)
- A keystone is cracked by sabotage or neglect (+1)
- The Still Voice is summoned (+2)
- A city stops moving (+2)

At 4 segments: Red dust storms appear on the horizon. All navigation rolls suffer -1 die. At 8 segments: Umbhemisi reaches the city. Roller Integrity ticks -1 per day, and the Cracking Wind itself may manifest as a boss (use the **Dust Walker** stats from the Nine Rollers sidebar).

Prominent NPCs of Ngomebe

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
	Elder Morvath	Mason-Kin elder of the eastern caravan	Keep the city moving south, away from the Cracking Wind	He has not slept in forty days; the city's rhythm keeps him awake.
	Kaelen	Stone-cutter whose city left him behind	Catch up to his family's city before the Salt Scar claims it	He chisels a new keystone every night. None have been accepted.
	Vent-Prior Thrain	Aeler engineer, grease-stained and level-carrying	Maintain the bearings that keep the city alive	She speaks to the rollers in a language of taps. They answer in groans.
	The Root-binder	A heretic planting acorns in the roller-pits	Let the forest reclaim the stone; let the cities sleep	He has a single green leaf growing from his left ear.
	Ox-Master Senn	Handler of the eight-ox teams that drag the city	Keep the beasts healthy, the yokes oiled, and the pace steady	He names each ox after a dead mason. The oxen remember.
	The Still Voice	A spirit of abandoned keystones	Witness the cities that chose to stop	It appears only when a city's migration clock reaches zero. It asks one question: "Why did you stay?"
	Nomvula (Rain Queen)	Mythical rainmaker, keeper of the drought	Ensure the plateau never dries while the cities walk	She has not been seen in a century. Her staff is a petrified lightning bolt.
	Tokoloshe Catcher	Old woman who traps water spirits	Keep the bearings free of malevolent tricksters	She catches tokoloshe in clay pots; they sing when the pot is shaken.

Names of Ngomebe

Inspired by the deep southern plateau: short, earth-toned syllables with clicks and tonal shifts. Surnames often denote a stone type, a city of origin, or a Mason-Kin House.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Morvath	Thandi	Keystone-carver	<i>the Unstill</i>
Kaelen	Nia	Roller-born	<i>the Grey-Faced</i>
Senn	Zola	Mason-Kin	<i>the Slow Walker</i>
Duma	Amara	Stone-song	<i>the Ninth Roller</i>
Temba	Lindi	Sledge-heir	<i>the Root-Breaker</i>
Jengo	Penda	Ox-kin	<i>the Warm Stone</i>
Nomvula	Lethabo	Rain-touched	<i>the Drought's Daughter</i>

(Quarry/Hall/Edge) Abandoned quarry where stone-song still echoes; Mason-Kin hall with walls carved in lineage; the edge of a city's path — the stone is warm to the touch.

Spades — Places

2. **City on the Move** — Rollers groan, oxen low, the ground trembles. *The city's shadow moves faster than the city itself. Stay in the shadow to keep pace.*
Mechanical hook: If you fall out of the shadow, tick **Migration Clock** **−1** (the city leaves you behind). On a Miss, you are separated for one scene.
3. **Abandoned Quarry** — Stone-song echoes from the walls. *The song is the memory of the last stone cut here. It sings of a mason who fell.*
Mechanical hook: A character who listens (Spirit+Lore DV 4) learns a secret of the stone (a Clue about a forgotten city). On failure, the song haunts them – gain the Condition *Quarry Dreams* (−1 die on all Resolve tests for a day).
4. **Mason-Kin Hall** — Walls carved with lineage, floor inlaid with sledge-ruts. *The carvings weep water when a city is in danger. The water tastes of granite.*
Mechanical hook: Drinking the water restores 1 Fatigue but ticks **Ancestor Favour** **−1** (the ancestors are watching). Refusing to drink when offered ticks **Ancestor Favour** **−2**.
5. **Edge of the Path** — The stone is warm. The warmth fades when the city leaves. *If you place your palm on the stone before it cools, you may ask the city one question.*
Mechanical hook: Ask the GM one yes/no question about the city's destination. On a Miss, the stone burns your hand – mark 1 Fatigue and the answer is a lie.

6. **Roller-Pit** — A trench where the great rollers turn, greased with rendered ox-fat. *The grease is mixed with ancestor ash. The rollers remember every mason who ever touched them.*
Mechanical hook: Entering the pit requires Body+Athletics DV 4. On failure, take 1 Harm. Sabotaging the pit (Wits+Craft DV 5) ticks **Migration Clock** –2 but starts a **Root-binder Sabotage** [4] clock.
 7. **Keystone Chamber** — The heart of the city, a single stone that bears all weight. *The keystone hums. The pitch changes when a mason swears a false oath.*
Mechanical hook: A character who swears an oath here cannot break it without ticking **Ancestor Favour** –3. The keystone will also reveal one lie spoken in its presence per scene.
 8. **Sledge-Track Scar** — A groove worn into the bedrock by centuries of passage. *The groove is deep enough to hide a corpse. Some say it already does.*
Mechanical hook: A character who hides in the scar gains +2 dice to Stealth, but on a Miss they disturb a ghost – start a **Haunted Track** [4] clock.
 9. **Oxen Corral (Mobile)** — A pen on sledges, dragged behind the city. *The oxen never sleep. They walk in their sleep. Their dreams move the city.*
Mechanical hook: A character who soothes the oxen (Presence+Beastcraft DV 4) clears 1 Fatigue from the team and advances **Migration Clock** +1. On failure, a stampede – lose 1 Supply.
 10. **Root-binder's Grove** — A hidden stand of trees planted in an abandoned roller-pit. *The trees have stone roots. The roots grip the rollers and will not let go.*
Mechanical hook: Entering the grove ticks **Root-binder Attention** +1. A character who offers a story (Spirit+Performance DV 4) may gain a **Green Blessing** (one use of acorn magic). On failure, the roots grab them – test Body+Athletics or be pinned.
- J **Abandoned City (Dead Keystone)** — A stone shell on a hill, silent and cold. *The keystone is cracked. A single green shoot grows from the crack. The Root-binder's work.*
Mechanical hook: The Still Voice is here. Roll 1d6 on the Still Voice table. If the party takes the shoot, they may plant it to start a new grove – but the Hollow will know.
- Q **Bearing Foundry (Aeler)** — A mobile forge where new rollers are cast. *The forge is pulled by a separate team of oxen. It is always last in the procession.*
Mechanical hook: The foundry can repair one roller per day (clear 2 segments of Roller Integrity) but costs 1 Supply in fuel. If the party is unwelcome, the Aeler engineer demands a story or a favour.
- K **The Thing-Holm of Stone** — A flat rock where Mason-Kin elders meet. *The rock is a single piece of fallen sky-metal. Oaths sworn here cannot be broken.*
Mechanical hook: Any oath sworn here is witnessed by the ancestors. Breaking it ticks **Ancestor Favour** –4 and the oath-breaker is exiled from all walking cities.

A **The First City (Myth)** — A walking city that never stopped. It is said to circle the plateau, just beyond the horizon. *Those who see it cannot speak of it for a year and a day. The stone seals their lips.*

Mechanical hook: If the party sights the First City, they gain a **First City's Echo** (Diamond). The GM also gains 3 SB – the Hollow is watching through the city's eyes.

(**Cutter/Elder/Engineer**) Stone-cutter whose city left them behind; Mason-Kin elder, grey with granite dust; Aeler engineer: grease-stained, carrying a level.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Stone-Cutter (Left Behind)** — Her city moved south. She stayed to carve a monument. *She carves her own face into the rock. "So the city will remember me," she says.*

Debt they owe: She owes a sledge-right to a House that no longer exists. If you find the House's charter, she will teach you a stone-song.

Price of aid: A chisel strike on her monument. She will not say where.

3. **Mason-Kin Elder** — Grey with granite dust, eyes the colour of slate. *He carries a hammer that has never struck a false blow. The hammer knows.*

Debt they owe: He lost a keystone charter to a Root-binder. If you recover it, he will grant you a **Keystone Charter**.

Price of aid: A day's labour in the roller-pits (Body+Athletics DV 4). On failure, you owe a story about a city that fell.

4. **Root-binder Heretic** — Planting acorns in the roller-pits, singing to the earth. *His hands are bark. His breath smells of green wood. The oxen fear him.*

Debt they owe: He was once a mason. The ancestors cursed him. If you lift the curse (a ritual at the Keystone Chamber), he will give you a **Green Pact**.

Price of aid: An acorn from his grove. Planting it ticks **Root-binder Attention +2**.

5. **Aeler Engineer** — Tuning fork in one hand, level in the other. *She can hear a crack in a bearing from a mile away. She never walks under a keystone.*

Debt they owe: She lost her tuning fork in a roller-pit. Find it, and she will repair any bearing for free.

Price of aid: A story about a machine that failed. She is collecting evidence for a case against the High Council.

6. **Ox-Master** — Whip of braided leather, voice like a landslide. *He names his oxen after dead masons. The oxen stop when he speaks their names.*

Debt they owe: One ox is sick. He needs a herb that grows only in Root-binder groves. If you fetch it, he will give you an **Ox-Master's Whip**.

Price of aid: A day of driving the oxen. On a Miss, the team bolts – tick **Migration Clock -1**.

7. **Ancestral Healer (Izinyanga)** — Reads the cracks in the keystone, speaks for the dead. *She wears a necklace of ground quartz. The ancestors whisper through the stones.*
Debt they owe: The ancestors have gone silent. She needs a sacrifice – a memory of a city that fell. If you give one, she will interpret a keystone crack for you (gain a Clue).
Price of aid: A drop of your blood on the keystone. The ancestors will remember your face.
8. **Tokoloshe Catcher** — Old woman, blind in one eye, carries a clay pot. *She traps tokoloshe in her pots. They sing when shaken. She uses their songs to find sabotage.*
Debt they owe: A tokoloshe escaped. Catch it, and she will give you a **Tokoloshe Pot** (once, +1 die to detect sabotage).
Price of aid: A day of listening. The tokoloshe's song will give you nightmares (GM gains 1 SB).
9. **Impundulu Tamer** — A legendary bird-whisperer, with scars from lightning. *He can call the lightning bird with a whistle. It demands payment: the blood of a mason.*
Debt they owe: He owes the bird a debt. If you pay it (1 Supply of raw meat), he will call the bird for you once.
Price of aid: A scar. The bird will remember your face – the GM may spend 1 SB to have it appear in a storm.
10. **Impi Captain** — Warrior of the city's flank guard, carrying a shield of braided leather. *She lost two fingers to a Root-binder ambush. She still holds her spear with the remaining three.*
Debt they owe: She wants revenge on the Root-binder who took her fingers. If you help her, she will fight beside you in any city battle.
Price of aid: A spear throw. On a Miss, you hit an ox – tick **Roller Integrity** –1.
- J **The First Mason's Ghost** — A translucent figure in a mason's apron. *He appears when a keystone is first laid. He offers advice. The advice is always wrong.*
Debt they owe: He wants his name carved on a keystone. If you do, he will grant you a **Stone-Song Fragment**.
Price of aid: His advice. Follow it, and the keystone will crack (tick **Roller Integrity** –2).
- Q **The Ninth Ox** — A mythic beast said to pull the First City. *Its hooves never touch the ground. It walks on the shadow of clouds.*
Debt they owe: It has no debt – it is a legend. If you see it, you may ask one question about the First City. The answer is always a riddle.
- K **Bearing-Caster (Aeler)** — A dwarf who pours molten metal into roller-molds. *He signs each bearing with his own thumbprint. The thumbprint is a prayer.*
Debt they owe: He lost his mould to a tokoloshe. Recover it, and he will cast a bearing for free.

Price of aid: A thumbprint. He will remember your face – the GM may spend 1 SB to have his prayer answered against you.

A **The Still Voice** — A spirit made of silence and cold stone. *It asks: “Why did you stop?” Answer truthfully, or it will never let you leave.*

Debt they owe: It collects the names of cities that stopped. If you give it a name, it will answer one question about that city’s fate.

Price of aid: A name. The Still Voice will whisper it to the Hollow – the GM gains a String on the city you named.

(Crack/Sabotage/Tremor) A keystone cracks — the city stops; Root-binder sabotage — a wheel jams; an earth tremor (all actions Desperate for a scene).

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Cracked Keystone** — The heart of the city fractures. The city stops. *The crack is singing. The song is the name of the mason who carved it. He is long dead.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Roller Integrity** –2. If Roller Integrity reaches 0, the city stops and the Still Voice appears (roll on its table). The crack can be sealed with a mason’s promise (a story or a memory).

3. **Root-binder Sabotage** — Acorns sprout in the roller-pits. A wheel jams. *The roots are intelligent. They twist toward the sound of oaths.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Root-binder Attention** +1. To clear the jam, a character must swear an oath (any oath). Swearing ticks **Ancestor Favour** –1. Breaking it later ticks –3.

4. **Earth Tremor** — The ground shakes. All actions are Desperate for a scene. *The tremor was not natural. The Still Voice is waking.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Ancestor Favour** –1. On a Miss, a roller slips – tick **Roller Integrity** –1. The party may offer a sacrifice (1 Supply) to calm the tremor.

5. **Mason-Kin Feud** — Two Houses argue over the next migration route. *The argument is carved into the keystone. The stone is splitting.*

Mechanical hook: The party must choose a side or mediate. Choosing a side gives an ally but ticks **Migration Clock** –2 (the other House sabotages the route). Mediating requires Presence+Sway DV 5; on failure, both Houses turn against you.

6. **Oxen Plague** — A sickness spreads through the teams. Speed halves. *The sickness came from a Root-binder’s grove. The leaves are in the fodder.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Migration Clock** –1 per day until cured. Cure requires a Medicine test (DV 5) or a Root-binder’s blessing (costs 1 Supply and ticks **Root-binder Attention** +1).

7. **Bearing Failure (Aeler)** — A roller seizes. The engineer blames the stone-cutter. *The bearing was sabotaged with dust from the Salt Scar. The dust whispers.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Roller Integrity** **−1**. The engineer demands a replacement bearing (1 Supply) or a public apology. Refusal starts a **Engineer's Grudge** [4] clock.

8. **Sledge-Track Collapse** — The ground gives way. A section of the city sinks. *The collapse reveals an older city buried beneath. The older city is still walking.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Migration Clock** **−2**. The party may explore the older city (a mini-dungeon). Each scene there ticks **Ancestor Favour** **−1** (the dead are restless).

9. **Migration Blockade** — Another city has stopped on the planned route. *The stopped city's keystone is dead. Its people have become Root-binders.*

Mechanical hook: The party must negotiate with the Root-binders (Presence+Sway DV 5) or clear a path (Craft test, DV 6). Failure ticks **Migration Clock** **−3** (detour).

10. **Ancestral Debt Called** — A Mason-Kin House demands a sledge-right from a century ago. *The right is carved on a tablet of slate. The slate is warm. The ancestors are watching.*

Mechanical hook: Pay 2 Supply or offer a hostage (a PC becomes a temporary follower of the House). Refusal ticks **Ancestor Favour** **−2** and starts a **Feud of the Slate** [6].

- J **Tokoloshe in the Bearings** — A water spirit fouls the roller-pits. The city groans. *The tokoloshe is small, fast, and invisible to the unaware. Only a catcher can see it.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Roller Integrity** **−1** per scene until caught. Catching requires a tokoloshe catcher (NPC) or a Wits+Spirit test DV 5. On failure, the tokoloshe escapes – tick again.

- Q **Impundulu Strikes** — A lightning bird shatters a keystone with a thunderous blow. *The bird is angry. Someone broke a vow to the Rain Queen. The city bleeds stone.*

Mechanical hook: Tick **Roller Integrity** **−3**. The bird demands a sacrifice: the blood of a mason (1 Harm to a PC) or a vow renewal (swear an oath to the Rain Queen). Refusal ticks **Ancestor Favour** **−3**.

- K **Root-binder Revolt** — A grove of walking trees attacks the roller-pits. *The trees have stone bark. The stones are carved with Mason-Kin faces.*

Mechanical hook: Combat (Cap 3 adversary). If the party loses, the city stops for 1d4 days. If they win, tick **Root-binder Attention** to zero – the grove burns, but the Hollow's attention ticks +2.

- A **The First City Approaches** — A city older than memory appears on the horizon. *It is made of obsidian. Its rollers are giant femurs. It wants to merge.*

Mechanical hook: The party has one scene to flee or negotiate. Merging cities will erase both identities – the party loses all Ngomebe Assets. If they flee, tick **Migration Clock** **−5** (the First City chases them).

(**Charter/Wax/Song**) Keystone charter (right to dwell in a city for a season); sledge-wax (greases negotiation with the Mason-Kin); stone-song fragment (one reroll on a survival test).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Keystone Charter** — Right to dwell in a city for a season, tax-free. *The charter is a chip of the keystone itself. Carry it to be welcomed.*
Ancestor cost: If you break the charter's terms (e.g., harm a mason), the chip turns to dust and you gain the Condition *Stone-Cursed* (−1 die on all rolls involving Ngomebe for a year).
3. **Sledge-Wax** — A lump of grey grease. Use it to gain +1 Position in Mason-Kin negotiations. *The wax is rendered from the fat of an ox that walked a thousand miles.*
Ancestor cost: The ox's ghost follows you. Once per session, the GM may have it low at an inopportune moment (tick **Migration Clock** −1).
4. **Stone-Song Fragment** — A recorded hum. Reroll a failed Survival test once. *The song is the city's heartbeat. Hum it, and the stone will guide you.*
Ancestor cost: Humming the song ticks **Ancestor Favour** −1 (the dead are listening). If you use it in a city that has stopped, the Still Voice appears.
5. **Roller-Bearing (Aeler-crafted)** — A spare bearing. Gift it to an engineer for a favour. *The bearing is stamped with a rune that means "no weight owed." The rune is a lie.*
Ancestor cost: Using the bearing voids the lie – the engineer will remember. The GM may spend 1 SB to have the bearing fail at a critical moment.
6. **Mason-Kin Hammer** — A tool that never misses a keystone's true face. *The hammer's head is a piece of the First City's keystone. It whispers warnings.*
Ancestor cost: The hammer whispers to the Hollow. Each time you use it, tick **Ancestor Favour** −1. When Ancestor Favour reaches 0, the hammer shatters.
7. **Ox-Master's Whip** — Crack it to make oxen move faster for one leg. *The whip's braid includes a hair from every ox that ever pulled a city.*
Ancestor cost: The whip angers the oxen's ghosts. After use, the next stampede is automatic (GM may spend 1 SB to trigger it).
8. **Root-binder's Acorn** — Plant it to stop a city's roller for one day. *The acorn grows into a sapling within an hour. The sapling has stone roots.*
Ancestor cost: Planting the acorn ticks **Root-binder Attention** +2 and **Ancestor Favour** −2 (the ancestors see it as betrayal). The acorn can be removed only by a Root-binder's blessing.
9. **Abandoned City Map** — A chart of dead cities and their keystone graves. *The map is drawn on stone. The stone is a page. The pages are bound in granite.*

Ancestor cost: The map is haunted. Each time you consult it, roll 1d6. On a 1, the Still Voice appears (roll on its table). On a 6, you find a forgotten keystone – gain 1 Supply.

10. **Elder’s Verdict** — A ruling that settles a Mason-Kin dispute in your favour. *The verdict is carved on a slate tablet. Carry it as a shield.*

Ancestor cost: The losing House will remember. Start a **Vendetta [6]** clock. When it fills, they sabotage your city.

- J **Bearing-Foundry Pass** — Access to the Aeler mobile forge for one repair. *The pass is a single steel coin. The coin is still hot.*

Ancestor cost: The forge is a witness. If you use the pass for a dishonest repair, the coin burns your hand – mark 1 Harm and the engineer will never trust you again.

- Q **Still Voice’s Silence** — One question answered truthfully by the spirit of abandoned stone. *The answer comes as a cold breath. The breath smells of geode crystals.*

Ancestor cost: After the answer, the Still Voice marks you. Tick **Ancestor Favour –2**. The Voice will ask you a question in return; you must answer truthfully or lose 1 XP.

- K **First City’s Echo** — A piece of obsidian that hums with ancient rhythm. *Once per campaign, touch it to make a city move one mile in a single night.*

Ancestor cost: Using the Echo ticks **Ancestor Favour –4** (the First City’s ancestors are disturbed). The city that moves will be haunted by the Echo’s ghost for a year (GM gains 1 SB per session).

- A **The Living Keystone** — A fragment from a city that still walks. *Plant it in dead stone, and a new city will grow. The growth takes a century.*

Ancestor cost: The keystone is alive. It will demand a blood-price (1 Harm per year of growth). Refusal turns it to dust – the Hollow takes your name.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters, wax, songs) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **stone-omens**—rollers that groan in harmony, keystones that weep water, a city that leaves no track.
- Track the **Migration Clock [10]**, **Roller Integrity [8]**, **Ancestor Favour [8]**, and **Root-binder Attention [6]** as campaign-wide pressures.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Keystone Bond (Relationship Mechanic):** Each walking city has a Keystone — a single stone that bears the weight of the roof. The Keystone is also the physical anchor of the city’s ancestral spirit. A character who bonds with the Keystone (by spending a downtime scene in meditation at its base) gains:
 - **Keystone Sense:** Once per scene, the character can ask the Keystone one question about the city’s current state (“Is the eastern roller cracking?” “Is there a saboteur in the foundry?”). The Keystone answers truthfully, but only about the present.
 - **Keystone Weight:** The character gains a 4-segment **Ancestor’s Attention** clock. When it fills, the ancestor demands a service — usually a pilgrimage to a forgotten quarry or the retrieval of a lost roller.
- **The Roller-Pits (Hazard Mechanic):** The city moves on rollers — massive wooden cylinders that must be greased and rotated. The roller-pits are dangerous, loud, and prone to sabotage.
 - Entering a roller-pit requires a **Body + Athletics test (DV 4)** to avoid being crushed. On a failure, the character takes 1 Harm.
 - Sabotaging a roller-pit (to stop the city or redirect it) requires a **Wits + Craft test (DV 5)**. On a success, the city moves in the desired direction; on a failure, the roller jams and the city stops — and the ancestors are angry.
 - Repairing a jammed roller takes 3 actions. Each action requires a **Body + Craft test (DV 4)**. On a failure, the roller shifts and the character takes 1 Fatigue.
- **The Migration Clock (Campaign Clock, size 10):** Every walking city has a Migration Clock. It advances each day the city moves, and retreats when the city stops.
 - At 2: The city enters fertile land. The party gains +1 die to foraging and hunting.
 - At 4: The city passes a rival settlement. The party may trade or raid.
 - At 6: The city enters a narrow pass. All navigation rolls are Desperate.
 - At 8: The city approaches a sacred site. The ancestors grow restless — all rolls involving the Keystone gain +1 die, but failure ticks the Ancestor’s Attention clock by 2.
 - At 10: The city reaches its destination — the end of the migration. The ancestors are satisfied. The party may claim a **Keystone Blessing** (a permanent +1 die to all rolls involving stonework or negotiation with Ngomebe).

The party can influence the Migration Clock by:

- **Scouting ahead** (Wits + Survival) – success advances the clock by 1, failure ticks it back by 1.

- **Repairing rollers** (Craft test) – success advances the clock by 2, failure advances it by 0 but ticks the Ancestor’s Attention.
- **Paying tribute** (a Honey Jar, a story, or a Boon) – advances the clock by 1 without risk.
- **The Root-binder Heresy (Faction Mechanic):** Root-binders are heretics who plant acorns in the roller-pits, hoping to stop the cities and let the forest reclaim the stone. They have a **Sabotage Clock (size 6)**. Each time the party fails a Craft or Survival roll in a roller-pit, the Sabotage Clock ticks.
 - At 2: A roller cracks. The city loses 1 Speed (travel takes longer).
 - At 4: A roller-pit floods. The city must stop for repairs (lose 1 day).
 - At 6: A major collapse. The city cannot move until the party clears the pit (requires a Strength + Craft test, DV 5, and costs 1 day).

Players can work with the Root-binders (gain information, sabotage rival cities) or against them (hunt them, protect the rollers). The Root-binders offer **Green Blessings** – a permanent +1 die to survival in the forest, but the forest’s attention tightens (the Hollow’s gaze falls more often).

- **The Mason-Kin Houses:** The walking cities are not nations but extended families. Each House controls a keystone, a migration route, and the rights to carve. Houses feud over sledge-tracks, water rights, and the honour of the First City.
- **The Aeler Pact:** The Aeler engineers of the southern ranges maintain the bearings and capstans that make the walking cities possible. The Ngomebe provide keystone hearts and stone-song. It is a partnership of equals, sealed in slate and iron.
- **Ancestral Cracks:** Once per session, a character may press their ear to a keystone and roll Spirit + Lore (DV 3). On success, the ancestors whisper a warning or a clue (GM reveals a hidden complication or a shortcut). On a miss, the stone is silent — but the ancestors are listening.
- **Tokoloshe Pots:** A character who carries a clay pot with a tokoloshe inside gains +1 die to detect sabotage or traps in the city. The tokoloshe sings when danger is near. However, if the pot breaks, the tokoloshe escapes and will haunt the carrier for a full season (all actions Desperate at night).
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The First Stone** — The Sealed Gate. *The keystone that never cracks; the oath that never breaks.*
 - **The Rain Queen** — Raéyn. *The bringer of storms and the drought; the mistress of the path.*
 - **The Lightning Bird** — The Storm King. *The shatterer of false keystones; the judge of masons.*

– **The Ancestor’s Voice** — The Witness. *The whisper in the crack; the memory in the stone.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Umbhemisi and the Salt Scar:** The Cracking Wind is said to be the ghost of the First City, ground into dust by its own stubbornness. Some Ngomebe elders believe that if a city ever stops moving for nine generations, the Wind will reclaim it entirely. The Root-binders whisper that the Wind is not a curse but a teacher: it cracks only the stone that refuses to grow.
- **The Sledge-Wax Trade (Way of Silk):** Sledge-wax is a valuable commodity on the caravan routes. Tulkani merchants trade it for story-knots; Fhara water-clerks use it to seal well-contracts. A missing shipment of sledge-wax could stop a city.
- **The Iron Mines of Vajrapur (Dhahara):** The Aeler engineers of Ngomebe source their bearing-metal from the Dhaharan iron mines. A dispute between a Mason-Kin House and a Dhaharan raja could choke the supply of rollers.
- **The Hollow and the Still City (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is attracted to still places. A city that stops moving becomes a beacon. The Aelaerem whisper that the First City never stopped because it is running from something — and that something may be the Cracking Wind itself.
- **Tokoloshe and the Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord sometimes capture tokoloshe and weave them into Hollowed children. The tokoloshe inside the child sings when a weight is overdue. The Ngomebe avoid Daughter-run hospices for this reason.
- **Sekogo’s Ukwe Roots:** The Ukwe’s roots are said to extend beneath the southern savannah. A Ngomebe mason who dreams of roots cracking her keystone knows that a debt to the Speaking Tree has come due.
- **Aelinnel Bone-Spinners:** The coastal gnomes who roll the dawn bones never explain why a failed roll sometimes sounds like a cracked keystone. The Ngomebe have learned to listen to both.

Ngomebe Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Roller:** Crumble a crust into the grease-pit. Ignore the first *Earth Tremor* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Sledge-Rope:** Tie a single knot in an ox’s halter. Cancel *Oxen Plague* or take –1 die on your next handling roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Keystone:** Whisper a dead mason’s name into the keystone’s crack. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with the Mason-Kin this scene, but the ancestors will expect an answer. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Mason-Kin guards** or **Aeler engineers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ox-drivers** or **stone-cutters**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Root-binders** or **keystone guardians**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable migration pace**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local **Mason-Kin elder** or **Aeler vent-prior** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **earth tremor** or **roller jam**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **Root-binder cell** or **rival House guard** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Mason-Kin, Root-binders, or Aeler engineers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**keystone cracks/city stops/First City sighted**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Mason-Kin High Council, Still Voice, or First City's herald intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**tremor opens a chasm/city splits in two/keystone begins to sing**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ngomebe (Stone Law):** Keystone hums a warning, roller-grooves glow faintly, the ground trembles without quake.
- **Ngomebe (Root-binder Heresy):** Acorns sprout from cracks, vines write warnings in the dust, trees move against the wind.
- **Ngomebe (Aeler Pact):** Bearings click in counterpoint, tuning forks ring without being struck, the smell of hot metal hangs in still air.
- **Ngomebe (Ancestral Spirits):** A cold breath whispers a name, the keystone weeps water, a tokoloshe laugh echoes from a dry roller-pit.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *False Trail*.
- **Cut the Sledge (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a keystone charter is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Tremor (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Earth Tremor*, you pick who stays standing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Stone & Root)

- **The Root-King (Nine Groves)** — *Phases:* Acorn Sabotage → Orchestrated Stillness → Forest Coup. *Cracks:* burn a grove, expose a false acorn, survive a landslide.
- **The Still Voice (Silence of Stone)** — *Phases:* Abandoned Keystones → Procession of Dead Cities → Stillness Baptism of an Elder. *Cracks:* relic stone-song, survivor testimony, the city moving against the Voice.

- **The Tokoloshe King (Master of Tricksters)** — *Phases*: Bearings Foul → Roller Pit Flooded → Oxen Stampede. *Cracks*: trap him in a clay pot, negotiate with a pot of sorghum beer, feed him a false name.
- **Umbhemisi (The Cracking Wind)** — *Phases*: Dust on the Horizon → The Song of Rust → The Stillness of Bone. *Cracks*: offer a forgotten keystone, speak the name of a city that never stopped, or let a mason carve a new oath into the Salt Scar.

Patronage & Power

Among the Ngomebe, power flows through keystones, migration rights, and the loyalty of the Mason-Kin Houses. An elder's authority rests on the age of his House's keystone and the number of cities that follow his route. The Aeler engineers hold technical authority; the Root-binders offer a heretical alternative; and the Ancestral Healers speak for the dead, who still vote through the cracks in the stone.

For the GM: Power in Ngomebe society is measured in movement and stone. Patronage often takes the form of keystone charters, sledge-wax, or stone-song fragments—each tied to a specific city and House. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (chips of keystone, lumps of wax, recorded songs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival Houses issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose city shelters them.
- Use the roller-pits, keystone chambers, and Mason-Kin halls as arenas for social contests, where migration routes are debated and saboteurs are judged.
- Introduce **Ancestral Cracks** as a way for players to gain clues from the dead — but at the cost of the ancestors' attention.

In Ngomebe society, the stone remembers everything — including the weights you carry. The ancestors do not forget. The tokoloshe does not forgive. And the city that stops dies.

The Nine Rollers: A City on the Edge

The Hook

The party arrives at the edge of a moving city — not one of the great metropolises, but a smaller Walker named **Khomani's Progress**, named after the mason who carved its keystone three centuries ago. The city is dying.

Elder Morvath meets you at the sledge-track, his face grey with granite dust and exhaustion. “The city has not stopped in forty days. We cannot stop. The ancestors will not let us. But the rollers are cracking. The oxen are dying. And something is following us — something that walks in the dust and counts our breaths.”

He leads you to the keystone chamber. The great stone is warm. Too warm. A network of fine cracks spreads from its centre like veins. The cracks are singing — a low, mournful hum in a language none of you recognize.

“The Ninth Roller is failing,” Morvath says. “It was carved by Khomani herself. It has never been replaced. If it fails, the city stops. If the city stops, the Hollow comes. We have nine days until the roller cannot turn. Find a replacement — or learn to sing the stone-song well enough to heal it.”

The Mechanics

The party has **nine days** (or scenes) to save *Khomani's Progress*. Each day, they may choose one action from the table below. The city's condition is tracked by three clocks:

|p0.3|p0.5|

Clock	Description
Roller Integrity [9]	Starts at 9 (the Ninth Roller). Ticks down each day. At 0, the roller fails.
Ancestor Favour [8]	Starts at 4. Ticks up when the party honours the ancestors, ticks down when they offend. At 8, the ancestors help. At 0, the Still Voice comes.
Root-binder Attention [6]	Ticks up when the party interacts with Root-binders or damages the forest. At 6, the Root-binders attack.

Daily Actions

Each day, the party chooses **one** primary action and may assign up to **two** party members to support (each support grants +1 die to the primary roll).

|p0.3|p0.25|p0.35|

Action	Roll	Outcome
Search for a new roller	Wits + Survival (DV 5)	<i>Success</i> : Find a suitable stone. <i>Partial</i> : Find one that needs carving. <i>Fail</i> : Find nothing — tick Roller Integrity -1.
Carve a replacement	Craft + Spirit (DV 6)	<i>Success</i> : New roller ready in 2 days. <i>Partial</i> : Ready in 4 days. <i>Fail</i> : Crack the stone — Roller Integrity -2.
Negotiate with Root-binders	Presence + Sway (DV 4)	<i>Success</i> : Root-binder Attention -2. <i>Partial</i> : -1. <i>Fail</i> : Root-binder Attention +2.

Chapter 5

Taharka

The Monsoon Crown.

Kofi admits: *“The passes are a graveyard for armies. The horses speak in riddles. The coffee ritual has three cups – and a fourth, silent one, for the spirits. I have never understood it. I just pay my toll and keep my mouth shut.”*

Taharka grows rich on monsoon trade – spices, coffee, incense – and has never been conquered. Its high passes are a graveyard for Ashaani armies, a barrier that Oshiiran grain barges cannot cross. The kingdom is a fortress of rock and thin air, where every valley speaks a different dialect and every ridge has a watchtower. The horse is not a mount; it is a lineage, a treaty, a weapon. And the old spirits – *mizimu*, *kichocheo*, *pepo* – are not legends. They are neighbours. Be polite. Count to eight. Never pour the fourth cup.

“Never refuse the second cup of coffee. The first is welcome; the second is a test of honour; the third is a contract. Refuse the second, and you have insulted the house – and the house’s ancestors, who listen through the floorboards.”

— Ridge-Watcher Captain Anwar

What do people eat for breakfast? Barley flatbread and spiced tea – the bread baked on iron griddles, the tea brewed with cardamom and mountain herbs that only the Ridge-Watchers know.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read the wind. The eight winds have names. The ninth wind has no name – it is the mountain’s breath. The mountain’s breath is death.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their breath. The air is thin. Fast breathers have not acclimated. Slow breathers are hiding something. Those who do not breathe are spirits.

What is the most common crime? Horse theft – a declaration of war. A stolen horse is a stolen ancestor. The thief’s clan pays in blood or trade.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Crown Council has not met in ten years. The passes are closed by snow, by war, by the simple fact that the councillors cannot agree on a meeting place. The Ridge-Watchers rule by the mountain’s voice.

Where do people go when they die? To the high passes. Bodies laid on stone platforms, wrapped in woollen shrouds. The wind carries their names to the peaks. The peaks remember.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a horse – the best in your stable. If the wronged party accepts, the debt is paid. If they kill the horse, the debt is blood. Blood is never repaid.

What is the most important festival? The First Rain (monsoon's arrival). The passes open, the caravans descend, the lowland ports receive the first spice ships. The celebration lasts nine days. The ninth day is silent – for the dead of the passes.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Crown Council's missing member is not missing. He is buried under a landslide that was not an accident. The Ridge-Watchers caused it – because he learned the passes' secret: they are not natural. Something older carved them, and the Ridge-Watchers are its servants.

The Aelaerem of the Southern Hills

The Aelaerem – pygmy halfling coffee-tenders of the highest passes – are described in full with their own generator tables at the end of this chapter (see the **Aelaerem of the Southern Hills** subsection). Their red threads, ninth-cup rites, and mist-shrouded terraces are a constant reminder that the smallest folk often hold the oldest keys.

5.1 Taharka — “The Monsoon Crown”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mountain listens. The horse remembers. The monsoon keeps the balance.*

Ridge-Watcher Captain (Elite): “The passes remember every army that tried to climb them. The mountains do not forgive haste, and they do not forget a foreign banner. We do not guard the highlands. We listen to them. They tell us who to let through.”

Horse Trader (Commoner): “Before you praise the rider, praise the horse. Before you praise the horse, praise the mountain that grew its lungs. A Taharkan foal is born breathing thin air, and each foal carries a *fumbo* – a riddle from its ancestor’s death. To ride it, you must answer. To answer wrong is to fall. To answer true is to be remembered.”

Genre / Mood: Monsoon trade, highland fortresses, spirit-ridden passes, oral law.

Starting Location: A rock-chapel at the head of the Silver Pass, where the air is cold and the wind smells of snow. A Ridge-Watcher captain blows a horn of ibex horn: “The Crown Council has declared a muster. The passes are closing to all foreign traffic. You have until dusk to declare your business – or turn back. The *mizimu* are restless. They taste fear on the wind.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Taharka grows rich on monsoon trade – spices, coffee, and frankincense that travel east to the distant ocean and west to the Gulf. The kingdom has never been conquered; its passes are a graveyard for Ashaani armies and a barrier that Oshiiran grain barges cannot cross. The highlands are a fortress of rock and thin air, where every valley speaks a different dialect and every ridge has a watchtower. On the coast, the monsoon winds bring dhows from Dhahara, Ayokha, and the eastern isles, and the coastal tongue – *Kimvita* – has grown from a dozen voices, the language of the wharves where a merchant can bargain in verse and a captain can curse in seven accents.

The old spirits are not a single kind. *Mizimu* watch from the cairns, demanding tobacco and silence. *Kichocheo* live in baobabs – they throw stones at anyone who counts to nine beneath their branches. *Pepo* ride the monsoon winds; they speak through the mad, and their price is always a white turban left at a crossroads. In the deepest passes, the *popobawa* hunts at the dark of the moon – but only if you whispered its name in doubt the night before. And the passes themselves are alive, breathing with the memory of every army that froze or fell.

Neighbors and Trade Partners:

- *North – Ashaan:* The Veiled Sisters' agents slip through disguised as spice merchants, but the high passes have never fallen to Ashaani armies. The Ridge-Watchers test every stranger with the coffee ceremony – three named cups: *Abol* (welcome), *Tona* (negotiation), *Baraka* (contract) – and now a fourth, the silence cup.
- *South – Ngomebe:* The walking cities of the Stone Men are distant neighbors, linked by the Salt Scar and the Aeler engineers who maintain both bearing-foundries and pass-capstans. Ngomebe masons occasionally travel north to study Taharkan rock-chapels.
- *East – Dhahara and Ayokha (Monsoon Circuit):* Taharkan coffee and spices ride the monsoon winds east to the Dhaharan coast and the Ayokhan river markets. The *mchango* – a rotating mutual-aid treasury – binds captains across three kingdoms; a Taharkan spice warehouse in Ayokha is considered neutral ground.
- *Southeast – The Aelaerem of the Southern Hills:* Pygmy halflings who tend the high passes and trade coffee for stories. Their ninth-cup rite is respected by every Ridge-Watcher.

What you notice first: The smell of roasting coffee and frankincense. The way the air thins as you climb, until each breath is a measured gift. The constant lowing of pack mules on terraced paths.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse the second cup of coffee. The first (*Abol*) is welcome; the second (*Tona*) is a test of honour; the third (*Baraka*) is a contract. Refuse the second, and you have insulted the house – and the house's ancestors, who listen through the floorboards. And never, ever pour the fourth cup – that is for the *mzimu* of the hearth, and they are always thirsty.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Pass

Power here is measured in passes, horse lineages, and the favour of the monsoon. The Crown Council rules from the high plateau, but each valley has its own lord, each pass its own toll-keeper. The Ridge-Watchers are the eyes of the kingdom, stationed in rock-chapels that double as signal towers. The horse is not a mount; it is a lineage, a treaty, a weapon. To control the highland breeds is to control the passes – and to control the passes is to remain free. The lowland coast operates under a different law: the *mchango* of the dhows, a rotating mutual treasury where every captain owes a share of every voyage to the community. A captain who cheats the *mchango* finds his ship's name struck from the *laha ya meli* (ship register), and the *mng'aro* of the wharf will point at him every dusk until he pays.

Prominent NPCs of Taharka

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
—	Ridge-Watcher Captain Anwar	Commander of the Silver Pass garrison	Keep the passes closed to Ashaani spies	He has not descended below the snow line in twenty years. His shadow is a man who died on the pass.
—	Merchant-Queen Safiya	Spice House matriarch of the western coast	Control the monsoon trade before the Crown taxes it	She speaks the coastal tongue with an accent that no one can place. Her left eye is a cowrie shell.
—	Horse Lord Tamrat	Breeder of the royal stables	Sell a foal to the Dhaharan court for a pass-right	He names his horses after dead poets. The horses recite verses in their gait – riddles called <i>fumbo</i> .
—	Sister Hana	Covenant judge of the highland circuit	Resolve disputes between lords without drawing Crown attention	She carries a water-clock that runs on melted snow. It never freezes.
—	The Spirit-Healer of the Monsoon	Crown advisor, <i>mganga wa pepo</i>	Predict the first rains to set the trade season	He has not seen the sun in thirty years. He keeps a <i>luba</i> (spirit drum) that plays itself at midnight.
—	The Pass Spirit (<i>Kinyamkera</i>)	A spirit of a soldier who froze on watch	Warn travellers of avalanches and ambushes	It appears as a column of steam. It points with a <i>kiwiko</i> (a wooden spoon).
—	Mama Zawadi	<i>Buna-tcha</i> (coffee woman) and spirit medium	Speak for the spirits of the baobab groves	She never walks on bare earth. Her sandals are woven from the roots of a sacred fig.

Names of Taharka

Inspired by the highland plateau and the coast: melodic, with doubled consonants, honorific prefixes (Mwalimu, Bibi, Bwana), and surnames that denote a clan, a pass, or a horse-line.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2				
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets	
Tamrat	Safiya	Berhanu	<i>the Ridge-Born</i>	
Anwar	Hana	Tesfaye	<i>the Horse-Tongue</i>	
Dawit	Zawadi	Gebre	<i>the Monsoon-Watcher</i>	
Kassim	Lij	Mekonnen	<i>the Ninth Pass</i>	
Solomon	Tsion	Desta	<i>the Coffee-Blade</i>	
Jabir	Mwanaidi	Asfaw	<i>the Thin-Air</i>	
Omari	Bahati	Ngoma	<i>Drum-Voice</i>	

(Farm/Chapel/Pass) Terraced coffee farm on stone steps; rock-chapel where walls drip condensation; high pass where snow lingers even in summer.

Spades — Places

2. **Terraced Farm (Coffee)** — Shrubs planted on stone-step shelves. *Each step is a different family's share – paid in beans, not coin. The buna-gada terrace is harvested only once every eight years, at the turn of the gada cycle.* '[LABOR]'
3. **Rock-Chapel (Dripping)** — A cave-temple where the walls weep condensation. *Drink from the eighth stone, not the ninth. The water tastes of iron and old bargains. A kichocheo lives in the drip.* '[RITUAL]'
4. **High Pass (Summer Snow)** — A saddle between peaks where the wind never stops. *The snow is blue – the frozen breath of the dead. The kinyamkera walks here at dusk, pointing with its spoon.* '[WEATHER]'
5. **King's Stable** — A long building of fitted stone, horses in brass halters. *Each stall has a nameplate – a defeated enemy's shield. To bond with a horse, you must answer its fumbo (riddle).* '[LEGEND]'
6. **Spice Warehouse (Coast)** — A wood-and-coral building that smells of cardamom. *The floor is layered with spices that fell from broken sacks. The ghosts of porters sort them at night – they accept no wages, only the rustle of a kanga cloth.* '[TRADE]'
7. **Monsoon Wharf** — A stone pier that is underwater half the year. *Each tide mark is a year when a ship never returned. The sailors' widows add new marks with their tears. The mng'aro of the wharf appears there on moonless nights.* '[DEATH]'

8. **Crown Council Hall** — A roundhouse of stone and horn, built into a hillside. *The hall has nine doors. Each door leads to a different valley. The ninth door is sealed. Behind it is a spider that weaves the future – but it only weaves at the turn of the gada.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
 9. **Horse Cemetery** — A field of cairns, each topped with a bronze bell. *The bells ring when a foal is born to the same bloodline. The dead horses speak through the bells – their advice is always a fumbo.* ‘[DEATH]’
 10. **Ridge-Watcher Tower** — A stone needle on a peak, with a signal fire that never goes out. *The fire burns blue when the passes are closed. It burns green when a foreign army is sighted. It burns red when a popobawa walks.* ‘[WARNING]’
 - J **Coastal Tongue School** — A thatched hut where children learn *Kimvita*. *The teacher is a one-eyed sailor. He signs his lessons with knots, not words. The knots are a map of the monsoon winds.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
 - Q **The Spirit-Healer’s Observatory** — A roofless tower with a bronze armillary sphere. *The sphere has nine rings. The ninth ring is broken. The mganga refuses to fix it – he says the ninth wind has no name.* ‘[MAGIC]’
 - K **The Pass of the Ninth Army** — A defile where an Ashaani host froze to the rock. *On cold nights, you can still see their shapes in the ice. Their lips move – they are still counting. If they reach nine, the popobawa answers.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
 - A **The King’s Tomb (Hidden)** — A cave sealed with a single keystone. *The keystone has a single word carved in Kimvita: “Wait.” The word changes each gada season. Only the Ridge-Watchers know the current one.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- (**Trader/Watcher/Envoy**) Horse trader with a copper bell; Ridge-Watcher captain with a bow over his shoulder; Spice House merchant in robes smelling of cardamom.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Horse Trader** — Copper bell on his belt, a ledger of bloodlines in his head. *He names his price in coffee, not coin. He knows every fumbo of every horse in the valley.* ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Ridge-Watcher Captain** — Bow of horn and sinew, arrows fletched with eagle feathers. *He can draw a bow at full gallop. He has never missed. He says the mountain guides his hand – but he also leaves a pinch of tumbaku at every cairn.* ‘[COMBAT]’
4. **Spice House Merchant** — Robes stained with cinnamon, fingers yellow with turmeric. *She can identify a spice’s origin by taste. She has been wrong twice. Both times, the ship sank. She no longer tastes alone – she shares the cup with a mzimu.* ‘[TRADE]’

5. **Crown Council Envoy** — Careful, neutral, carrying a staff of office carved from a single piece of ebony. *He speaks in questions. “Would the honoured traveler perhaps consent to...” The questions are traps. The answers are leverage. The staff is the bokku of the abba gada. ‘[POLITICS]’*
6. **Coffee Farmer** — Hands stained black from hulling beans, eyes crinkled from sun. *He offers a cup to every passerby. The cup is clay – from a sacred spring. He never drinks first; that would insult the spirit of the bean. ‘[COMMUNITY]’*
7. **Monsoon Captain** — A sailor with a brass ring in one ear and a scar across his throat. *He speaks the coastal tongue with a Dhaharan accent. His ship is named “Ninth Wind.” He has never lost a dhow to a storm – the storms are his cousins, because he pays his mchango on time. ‘[TRAVEL]’*
8. **Pass Guide** — A hooded figure with a staff tipped with a horse skull. *She never speaks above a whisper. The wind carries her voice exactly as far as needed. She knows every crevasse by the sound it makes when she spits into it – and which ones are actually the breath of a kinyamkera. ‘[STEALTH]’*
9. **Sister Hana (Covenant Judge)** — Grey robe, water-clock, a scale that never balances. *She has ruled on nine border disputes. The losing party always apologizes. The winning party always shares their meal with her – and a cup of Baraka. ‘[JUSTICE]’*
10. **Horse Lord Tamrat** — Grey beard braided with horsehair, missing two fingers. *The missing fingers were bitten off by a foal. He kept the foal. It is now his favourite mount. Its name is “Apology” – and its fumbo is unanswerable. ‘[SOCIAL]’*
- J **The Spirit-Healer** — Blind, pale, wrapped in wool. He smells of wax and ozone. *He predicts the monsoon by the pulse of a luba drum. The drum has never been wrong. He feeds it his own dreams. ‘[MAGIC]’*
- Q **The Pass Spirit (Kinyamkera)** — A column of steam in the cold air, shaped like a soldier. *It points with a wooden spoon. The direction indicates the safest route – but the spoon is cold. If you take the spoon, you can ask one question of the dead. Your hand will freeze to it. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WARNING]’*
- K **The King (Offstage)** — Never seen, rarely heard, but his name opens every door. *Rumour says he is a horse. Rumour says he is a pepo. Rumour says he is a child of nine who never grew up. The Ridge-Watchers do not correct any rumour. ‘[AUTHORITY]’*
- A **The Ninth Heir (Exiled)** — A prince who lost a succession war, now living as a horse-trader. *He carries a seal made of bone. The bone was his father’s thumb. He has not used it. He is waiting for the right moment – or the right fumbo. ‘[LEGEND]’*

(Landslide/Sickness/Assassination) A landslide blocks the pass (delay 2 segments); horse sickness spreads — all mounts lose 1 Speed; the king is assassinated — passes close to all foreign traffic.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Landslide Block** — A rockslide covers the pass. Delay 2 segments. '[WEATHER]'
The rocks are warm. The landslide was caused by a signal fire on the peak. Someone wanted the pass closed – and they did not leave an offering at the kichocheo's baobab.
3. **Horse Sickness** — A cough spreads through the stables. All mounts lose 1 Speed. '[DISEASE]'
The sickness came from a Dhaharan ship. The captain is a spy. The horses cough in a rhythm that spells a fumbo – a warning about the ninth pass.
4. **King Assassinated** — The Crown Council declares a succession crisis. All passes close. '[POLITICS]'
The assassin was a horse. The horse was poisoned. The poison was in the coffee – the Baraka cup. The horse is still alive. It will not speak.
5. **Ashaani Raiders (Disguised)** — A caravan of “merchants” is actually a Veiled Sister's scout team. '[SPY]'
They wear Taharkan dress but do not remove their shoes indoors. The innkeeper noticed. She poured them a fourth cup – the silence cup – and a pepo now follows them.
6. **Coffee Blight** — A fungus attacks the terraces. Prices triple. Starvation looms. '[DISASTER]'
The blight was spread by a trader from the coast. The trader's ship flew no flag. The fungus writes names on the leaves – the names of those who broke the gada oath.
7. **Monsoon Delay** — The winds shift. The first ships are three weeks late. '[WEATHER]'
The delay was predicted by the spirit-healer. He warned the Crown. The Crown did not listen – they refused to renew the mchango with the eastern fleets. The spirit-healer has stopped drumming.
8. **Spice Warehouse Fire** — A stack of cinnamon ignites. The whole wharf is at risk. '[DISASTER]'
The fire was set by a rival House. The House has a monopoly on pepper. The smoke smells of cloves – but cloves do not burn. A mng'aro is laughing in the smoke.
9. **Trade Creole Dispute** — A contract is voided because of a mistranslated word. '[SOCIAL]' '[DEBT]'
The word means “shipment” in Kimvita and “hostage” in Kiamu. The merchant knew. The hostage is the party's ally. The kinyamkera points at the merchant's house.
10. **Ridge-Watcher Betrayal** — A captain sells the pass schedule to an Ashaani agent. '[SPY]' '[DEBT]'
The captain's daughter is a spirit-broken slave in Galanina. He had no choice. He carved her name into every stone of the pass – and now her mzimu walks there at dusk.
- J **The Pass Spirit's Warning** — The kinyamkera points at a traveller. The traveller will die before sunset. '[DEATH]' '[OMEN]'
The traveller is a party member. The spirit is pointing at a shadow, not a person. The shadow is not theirs. It belongs to a popobawa that has been following them since they doubted its name.

- Q Crown Council Schism** — The nine lords cannot agree on a successor. Civil war looms. '[POLITICS]' *The ninth lord is a child. The child speaks only the coastal tongue. No one understands. The child's nanny is the only interpreter – and she is not neutral. She is the abba gada of the skipped generation.*
- K Horse Line Extinction** — A plague kills the last mare of the royal bloodline. '[DEATH]' '[LEGEND]' *The mare's foal was stolen by a rival kingdom. The foal is in a Dhaharan stable. The mare's ghost runs the passes every night, whinnying a fumbo that no one has answered.*
- A Spirit Rising (Mzimu Uprising)** — The old ancestors wake from the cairns. They demand a reckoning. '[MAGIC]' '[FEAR]' *A traveller broke a taboo – they counted to nine near a spirit tree. The mizimu want a story that ends with eight. Tell one, or pay in a lock of hair and a cup of tumbaku.*

(Bond/Stone/Pass) Horse-bond – a foal promised (future String); *Jiwe la Mng'aro* (“the gleam-stone”) – crossing a high pass at half toll; *Kikombe cha Buna* (coffee cup) – trade goods at +1 Position for one scene.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Horse-Bond (*Kiapo cha Farasi*)** — A future String. The foal has not yet been born. '[COMMUNITY]' *The bond is a braid of horsehair, braided with a fumbo. Wear it, and the mare will remember you. When the foal is born, you will be its first rider – if you answer its riddle.*
3. **Pass-Stone (*Jiwe la Mng'aro*)** — A carved token. Cross any high pass at half toll. '[TRAVEL]' *The stone is a piece of the kinyamkera's spoon. It is cold to the touch. It warms when a storm is coming – and it burns if you have spoken a doubt about the popobawa.*
4. **Coffee Measure (*Kikombe cha Buna, Royal Seal*)** — A clay cup. Trade goods at +1 Position for one scene. '[TRADE]' *The cup was used by the king. He drank Baraka from it once. The crack is from his tooth. He still has the tooth – it is set in a ring that can open the ninth door.*
5. **Ridge-Watcher's Horn** — Blow it to summon a guide from the nearest tower. '[TRAVEL]' *The horn is made from an ibex that the captain killed with a single arrow. The ibex's ghost will lead you – if you give it a story that ends with eight.*
6. **Spice House Letter of Credit** — 5 Measures of trade value, redeemable at any coast warehouse. '[TRADE]' *The letter is sealed with cinnamon oil. The seal smells of betrayal. It also smells of profit – and the mchango treasury will honour it once before the ink dries.*

7. **Crown Council Verdict** — A ruling in your favour on any border dispute. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The verdict is carved on a slate tile. The tile is also a signal flag. Show it to a Ridge-Watcher, and they will argue for you – but they will also ask for a cup of Tona.*
 8. **Monsoon Schedule (Spirit-Healer’s Copy)** — Predicts safe sailing days for the next season. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The schedule is drummed into a clay cylinder. The cylinder must be kept in a jar of water. If the water dries, the predictions invert – and the luba will play a warning.*
 9. **Coastal Tongue Phrasebook** — Gain +1 die to all social rolls on the coast for one journey. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The phrasebook is a string of knots. Each knot is a curse. The curses are useful. The blessings are not – they are just knots tied by the one-eyed sailor’s ghost.*
 10. **Horse Lord’s Favour** — One foal from the royal stables, delivered in a year. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The favour is a single white hair from the stallion’s tail. The stallion is dead. The hair is still warm – and it answers to its fumbo only when the wind is from the north.*
- J **Pass Spirit’s Pointing** — One safe route through any high pass, guaranteed. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The kinyamkera writes the route in frost on a rock. The frost melts at noon. You must memorize it before then – and you must leave the wooden spoon at the cairn.*
- Q **The Spirit-Healer’s Drum (Luba)** — A clay drum that pulses with the monsoon’s heartbeat. ‘[MAGIC]’ *Once per campaign, drum the luba to summon a pepo. The pepo will answer one question about the weather – but then it will ask a question of its own. The question is always personal.*
- K **The Ninth Heir’s Seal** — A bone thumbprint. Commands loyalty from the exiled prince’s network. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The seal is also a key. It opens a lock in the Crown Council Hall. The lock is the ninth door. The door leads to a room with no floor – only a spider’s web that weaves the names of those who have broken the gada oath.*
- A **The King’s Blessing** — A royal decree written in the coastal tongue. One national favour. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The decree is written on a horse’s hoof. The hoof was the king’s favourite mount. The king still weeps when he sees it – and the mount’s mzimu will carry you one night, but only if you answer its fumbo correctly.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (bonds, stones, measures) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **monsoon-omens** — horses that speak in *fumbo*, coffee that tastes of snow, a pass that closes behind you, a *luba* drum that plays without a hand, a spider that weaves the future into its web.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Ridge-Watcher Signals:** A network of signal towers on every peak. A fire, a mirror, or a horn can send a message across the entire kingdom in a day. The Ridge-Watchers are neutral in Crown politics; they serve only the passes. A character who spends an action to light a signal fire may reduce the next weather hazard by 1 segment, but the fire also attracts *mizimu* (GM gains 1 SB).
- **Mchango of the Dhows (Mutual Treasury):** Along the coast, every captain contributes a fixed share to a rotating treasury. A character who contributes to the *mchango* (by paying a share, repairing a dock, or telling a true story) gains a *Community Favour* token. Spend it to reroll a failed social roll with any coastal merchant or captain. Hoarding wealth without contributing, however, gives the GM 1 SB per session as the community closes ranks – and the *mchango* treasurer may send a *pepo* to remind you.
- **Spirit Taboos (*Mwiko*):** The old spirits have specific taboos. Breaking a taboo (counting to nine near a *kichocheo*'s baobab, refusing a second cup of coffee, wearing shoes in a shrine) draws their attention. The GM may then spend 2 SB to have a spirit appear and demand a story that ends with the number eight. A good story pacifies the spirit; a poor one curses the offender with *Mwiko* (–1 die on all rolls until they make an offering of honey and blood).
- **Horse Lineage as *Fumbo* (Riddle):** Every highland horse belongs to a lineage that traces back to a legendary stallion – and each lineage has a *fumbo*, a riddle. Knowing a horse's *fumbo* gives +1 die on social rolls with its owner. A character who can recite the *fumbo* of a horse from memory may treat the horse as a temporary ally (Cap 2) for one scene. Forging a lineage (inventing a false *fumbo*) is a capital crime – the Crown Council has executed three forgers in the last decade. Their ghosts guard the pass where they died, and their *fumbo* is unanswerable.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Mzimu wa Kwanza** (The First Spirit) – The Witness. *The ancestor who remembers every oath, every betrayal, every cup of Tona refused.*
 - **Bwana wa Nyasi** (Lord of the Grass) – The Traveler. *The wind that guides the monsoon dhows and the rider lost in the high passes.*
 - **Shetani wa Tisa** (The Spirit of Nine) – The Ninth. *The presence that lives in the missing step, the uncounted wave, the breath after eight.*
 - **Bibi wa Kahawa** (Grandmother of Coffee) – Inaea. *The web of trade that binds coast to highlands, merchant to farmer, dhow to mule. Her fumbo is the answer to every broken promise.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Monsoon Trade (Dhahara/Ayokha):** Taharka's spice and coffee travel east on the monsoon winds, reaching the Dhaharan coast and the Ayokhan river markets. A delay in Taharka means famine in a dozen ports. The dhows are blessed by Bibi wa Kahawa; a captain who breaks the blessing finds his ship becalmed for nine days – and the *mchango* treasury will not lend him a single sail.
- **The Pass Spirit and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The *Kinyamkera* is a spirit of the threshold – a border between living and dead. The Aelaerem say it is a cousin to the Hollow, bound by an oath to the first king. If you see it point at you, you have one day to settle your obligations. The Hollow collects the rest – and the *kinyamkera* will take your spoon.
- **Ashaani Spies and the Veiled Sisters (Ashaan):** Ashaani agents often pose as spice merchants. The Ridge-Watchers have learned to test them by offering coffee – a foreigner who does not know the ritual of three cups (*Abol*, *Tona*, *Baraka*) reveals themselves. The Veiled Sisters have begun sending agents who have studied the ritual. The Ridge-Watchers are now testing with a fourth cup – the silence cup. Those who drink it are marked, and a *pepo* follows them.
- **The Ninth Heir and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The exiled prince is rumoured to have bought his horse from a Dhaharan smuggler – a horse that carried a certain green glass amulet. The Crown Council wants to know where the amulet is now. The prince says he sold it for a *jiwe la mng'aro* (pass-stone). The pass-stone is now in the hand of the spirit-healer – and its *fumbo* has not been answered.

Taharka Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Pass:** Crumble a crust at the highest point of the pass. Ignore the first *Landslide Block* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Horse's Tail:** Tie a single knot in a horse's tail hair. Cancel *Horse Sickness* or take –1 die on your next riding roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Coffee:** Whisper a dead Ridge-Watcher's name into a cup of *Abol*. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating passage this scene, but the ancestors will expect an answer – and the cup will be empty when you look down. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Ridge-Watchers** or **Crown Council envoys**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **horse guards** or **spice warehouse clerks**.

- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **pass guides or rival horse traders**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable monsoon window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local Ridge-Watcher captain or Spice House factor** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **landslide or fog**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival horse lord or Ashaani agent** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Ridge-Watchers, Crown guards, or spice house enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – **king assassinated/monsoon fails/pass closes forever**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Crown Council, the Spirit-Healer, or the *Kinyamkera*** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **avalanche buries the pass/monsoon surf floods the wharf/coffee terraces catch fire**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Taharka (Highlands):** Pass stones glow faintly, horse bells ring without wind, snow falls upward, a *fumbo* whispers in your ear.
- **Taharka (Coast):** Monsoon winds carry whispers, spice dust forms faces, the coastal tongue sprouts new words unbidden, a *luba* drum plays a single note.
- **Taharka (Spirit Law):** A *kichocheo* laughs from a baobab, a coffee cup cracks, a spider weaves a question into its web, the *popobawa* scratches at your door.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thin Air*.
- **Cut the Pass (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a pass-stone is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Monsoon (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Monsoon Delay*, you pick which ships dock; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Horse, Monsoon & Spirits)

- **The Horse-Line Thief (Nine Bloodlines)** – *Phases*: Foal Thefts → Orchestrated Plague → Stable Coup. *Cracks*: recover a stolen foal, expose a false *fumbo*, survive a stampede of ghosts.
- **The Monsoon-Breaker (Storm That Stalls)** – *Phases*: Delayed Ships → Procession of Empty Wharves → Famine Baptism of a Merchant. *Cracks*: relic monsoon drum, survivor testimony, the wind turning against them – and a *pepo* whispering the true schedule.
- **The Spirit of the Ninth Pass (*Shetani wa Tisa*)** – *Phases*: Miscount Whispers → Stone Slides → Pass Feast. *Cracks*: recite a counting song that ends at eight, offer a honey-and-blood sacrifice at the *kinyamkera*'s cairn, survive a night on the mountain without fire – and without doubting the *popobawa*'s name.

Patronage & Power

Among the Taharka, power flows through passes, horse lineages, and the favour of the monsoon – and through the *gada* cycle, the eight-year rotation of political authority. The Crown Council rules by consensus, but each valley lord commands his own Ridge-Watchers. The spice merchants of the coast operate independently, paying tariffs to the Crown but answering to no single lord. The *mchango* of the dhows is a parallel economy of mutual aid – a captain who cheats it finds his ship’s name erased from every mooring post, and the *mng’aro* of the wharf will point at him every dusk until he pays.

For the GM: Power in Taharkan society is measured in altitude, access, and the answering of riddles. Patronage often takes the form of pass-stones, horse-bonds, or coffee cups – each tied to a specific valley, bloodline, or trade route. To emphasize the highland spirit-culture:

- Tie rewards to physical tokens (carved stone, braided hair, clay cups) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided – and that may carry a *fumbo* of their own.
- Let rival lords issue conflicting pass-rights, forcing players to choose whose path to follow – and whose *mzimu* to offend.
- Use the rock-chapels, horse cemeteries, and monsoon wharves as arenas for social contests, where hospitality is law, a cup of coffee is a contract, and a *pepo* may be listening.
- Introduce spirits as recurring obstacles – they are not enemies but creditors of a different kind, demanding stories rather than silver, and always asking: “Did you count to eight before you spoke?”

In Taharkan society, the mountain remembers every step – and the horse remembers every rider. The spirits remember every miscount.

5.1.1 Aelaerem of the Southern Hills

“They are small, but the mountain does not crush them. They walk where the passes forget their names, and the coffee they trade tastes of mist and memory. Never refuse a cup – the first is welcome, the second is a test, and the ninth cup is for the hollow that lives under the hill. They pour eight and leave the ninth empty. So should you.”

Quick Reference **Tagline:** *Small hands, old obligations. The hill remembers every foot-step.*

Genre / Mood: Pastoral highland folk, hospitality traps, mist-veiled pygmy clans.

Who They Are. In the high passes of southern Taharka, where the air thins and the coffee terraces climb into the clouds, live the Aelaerem of the Southern Hills – a pygmy halfling people who were ancient in these mountains before the first Taharkan king raised his banner. They keep to the upper slopes, tending terraced groves of wild coffee, shepherding shaggy mountain goats, and weaving red thread through the antlers of the passes. Outsiders call them *hill-kin* or *cloud-tenders*; they call themselves *the remembered*, because every stone on every cairn has a name, and they are the ones who still speak them.

The Aelaerem have no king, no capital. Their courts are the circle of standing stones at a mountain spring; their law is the counting of cups and the tying of knots. They trade coffee, mountain herbs, and old tales with Taharkan caravans, but they do not trust the lowlands – and the lowlands have learned to respect the ninth cup.

What you notice first: The smell of roasting coffee and damp moss. The way every threshold of their felt and stone huts has a red thread tied at eye level. The silence when a stranger approaches – and the sudden song when a child decides you are welcome.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a second cup of coffee. The first is welcome; the second is a test of honour; the third is a contract. Refuse the second, and you have insulted the house – and the house’s ancestors, who listen through the floorboards. And never, ever pour the ninth cup.

The Ninth Cup in the Highlands. Among the Taharkan Aelaerem, the rite of the ninth cup is subtle: at any feast or negotiation, eight cups are poured. The ninth cup is left empty on the table, facing the door. It is for the Hollow – the presence that walks the high passes when the mist rolls down. If a stranger pours the ninth cup, the Hollow will drink, and the stranger will owe a weight. If the stranger drinks the ninth cup themselves, they have invited the Hollow to sit beside them. The Aelaerem will not intervene. The Hollow is patient.

Coffee & Knots. Aelaerem coffee is famous across Taharka, but it is never sold for coin. It is bartered for stories, for promises, for red thread that will be tied around a debtor’s wrist. A bag of highland beans comes with a knot – a promise recorded in wool. The knot is cut when the promise is kept. Until then, the debtor can feel it tighten when they sleep.

Spades — Aelaerem Places (d6)

2. **Cloud Terrace** — Coffee shrubs planted on stone steps lost in mist. *The mist has a voice. It whispers the names of those who have not yet fulfilled their promises. The eighth step is warm; the ninth is cold.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
3. **Red Thread Cairn** — A pile of stones bound with faded wool; prayers tied to antlers. *Each thread is a promise kept. The cairn grows a handspan each year – but the ninth thread is never tied. It is left loose for the Hollow.* ‘[RITUAL]’
4. **Spring Circle** — A ring of standing stones around a cold mountain well. *The water tastes of iron and old bargains. Drink only from the eighth stone. The ninth stone has no cup.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Felt Hut of the Story-Keeper** — Low, warm, full of smoke and the smell of roasting beans. *The Story-Keeper has not left in forty years. The hut has not grown colder. She pours eight cups at dusk, and the ninth she leaves for the kinyamkera.* ‘[HOSPITALITY]’
6. **Goat Walk** — A vertiginous path where only the sure-footed pass. *The goats have names. They will tell you the safe route – if you ask politely, and if you answer their fumbo.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
7. **The Ninth Cairn** — A mound of stones with no thread, no offering, no name. *The ninth cairn is for promises that can never be kept. Do not touch it. Do not point. If you must leave something, leave a cup of Abol – then walk away without looking back.* ‘[DEATH]’

Hearts — Aelaerem People (d6)

2. **Coffee Wife** — The matriarch of a terrace, keeper of the harvest and the promises. *She ties a knot for every sack. She has never lost a knot. She knows the fumbo of every bean.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
3. **Goat-Herd** — A small figure in a patched cloak, always humming. *His goats answer to the hum. They also answer to the names of dead Aelaerem – and they will not cross a threshold where the ninth cup has been poured.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
4. **Thread-Witch** — A hedgewise woman who weaves red wool and omens. *She can tie a knot that will hold a ghost – or cut one that should have held. She never cuts the ninth knot; that is for the Hollow to loose.* ‘[MAGIC]’
5. **Stone-Speaker** — An elder who reads the names carved on the old cairns. *He has forgotten his own name. The stones remember it for him. He speaks only in eights – never nine.* ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’

6. **Mist-Walker** — A young Aelaerem who guides caravans through the high passes. *She never uses a compass. She reads the taste of the fog – and she knows which patches of mist are actually the breath of a kinyamkera.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
7. **The Hollow’s Witness** — An ancient, half-blind figure who sits at the ninth cairn. *She does not speak. She points. The direction she points is the direction the Hollow will walk tonight. If she points at you, pour a cup of Baraka on the ground and do not sleep.* ‘[DEATH]’

Clubs — Aelaerem Complications (d6)

2. **Road-Bread Refused** — A caravan master sneers at the offer of a shared cup. *The pass closes behind him. The mist has teeth – and the kichocho in the nearest baobab is throwing stones.* ‘[HOSPITALITY]’
3. **Ninth Cup Poured (By Mistake)** — A stranger pours the empty cup. *The Hollow drinks. The stranger now owes a weight to a creditor who does not accept silver – only a story that ends with eight.* ‘[DEBT]’
4. **Red Thread Cut** — Someone cuts the thread around a debtor’s wrist. *The promise does not vanish. It transfers. The cutter is now the debtor – and the thread will retie itself around the cutter’s neck by dawn.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Goat Stampede** — A flock of shaggy mountain goats barrels through the caravan. *They are not angry. They are fleeing something worse. The mist behind them has a shape – and the shape is counting to eight.* ‘[FEAR]’
6. **Coffee Blight** — A fungus turns the berries black; the terrace sings at night. *The song is a name. The name is the Coffee Wife’s. She will not speak of it – but she pours a cup of Tona on the ground every night, and the blight retreats an inch.* ‘[CURSE]’
7. **Stone-Speaker’s Silence** — The old man stops reading the cairns. *The stones are angry. A promise was broken – a fumbo left unanswered. The party is the closest witness. The stones will ask a riddle; if you cannot answer, the ninth cairn will open.* ‘[JUSTICE]’

Diamonds — Aelaerem Rewards (d6)

2. **Red Thread Knot** — A knot tied by the Coffee Wife. Present it to claim a minor promise from any Aelaerem. *The knot tightens when the debtor lies. It loosens when they speak true – but it will never untie completely. That is the interest.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
3. **Highland Bean Sack** — A bag of coffee that never runs dry. *Brew it to gain +1 die on negotiation rolls with any highlander for one scene. The beans smell of mist – and of the fumbo of the horse that carried them.* ‘[TRADE]’

4. **Moss-Hide Cloak** — Woven from mountain moss and goat wool. *When standing still in mist, you are invisible to mundane sight. The mist does not betray you – unless you owe a promise. Then it will part, and the kinyamkera will point at you.* ‘[STEALTH]’
5. **Goat’s Tooth Whistle** — Blow it to call a single sure-footed goat. *The goat will carry a light load and never slip. It will also judge your character and report to the herd – and the herd’s fumbo is older than the mountain.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
6. **Stone-Speaker’s Name** — A single true name of an ancestor carved on a pebble. *Speak it at a cairn to ask one question of the dead. The answer is always a riddle – and the riddle will cost you a memory if you cannot solve it.* ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’
7. **The Hollow’s Cup** — An empty ceramic cup, warm to the touch. *Set it on a threshold, and the Hollow will not cross for one night. After that, the Hollow will remember the favour – and it will ask for a cup of Abol at the next new moon.* ‘[PROTECTION]’

Adventure Seed: The Ninth Cairn’s Promise A Stone-Speaker has stopped speaking. The ninth cairn is weeping water that tastes of salt and old blood. The Coffee Wife says a promise was called in – a pledge made by a Taharkan prince to an Aelaerem chieftain, three generations ago. The prince’s descendant is in the party’s caravan, travelling in disguise. The Hollow walks the passes. The party must either:

- Find the original promise (hidden in a cairn under a stone that has not been moved in a century – and guarded by a *kichocheo* that demands a story ending with eight).
- Pay the weight in memory (a cherished recollection of a kindness, given to the Hollow at the ninth cairn – and the Hollow will also take the memory of your face).
- Or convince the Aelaerem to forgive the promise – which requires a story that moves the stones themselves, and a cup of *Baraka* shared with the *mizimu*.

The reward is the Coffee Wife’s blessing: a single red thread that can tie any two willing parties into a binding promise, enforceable by the mountain itself – and a *fumbo* that answers itself.

Chapter 6

Sekogo

The Green Council.

Kofi shrugs: *“The jungle is not a place. It is a council. The Ukwé – the Speaking Tree – decides whose debts are collected and whose are forgiven. I have seen a man lie before the Ukwé. He did not speak again for a year.”*

Sekogo lies between the Sahel grasslands and the southern plateau – a dry savannah that grows wetter as you travel east, until the baobabs give way to deep jungle. The Green Council rules through consensus; honey-orchards are sacred; old spirits still walk. Slavery is forbidden – the jungle itself would rise against any slaver who crossed its border. The Ukwé, the Speaking Tree, remembers every promise. The Leopard Society hunts those who break the deepest taboos. Honey is a bond. A mask is a law.

“Never cut a marked tree. The bark grows over the names of debtors, but the wood remembers. Cut it, and the Ukwé will add your name to its ledger.”

— Hunter Okoro, Leopard Society mask-wearer

What do people eat for breakfast? Mashed yams and groundnut stew – the yams from clearings that shift with the seasons, the groundnuts harvested by monkey-tribes who speak the old tongue. The monkeys are not paid. They are remembered.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the spirits. River, Tree, Stone, Rain, Fire, Wind, Honey, and the ninth – the spirit that has no name. The ninth spirit is the Ukwé’s shadow. It never forgives.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their mask. Carved wood, painted with lineage symbols. A cracked mask means a broken taboo. A blank mask means no lineage. No mask means not a person. The Leopard Society hunts the maskless.

What is the most common crime? Debt-forgetting – a sickness. The Ukwé keeps the Calendar of Debt. A forgotten debt grows roots and strangles the debtor’s house.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Green Council does not rule. The Ukwé rules. The Council is its voice – eight speakers chosen by the tree’s roots. The ninth seat is empty. The ninth speaker is the tree itself. It does not speak. It waits.

Where do people go when they die? *To the Ukwé's roots. Bodies laid at the base of the Speaking Tree. The roots absorb them. A new leaf grows for each soul. The leaves whisper the names of the dead.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You hammer a nail into a nkisi power figure. The nail is your wrong. The spirit inside accepts it. When the nail rusts away, your debt is paid. The nail never rusts.*

What is the most important festival? *The Honey Harvest (autumn). The bees are sung to sleep. The first bowl is offered to the Ukwé. The tree drinks. The tree does not thank.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Ukwé is not a tree. It is a prison – the binding of a spirit that tried to consume the jungle nine centuries ago. The spirit is still alive. The tree is its cage. The Green Council has forgotten what it guards.*

6.1 Sekogo — “The Green Council”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The jungle remembers every promise. The mask is the law. The honey is a bond.*

Leopard Society Hunter (Elite): “The jungle has a memory. When a fever rises, we cut it out. When an oath is broken, we restore the balance. We are not cruel. We are necessary. The tree remembers every deed, and we are its teeth.”

Honey-Gatherer (Commoner): “The bees know my name. They do not sting me because I sing to them the song of the first blossom. My grandmother taught me that the honey is not a gift; it is a trust. One day, the grove will need something from you, and you will remember the taste.”

Genre / Mood: Jungle folk horror, spirit diplomacy, mask-law.

Starting Location: A honey-orchard at the jungle’s edge, where the trees hum and the air is thick with bees. A masked figure in a leopard pelt steps from the shadows: “The Ukwé has asked for a name. A caravan master broke his oath to the grove. Find him before the roots do — or become his witness.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Sekogo lies between the Sahel grasslands and the southern plateau — a dry savannah that grows wetter as you travel east, until the baobabs give way to deep jungle and the air turns thick with the smell of damp earth and overripe fruit. Here, the Green Council rules through consensus, honey-orchards are sacred, and the old spirits still walk. Slavery is forbidden; the jungle itself would rise against any slayer who crossed its border. But the Council is divided: Conservators want to protect the old pacts, while Wakers argue that the jungle has grown sluggish and needs to be roused with fever-mists, thorn-spirits, and older, bloodier rites. At the eastern edge lies the Crimson Valley, home to the Lethai-ar — chestnut-brown elves whose silk bridges span red canyons and whose web-law keeps both empires from using the valley as a shortcut to war.

Neighbors and the Unclaimed Ground:

- *North – Ameria and the Neutral Kingdoms:* Beyond Sekogo's northern savannah lies a patchwork of small, independent kingdoms — buffer states that pay tribute to neither Sekogo nor Kahfagia. Their courts are weak, their laws a creole of jungle custom and coastal tariff. Smugglers and exiles thrive there. The Leopard Society occasionally hunts across the border, but always with a local guide.
- *East – The Crimson Valley (Lethai-ar):* The Ukwe's roots extend into the valley's red stone. The Lethai-ar silk-wardens respect the Speaking Tree, and the Green Council's witnessed promises are sometimes recorded on a Lethai-ar cord. A bridge toll paid in Sekogo honey is honored on both sides of the gorge.
- *South and West – The Jungle's Own:* Sekogo's borders are not lines but gradients. The deeper you go, the more the Ukwe's roots thicken and the Leopard Society's law becomes the only law.

What you notice first: The sound of bees — a constant, low drone that never stops, even at night. The way the trees lean toward you when you speak a secret. The smell of honey and rotting fruit, sweet and sharp at once.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cut a marked tree. Each such tree is a living witness. The bark grows over the names of those who have broken harmony, but the wood remembers. Cut it, and the Ukwe will add your name to its memory.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Root

Power here is measured in witnessed promises, honey tithes, and the balance between jungle and council. The Leopard Society hunts those who break the deepest taboos — oath-breakers, slavers, outsiders who take more than they give. The Earth Society keeps the **Calendar of Witness**, a sacred list written on bark and buried at the Ukwe's roots — not a record of debts, but a memory of what must not be forgotten.

The spirits of Sekogo are not a single kind. *Mzuka* are ancestral shades bound to partic-

ular groves; they speak in the voices of the dead and demand offerings of honey and silence. *Kizimba* are nature guardians — a crocodile in a bend of the river, a baobab that remembers a broken treaty. They do not speak; they show. A *Ngozi* is a vengeance spirit, born from a promise paid in blood instead of honey; it wears the face of the wronged and hunts until the debt is settled. *Anansefo* — the children of the spider-trickster — weave illusions and swap promises for laughter. And in the oldest groves, the *Ninki Nanka* — a serpent with a mirror-back — slithers between roots, its reflection showing the lies you have told. The Hollow manifests here as the *Mwitu*, the forest that forgets where the village ends — and that forgetfulness is a hunger.

Prominent NPCs of Sekogo

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Hunter Okoro	Leopard Society mask-wearer	Hunt down a Waker who poisoned a foreign caravan	He never removes his mask. The mask is his real face now.
Elder Imani	Earth Society Ogboni	Keep the Calendar of Witness from being forgotten	She speaks only while holding a piece of the Ukwe's bark. She cannot lie.
Nganga Malika	Spirit-doctor of the <i>minkisi</i>	Heal a wound caused by a broken <i>nkisi</i>	She carries a carved figure with nine nails. The ninth nail is loose.
Waker Sefu	Radical who wants to wake the jungle	Poison the wells of a Conservator village	A green shoot grows from his shoulder. It bleeds when he lies.
Lethai-ar Silk-Warden Anara	Guard of the Crimson Valley bridges	Keep the web-law intact against Oshiiran pressure	Her skin-tattoos record a witnessed promise her grandmother carried. She will not say to whom.
The Ukwe's Voice	A spirit that speaks through a cracked root	Remind the Council of a promise nine years overdue	It speaks in the voice of a dead child. The child was a witness.
Ananse's Child (Trickster)	A spider-spirit in human form	Unravel oaths for the joy of chaos	It wears nine tiny bells on its ankles; each bell is a broken promise.
Mami Wata	Water spirit of the Crimson Falls	Collect a memory from every soul that crosses her pool	Her hair is black water; her eyes are river stones. She never blinks.

Names of Sekogo

Inspired by the savannah and jungle regions: melodic, with nasal consonants and tonal shifts. Surnames often denote a totem animal, a grove, or a witnessed deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
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Okoro Imani Ngoma *the Masked*

Sefu Malika Ukwe-born *the Honey-Tongue*

Chima Anara Leopard-kin *the Oath-Keeper*

Kofi Zola Root-walker *the Ninth Nail*

Tunde Amara Grove-singer *the Unmarked*

Biko Nkiru Minkisi-hand *the Still Witness*

Adofu Adaeze Ananse-fo *the Trickster's Child*

(Orchard/Circle/Bridge) Honey-orchard where the trees hum; druid circle with moss-covered stones and a leopard skull at centre; Lethai-ar silk bridge spanning a crimson gorge with the Ukwe's roots clutching the water below.

Spades — Places

2. **Honey-Orchard** — The trees hum. The air is thick with bees. *The honey is dark red. It tastes of iron and forgotten promises. The ninth hive is always empty — the bees say the Hollow has taken the queen.* '[SPIRIT]'
3. **Druid Circle (Leopard Skull)** — A ring of moss-covered stones. A skull sits at the centre. *The skull is warm. When the Leopard Society hunts, the eye sockets glow — and the mzuka of the skull whispers the quarry's true name.* '[RITUAL]'
4. **Lethai-ar Silk Bridge** — A span of woven silk across a crimson gorge. *The silk is made from spider-sap and oath-hair. It will not break unless an oath is called. The ninth strand is invisible — it is the Hollow's witness.* '[OATH]'
5. **The Ukwe (Speaking Tree)** — A baobab so old its bark is carved with a thousand names. *The tree speaks in the voices of the dead. It never gives answers — only new questions and old memories. The ninth root never stops growing; it searches for the name that was erased.* '[WITNESS]'
6. **Nkisi Grove** — A clearing where broken power-objects are buried. *The ground hums. The nails that sealed the minkisi have grown into iron thorns. The ninth thorn is always warm; it marks the grave of the nganga who drove the first nail.* '[MAGIC]'
7. **Calendar of Witness (Earth Society Vault)** — A hollow log sealed with wax and bone. *Inside are strips of bark. Each strip records a broken harmony. The bark is still growing — and the ninth strip has no writing. It waits for a promise that has not yet been broken.* '[MEMORY]'
8. **Waker's Fever-Mist Pool** — A stagnant pond that steams even in winter. *The mist smells of rotting flowers. Breathe it, and you will see the jungle as the Wakers see*

it — a place that is starving, waiting to be woken. The ninth breath of the mist shows the Mwitu. ‘[WEATHER]’

9. **Leopard Society Lodge** — A longhouse hidden in a thicket of thorn-vines. *The walls are made of human jawbones. The jaws are from oath-breakers. They still click when a new name is spoken — and the ninth click is always the name of the next quarry.* ‘[SECRET]’

10. **Crimson Valley Gorge** — A canyon of red stone, crossed by silk bridges at three points. *The stone is warm. It bleeds rust when the web-law is broken. The ninth bridge is a myth — it appears only when a promise is witnessed by a ghost.* ‘[THRESHOLD]’

- J **Conservator Archive** — A cave filled with sealed clay pots. Each pot contains a memory. *The memories are for sharing. The price is a memory of equal weight. The ninth pot is cracked — the memory inside is leaking, and no one remembers what it was.* ‘[MEMORY]’

- Q **The Grove of Sleeping Spirits** — A forest where the *minkisi* go to die. *The spirits do not wake. They dream of the first nail. The dream is contagious — and the ninth dream is the Hollow’s own.* ‘[DEATH]’

- K **The Ukwe’s Root-Chamber** — A cavern beneath the tree where the roots form a throne. *The throne is made of braided roots. Sit on it, and the tree will ask one question. Answer poorly, and you never leave. Answer with a lie, and the ninth root will bind your tongue.* ‘[JUDGMENT]’

- A **The Crimson Falls** — A waterfall that runs red after the first rain of spring. *The water is not blood. It is rust from the canyon walls. The Lethai-ar say it is the earth’s memory of a war — and the ninth drop is always cold, because it fell on a broken oath.* ‘[SPIRIT]’

- A+ **The Pool of Mami Wata** — A still, black pool behind the Crimson Falls, reachable only by diving underwater. *The water is warm. It shows not your reflection, but the face of the person whose memory the spirit holds. The ninth ripple is always your own face — but older, and weeping.* ‘[WATER]’

(Gatherer/Druid/Warden) Honey-gatherer with a fruit offering and a leopard claw necklace; Green Council druid with a thorn-staff and milky eyes that see the weight of promises; Lethai-ar silk-warden, masked and quiet, his mask painted with the Ukwe’s roots.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Honey-Gatherer** — She wears a leopard claw around her neck. The claw is from a cat she killed with her bare hands. *She offers a fruit to the trees before each harvest. The fruit is always a little rotten — the ninth bite is for the Mwitu.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’

3. **Green Council Druid (Conservator)** — Milk-white eyes, a staff of living wood. *She cannot see the living. She sees only the threads of promises — glowing connections between every person and the Ukwe. The ninth thread is always frayed.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
4. **Waker Radical** — Carries a bag of fever-mist spores. His eyes are yellow. *He plants thorns in the paths of Conservator caravans. The thorns grow into walls overnight — and the ninth thorn is always a nkisi nail, driven into a forgotten promise.* ‘[DANGER]’
5. **Lethai-ar Silk-Warden** — Mask carved from the Ukwe’s root, painted with oath-names. *He never speaks above a whisper. The bridge hears him anyway — and the ninth whisper is always the name of someone who will break a promise before dawn.* ‘[OATH]’
6. **Leopard Society Hunter** — Wears a pelt that shifts and moves as if alive. *He can transform into a leopard at night. Or so he claims. No one has survived a hunt to confirm it — but the ninth transformation is said to be permanent.* ‘[FEAR]’
7. **Earth Society Elder** — Holds a piece of the Ukwe’s bark. The bark is warm. *She asks every visitor: “What have you forgotten to honour?” The answer is carved into her memory — and the ninth answer is always the same: a name that cannot be spoken.* ‘[TRUTH]’
8. **Nganga (Spirit-Doctor)** — Carries a *nkisi* carved with nine nails. The ninth nail is loose. *She hammers a nail into the figure to call a spirit. Each nail is a cost. She has nine costs left — and the ninth nail, if driven, will call the Hollow.* ‘[MAGIC]’
9. **Oath-Keeper (Hollow Manifestation)** — A figure made of bark and silence. It appears when the Calendar of Witness grows heavy. *It does not speak. It points at the one who broke harmony. That person’s name appears on the nearest tree — and the ninth letter of the name glows green.* ‘[DEATH]’
10. **Lethai-ar Mark-Cutter** — A tattooist who records promises on skin. *She uses a needle of silk-fiber and ink made from crushed crimson stone. The ink glows when a promise is broken — and the ninth mark she ever cut was her own.* ‘[MEMORY]’
- J **The Ukwe’s Voice (Spirit)** — A crack in the tree’s bark that speaks. *The voice changes. Sometimes it is a child. Sometimes it is a jarl. Sometimes it is the listener’s own. The ninth word it speaks is always the name of a promise you forgot to make.* ‘[SPIRIT]’
- Q **The First Nail (Legend)** — A mythic nganga who sealed a spirit into the Ukwe itself. *She is said to still walk the jungle, carrying a hammer made of root and bone. The ninth nail she drove was never found — it is still searching for the promise it was meant to seal.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- K **The Leopard King** — A spirit that leads the Society’s midnight hunts. *It has no mask. Its face is a leopard’s. Its eyes are human. The ninth hunter who follows it never returns — they become the Leopard King’s shadow.* ‘[FEAR]’

A The Crimson Valley's First Weaver — A ghost who teaches the web-law to new wardens. *She appears at dawn on the central bridge. She asks one question: "Who watches the watchers?" The ninth warden who answers wrongly is woven into the bridge.* '[JUSTICE]'

A+ Ananse's Child (Trickster) — A small figure with too-long fingers, wearing nine tiny bells. *It offers to "renegotiate" any promise — but its renegotiation always adds a new, hidden clause. The clause is a joke. The joke is always on you — and the ninth bell rings only when the joke is already done.* '[TRICKERY]'

(Spirit/Offer/Name) A thorn-spirit blocks the path — must offer honey or fight; the Ukwé demands a name before letting you pass; a Lethai-ar silk-walker challenges you to recite the web-law.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. Thorn-Spirit Block — A wall of living thorns grows across the path. *The spirit — a kizimba of the hedge — demands a name. Give a false one, and the thorns grow inward. Give a true one, and the thorns will part — but the spirit will remember your face.* '[SPIRIT]' '[DEBT]'

3. Ukwé Demands a Name — The tree speaks: "I have forgotten a promise. Remind me." *If you cannot name a broken promise, the tree will take your name instead — and the ninth root will grow a new leaf with your face on it.* '[WITNESS]' '[TRUTH]'

4. Lethai-ar Web-Law Challenge — A silk-warden blocks the bridge: "Recite the ninth clause." *The ninth clause is unwritten. It changes with each warden. You must guess — but the ninth guess is always wrong, because the clause is the warden's own secret.* '[OATH]'

5. Leopard Society Hunt — A masked hunter appears at dusk. "You are called to witness." *Refusal earns a Leopard's Mark. The jungle becomes hostile to you — and the ninth beast you meet will be wearing a mask of your face.* '[FEAR]'

6. Nkisi Hunger — A spirit-object you carry begins whispering. It wants a memory. *Refuse, and the nkisi shatters. The spirit inside is not friendly — and the ninth shard will embed itself in your shadow, following you until you feed it.* '[MAGIC]'

7. Waker Poisoning — A well is found with a green film on the water. *The poison is not lethal. It makes you dream of the jungle's hunger — and the ninth dream is always the Mwitú asking, "Why are you still here?"* '[WEATHER]'

8. Earth Society Audit — An elder demands to see what you carry in your memory. *The record is written in scars on your skin. You have no scars. That is suspicious — so the elder will give you nine scars, one for each forgotten promise you cannot name.* '[TRUTH]'

9. **Honey-Tithe Demanded** — A grove spirit appears: “Pay the ninth jar.” *You have no honey. The spirit offers a bargain. The interest is a story — and the ninth story you tell will become a new root in the Ukwe’s memory.* ‘[DEBT]’
10. **Crimson Valley Border Dispute** — Oshiiran surveyors cross the web-line. The Lethai-ar arm their bows. *The party is caught between. Whoever you side with, the other will remember — and the ninth bridge will close to you forever.* ‘[POLITICS]’
- J **The Ukwe’s Root Breaches** — A root bursts through a village floor. It is looking for a specific name. *The name is carved on the root. The root is weeping. The one who broke the promise is still alive — and the ninth night they sleep, the root will find them.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **Leopard Society Coup** — The Wakers have infiltrated the Lodge. The masks are fighting. *You cannot tell who is who. Both sides wear leopard pelts. Both sides smell of blood — and the ninth mask you see will be the one that speaks with the Leopard King’s voice.* ‘[CONFLICT]’
- K **Calendar Fire** — A spark catches the Earth Society vault. The memories are burning. *The smoke forms faces. The faces are those who broke harmony. They are screaming — and the ninth scream is your own, from a promise you made and then forgot.* ‘[DISASTER]’
- A **The Crimson Falls Run Red** — The waterfall turns to blood. The Lethai-ar say the web-law has been broken. *The break was centuries ago. The falls are just catching up — and the ninth drop of blood carries the name of the first oath-breaker.* ‘[OMEN]’
- A+ **Mami Wata’s Gaze** — A figure rises from the black pool behind the falls. It asks: “What promise have you never been able to keep?” *If you lie, the water will take your voice. If you tell the truth, it will ask for a memory as interest — and the ninth memory you offer will be the one you need most.* ‘[SPIRIT]’ ‘[DEBT]’

(**Favor/Trust/Shard**) Leopard’s Favor (once, call on the Leopard Society for a hunt — you owe them a future hunt); Ukwe Memory (reroll a failed Survival test once per session, but GM gains 1 SB for a jungle complication); Nkisi Shard (add +1 Effect to a magical working, but the shard shatters and costs 1 Corruption).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Leopard’s Favor** — A leopard claw wrapped in red thread. One use to summon a Society hunt. *The favour is a bond. The Society will remember. The price is a future hunt — and the ninth hunt will be for your own name, if you break the bond.* ‘[DEBT]’
3. **Ukwe Memory (Leaf)** — A single leaf from the Speaking Tree. Reroll a failed Survival test once per session. *The leaf is green.*

It will not wilt. The tree remembers who took it — and the ninth time you use it, the leaf will turn black and whisper a name you have forgotten. ‘[MEMORY]’

4. **Nkisi Shard** — A piece of a broken power-object. Add +1 Effect to a magical working, then it shatters. *The shard is warm. It whispers secrets in a language you almost understand — and the ninth secret is always about a promise you made to yourself and broke.* ‘[MAGIC]’
5. **Honey-Jar (Royal Tithe)** — A clay pot of dark red honey. Trade it for safe passage through any grove. *The honey is thick. It moves in the jar as if alive. Do not open it — the ninth time you open it, the bees will remember your name and ask for a tithe.* ‘[TRADE]’
6. **Earth Society Tablet** — A strip of bark with a broken promise recorded. Present it to recall a forgotten harmony. *The bark is still growing. The memory is still fresh — and the ninth time you use it, the bark will grow over your hand and show you the promise you yourself broke.* ‘[MEMORY]’
7. **Lethai-ar Silk Cord** — A braided cord that records a witnessed promise. Use it to enforce any oath. *The cord tightens when the oath is broken. It will not stop until blood is drawn — and the ninth drop of blood will be your own, if you witnessed a false promise.* ‘[OATH]’
8. **Leopard Mask (Temporary)** — Wear it to pass as a Society hunter for one scene. *The mask has eye holes that see the weight of promises. It also sees your own — and the ninth time you wear it, the mask will not come off.* ‘[SECRET]’
9. **Waker’s Spore Pouch** — A bag of fever-mist spores. Release them to confuse pursuers. *The spores cause vivid hallucinations. The hallucinations are always of the Ukwe — and the ninth hallucination will be a question: “Why did you lie?”* ‘[STEALTH]’
10. **Nganga’s Hammer** — A small iron hammer. Drive a nail into any object to seal a spirit inside. *The hammer has a cost. Each nail requires a memory — and the ninth nail you drive will seal a fragment of your own soul into the object.* ‘[MAGIC]’
- J **The Ukwe’s Answer** — A single truth from the Speaking Tree, whispered on the wind. *The truth is always about a broken promise. The promise may not be yours — but the ninth time you listen, the tree will speak a promise you made and forgot.* ‘[TRUTH]’
- Q **Silk-Warden’s Mask** — A carved mask that grants safe passage across any Lethai-ar bridge. *The mask is also a witness. It will remember every promise you make while wearing it — and the ninth promise will be witnessed by the Hollow.* ‘[OATH]’
- K **Oath-Keeper’s Finger** — A dried root shaped like a digit. Use it to call an Oath-Keeper once. *The Oath-Keeper will settle one broken promise for you. Then it will ask for yours — and the ninth finger of its hand will point at the promise you most fear to keep.* ‘[DEATH]’

A **The First Nail** — A legendary iron nail that sealed the first spirit into the Ukwe. *Drive it into any tree to create a new Speaking Tree. The tree will remember everything — and the ninth name it speaks will be your own, unless you offer a memory in its place.* ‘[LEGEND]’

A+ **Mami Wata’s Tear** — A drop of water that never dries, said to be the spirit’s grief for a promise broken long ago. *Drink it to forget one broken promise permanently — but you will dream of drowning once each season. The ninth dream will be the promise itself, remembered.* ‘[WATER]’ ‘[MEMORY]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (favours, memories, shards) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **grove-omens** — bees that fly backward, roots that bleed sap, a mask that watches from the trees, the ninth bell of Ananse’s Child ringing in still air. If an A+ appears (special high-rank result), a spirit of the deep jungle (Mami Wata, Ananse’s Child, the Leopard King) manifests directly.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Three Societies:** Sekogo is governed by three overlapping authorities: the Leopard Society (hunters who restore balance), the Earth Society (elders who keep the Calendar of Witness), and the nganga (spirit-doctors who work with *minkisi*). A single elder often belongs to two societies, and the tension between their roles is where drama lives.
- **The Ukwe (Speaking Tree):** A living witness whose roots extend across Sekogo. Every broken promise, every forgotten harmony stains its leaves. It answers questions — but never with kindness, and never for free. Accepting its gift creates a reciprocal bond that the tree may call upon at any moment. The ninth root is never still — it searches for the name that was erased.
- **The Crimson Valley and Web-Law:** The Lethai-ar guard the valley with fierce neutrality. Their skin-tattoos (Marks) record promises witnessed. When a Lethai-ar dies, their Marks are cut from the skin and buried at the Ukwe’s roots. The web-law is unwritten; each warden carries a different clause in memory. The ninth clause is always a secret known only to the First Weaver’s ghost.
- **Mask Law:** In Sekogo, a mask is not a disguise — it is a role. Wearing the mask of a Leopard Society hunter, a Waker, or a spirit entitles you to speak for that office, but

also binds you to its taboos. Breaking a mask’s taboo (e.g., a Leopard mask showing mercy to a slayer) causes the mask to crack and the wearer to lose 1 die on all social rolls until they atone. The ninth mask is the Hollow’s own — it has no face, and it never cracks because it was never whole.

- **Bark Debt-Strings (*Mukanda*):** Promises are recorded on strips of bark called *mukanda*. Each strip is knotted; the knot tightens when the promise is strained, loosens when it is kept. A *mukanda* that rots means the debt is forgiven; one that hardens into wood means the interest has compounded. The ninth knot on a *mukanda* is never tied — it is left loose for the Hollow to judge.
- **Ananse’s Bargain (Trickster Mechanic):** Once per session, a character may call upon Ananse’s Child to “renegotiate” any promise, oath, or contract. Roll Spirit + Lore (DV 4). On a success, the terms shift in your favour — but the GM gains 1 SB and may add a hidden clause that will trigger at the worst possible moment. On a miss, the burden doubles — and the ninth clause added will be the Hollow’s own terms.
- **The *Mwitu* (Hollow of the Forest):** When the Ninth manifests in Sekogo, it is as the *Mwitu* — the forest that forgets where the village ends. It appears as a wall of grey mist between the trees, and it whispers: “Why are you still here?” Those who cannot answer lose their sense of direction (all navigation rolls at –1 die for one scene). The *Mwitu* can be appeased by leaving a *mukanda* at the edge of the mist — a promise to remember a forgotten name.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Root Father** — Grimmir. *The ancient pact between the jungle and the first honey-gatherer. His ninth root is the Hollow’s own.*
 - **The Masked One** — Mykkiel. *The law that wears a leopard’s face; the judge who hunts. His ninth mask is a blank — for the case he cannot judge.*
 - **The Spider’s Whisper** — Inaea. *The trickster who spins webs in the spaces between promises. Her ninth knot is never tied.*
 - **The Water Mother** — Raéyn. *Mami Wata, who holds the memories of the drowned. Her ninth tear is the one she never sheds.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ukwe’s Shadow and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Hollow is said to be the shadow of the Ukwe — the space where broken promises go when the tree forgets them. Aelaerem hedge-keepers leave offerings at the Ukwe’s roots to keep the Hollow from wandering. The ninth offering is always a *mukanda* with a single knot — a promise to remember.
- **Lethai-ar Silk and the Way of Silk:** The silk bridges of the Crimson Valley are made from spider-sap and oath-hair. Tulkani traders prize the silk for memory-cords;

Fhara water-clerks use it to seal well-contracts. A bolt of Crimson silk can buy safe passage across half the continent — but the ninth bolt is always reserved for the Hollow’s bridge.

- **Leopard Society and Ashaani Slavers:** The Leopard Society has a standing grudge against Ashaani slavers. A masked hunter may offer the party a deal: help free a group of captives from a Black Hand caravan, and the Society will forget an old broken promise. The ninth captive freed will be marked with a Leopard’s claw — a sign that they owe the Society a hunt.
- **Nganga and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The nganga of Sekogo believe the Kalrantha amulet is a rogue *nkisi* — a spirit-object that was never properly sealed. They want to drive a nail into it to bind the demon. The ninth nail would seal the amulet forever — but the nganga who drives it will become the amulet’s new keeper.
- **Ananse’s Child and the Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** The trickster spirit is known to trade fragments of forgotten prophecies for stories. Some psions claim that Ananse’s Child taught the first Echo-Readers the art of reading broken promises in the wind. The ninth prophecy it ever told was about the Hollow’s return — but it told it as a joke, and no one laughed.
- **The Neutral Kingdoms (North):** Smugglers from the unclaimed lands often carry Sekogo honey across the savannah. A Leopard Society hunt that crosses the border may find itself negotiating with a petty king who broke a promise to the Ukwe three generations ago. The king’s ninth ancestor was a witness — and his ghost still sits on the throne, waiting for the promise to be kept.

Sekogo Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Root:** Crumble a crust at the Ukwe’s base. Ignore the first *Ukwe Demands a Name* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Silk:** Tie a single knot in a Lethai-ar bridge cord. Cancel *Web-Law Challenge* or take −1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Nail:** Whisper a dead nganga’s name into a *nkisi*. Gain +1 Effect when using a spirit-object this scene, but the ancestors will expect an answer — and the ninth answer must be a promise. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Spit to the Mask:** Before donning a ceremonial mask, spit on the inside. If the mask accepts, you gain +1 die to all rolls while wearing it. If it rejects, the mask will not come off for 1d4 hours — and the ninth hour, the mask will speak. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Leopard Society** hunters or **Earth Society** elders.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bees** or **Lethai-ar** wardens.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **Oath-Keepers** or **Waker** spies.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **safe passage** through a grove.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource** clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local **Leopard Society** or **Green Council** druid becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **thorn-spirit** or **fog from the Crimson Falls**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **Waker** cell or **Oath-Keeper** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Leopard Society**, **Earth Society** guardians, or **Lethai-ar** archers arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **Ukwe speaks/Waker** poison spreads/**web-law** broken.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Leopard King**, **Ukwe's Voice**, or **Crimson Valley First Weaver** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — *nkisi* shatter/honey turns to blood/**Ukwe's root** breaches the ground.

- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Sekogo (Jungle Law):** Bees form words, tree bark weeps sap, the Ukwe's root trembles.
- **Sekogo (Crimson Valley):** Silk cords tighten, canyon walls bleed rust, the web-law recites itself.
- **Sekogo (Society Conflict):** Masks shift expressions, bark strips burn without flame, a ninth nail appears in every *nkisi*.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thorn Wall*.
- **Cut the Web (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a silk cord is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Hunt (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Leopard Society Hunt*, you pick who is targeted; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Root & Mask)

- **The Root-King (Nine Broken Promises)** — *Phases:* Promise Calls → Orchestrated Famine → Grove Coup. *Cracks:* burn a bark strip, expose a false memory, survive a harvest without honey. *The ninth root follows you home.*
- **The Mask that Walks (Leopard's Shadow)** — *Phases:* Midnight Hunts → Procession of Masks → Skin-Baptism of a Warden. *Cracks:* relic leopard claw, survivor testimony, the mask turning against them — and the ninth mask is always the Hollow's own.
- **Mami Wata's Wrath (Water Spirit)** — *Phases:* Pool Rises → Crimson Falls Reversed → Memory of the Drowned. *Cracks:* offer a true memory of loss, speak the name of a slaver ship she sank, return a stolen mirror to her pool. *The ninth memory she takes is your own.*

Patronage & Power

Among Sekogo, power flows through witnessed promises, honey, and the consent of the jungle. The Green Council rules by consensus, but the Leopard Society restores balance, the Earth Society keeps the Calendar of Witness, and the nganga negotiate with spirits. No single faction holds all the power — and that is by design.

For the GM: Power in Sekogo society is measured in broken promises and witnessed oaths. Patronage often takes the form of favours, memories, or shards — each carrying a future cost. To emphasise this:

- Tie rewards to objects that create reciprocal bonds (leopard claws, Ukwé leaves, *nkisi* shards, *mukanda* strips) that can be called in at inconvenient moments.
- Let rival societies offer conflicting judgments, forcing players to choose whose law to follow — and whose ninth clause to honour.
- Use the honey-orchards, druid circles, and silk bridges as arenas for social contests, where a gift of honey is a treaty and a broken promise is a death sentence.
- Introduce trickster spirits (Ananse's Child) to complicate simple resolutions — they are excellent wild cards, and their ninth bell is always the Hollow's cue.
- Remember that Mami Wata is not evil; she is ancient. She collects memories, not lives. A bargain with her may be the only way to escape a blood-feud — but the ninth memory she asks for will be the one you cannot spare.

In Sekogo society, the jungle remembers everything — and the Ukwé forgets nothing. The *Mwitu* waits at the edge of the ninth root, and the ninth bell of Ananse's Child rings only when a promise is already broken.

Chapter 7

Lethai-ar of the Crimson Valley

Silk Bridges and Web-Law.

Kofi whispers: *“The Crimson Valley is a wound of red stone, carved by a river that runs rust-coloured after every rain. The Lethai-ar guard the bridges. Their web-law is unwritten. Cross a bridge without a witness, and the silk will remember your weight – and your name.”*
The Crimson Valley is a deep jungle rift between Sekogo and Oshiira – a scar of red stone, carved by a river that runs rust-coloured after every rain. Here, the Lethai-ar guard their borders with fierce neutrality, their chestnut-brown skin blending with the canyon walls. Silk bridges span the gorges, woven from spider-sap and oath-hair. The web-law is unwritten, carried in the memory of each warden; it keeps both empires from using the valley as a shortcut to war. Every promise is a strand. Every broken oath is a tremor through the whole valley.

“Never step onto a silk bridge without first naming a witness. The bridge will remember your footsteps. If you fall, it will ask why no one was watching.”

— Silk-Warden Anara

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice porridge and fermented tea – the rice from terraces cut into canyon walls, the tea aged in clay pots buried beneath the bridges. The tea is bitter. The bitterness is for memory.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a Mark. Promise, Debt, Witness, Apology, Interest, Cut, Forgive, and the ninth – the empty space where a Mark was erased. The erased Mark is a broken promise. The cut is a scar.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their Marks. Fresh Marks mean new promises. Faded Marks mean unpaid debts. Cut Marks mean exile. The exiled are not spoken to. They are not remembered.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-cutting – which is war. A bridge is a promise between two shores. Cut it, and the valley tightens its web.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The valley is not a place. It is a creature – a sleeping serpent whose spine is the canyon walls, whose scales are the silk bridges, whose heart is the rust-coloured river. The Lethai-ar are its parasites. They do not know it is asleep.

Where do people go when they die? *To the river. Bodies wrapped in silk and cast into the rust-coloured water. The river carries them downstream, into the Ukwe's territory. The Ukwe drinks. The Ukwe remembers.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a Mark – a promise cut from your own skin. It is pressed into the wronged party's ledger. If they accept, the debt is transferred. If they refuse, the Mark is buried. Buried Marks are debts that never die.*

What is the most important festival? *The Weaving of the New Bridge (spring). The silk is harvested from the canyon's spiders. The bridge is woven in a single night. It is named after a promise. The promise is always the same: the valley will hold.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The river's rust colour is not iron. It is blood – the blood of the serpent that sleeps beneath the canyon. The serpent is wounded. The wound has been bleeding for nine centuries. The Lethai-ar know. They do nothing. If the serpent wakes, the law ends.*

7.1 Lethai-ar — “The Crimson Valley”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The bridge remembers every step. The silk knows every promise.*

Silk-Warden (Elite): “The web-law is not written on parchment. It is woven into every bridge, every strand, every knot. When a promise is made, the valley remembers. When a promise is broken, the silk tightens. We are not judges. We are the loom. The spider spins; we only follow the thread.”

Mark-Cutter (Commoner): “Each line on my skin is a promise I witnessed. Each line is a story I carry. When I die, they will cut these marks from my body and bury them at the Ukwe’s roots. Then the tree will remember what I witnessed. I hope it is enough. The thread does not break; it only passes to the next hand.”

Genre / Mood: High-fantasy legal drama, spidersilk noir, ancestral witness.

Starting Location: The central silk bridge, where the gorge is deepest and the wind carries the smell of rust. A Silk-Warden blocks your path, her mask painted with roots: “The web-law demands a toll. Not in coin – in a promise. Swear that you will not use this valley to carry steel to Ashaan, or turn back now. The thread is watching. So is the spider.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Crimson Valley is a deep jungle rift between Sekogo and Oshiira – a wound of red stone, carved by a river that runs rust-coloured after every rain. Here, the Lethai-ar guard their borders with fierce neutrality, their chestnut-brown skin blending with the canyon walls. Silk bridges span the gorges, woven from spider-sap and oath-hair, strong enough to hold a caravan and light enough to sway in the monsoon wind. The web-law is unwritten, carried in the memory of each warden; it keeps both empires from using the valley as a shortcut to war.

Unlike their northern kin who fell from grace, the Lethai-ar are adopted children of the old powers – not fallen, but chosen to carry memory. Each can name the specific mountain, river, or grove where their ancestor left the spirit world to become mortal. Their skin-tattoos (Marks) are woven with red ochre and jungle sap, each line a promise witnessed, each curve a story recorded. When a Lethai-ar dies, their Marks are cut from the skin and buried at the Ukwe’s roots, so the tree may remember what they witnessed.

The valley itself is alive. The silk remembers every footfall; the river whispers the names of those who have crossed; and in the oldest bridges, the spider – Inaea, the weaver of bonds – still spins. The Lethai-ar do not worship her, but they honour the thread. They say that every promise is a strand in her web, and that a broken oath sends a tremor through the whole valley.

What you notice first: The whisper of silk ropes in the wind. The smell of red ochre and damp stone. The way every Lethai-ar touches their left wrist when they speak a name – a gesture of witness.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never step onto a silk bridge without first naming a witness. The bridge will remember your footsteps. If you fall, it will ask why no one was watching.

Regional Mood: The Weight of Witness

Power here is measured in witnessed promises, silk strands, and the balance of the web-law. The valley is neutral ground – Oshiiran grain barges do not float here, and Ashaani armies dare not march. The Lethai-ar trade silk for honey with Sekogo druids and stonesong for poison with Ngomebe masons. Their Marks are not decoration; they are a public memory, written on skin, read by anyone who knows the phase of the crimson moon. A Lethai-ar who bears a Mark they cannot fulfil loses standing; a warden who cuts a bridge without cause is exiled. But the true authority is the web itself – the invisible threads that connect every oath ever sworn in the valley. The Lethai-ar do not create the web. They tend it.

Prominent NPCs of the Crimson Valley

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Warden Anara Silk-warden of the central span Keep the Oshiiran grain barges from crossing Her left arm is covered in Marks from wrist to shoulder. She will not say what they mean.

Mark-Cutter Tebe Tattooist who records promises Witness a treaty between Sekogo and Ngomebe She uses a needle of silk-fiber and ink made from crushed crimson stone. The ink glows under the full moon.

Bridge-Keeper Solan Guardian of the eastern crossing Prevent Ashaani scouts from using the valley He has not slept in nine days. He says the bridge whispers when someone lies.

Elder Mira Memory-keeper of the valley's spirits Record the name of every ancestor who walked the spirit path She carries a bundle of silk cords, each tied to a different knot. The knots are the names.

The Spider's Child Tulkani trader of oath-silk (whisperer of Inaea) Buy a bolt of crimson silk for a story – and to listen She is not Lethai-ar but has lived in the valley for thirty years. The wardens tolerate her. She never closes her eyes.

The Unmarked A Lethai-ar who refused any Marks An outcast who lives in the gorge below the bridges Her skin is blank. She is invisible to the web-law – and to the valley's spirits. She carries a single knotted thread.

Names of the Crimson Valley

Lethai-ar names are soft, with rolling consonants and vowel endings. Surnames often denote a bridge, a gorge, or a spirit-ancestor. Epithets refer to Marks or witnessed deeds.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Solan	Anara	Silkweave	<i>the Unbroken</i>	
Tebe	Mira	Gorge-born	<i>the Ninth Witness</i>	
Kael	Nira	Root-memory	<i>the Marked</i>	
Veth	Liana	Spider-kin	<i>the Bridge-Heart</i>	
Renn	Sora	Crimson-touch	<i>the Unweaver</i>	
Thorn	Aria	Oath-strand	<i>the Still Watcher</i>	

(Bridge/Gorge/Roots) Silk bridge spanning a crimson gorge – ropes sing in the wind; a Lethai-ar village built into the canyon wall; the Ukwe's roots clutching the water below the central span.

Spades — Places

2. **Central Silk Bridge** – A wide span woven from crimson and grey strands. The bridge hums when a promise is made on it. *The pitch tells the warden if the promise is true. If the thread vibrates at the ninth frequency, the spider is listening.* ‘[WITNESS]’
3. **Mark-Cutter’s Studio** – A cave with a stone table and pots of ochre. *The walls are carved with Marks that were never cut into skin. They are stories the cutter refused to witness. The stone is warm to the touch.* ‘[CRAFT]’
4. **Ukwe’s Riverside Root** – A massive root that dips into the crimson river. *The root is warm. Touch it, and the tree will show you one forgotten promise from a dead Lethai-ar. The water ripples in response.* ‘[MEMORY]’
5. **Abandoned Silk Span** – A broken bridge hanging over the gorge. The cut ends are frayed. *The cut was not clean – someone broke an oath mid-crossing. The strands still twitch.* ‘[DEATH]’
6. **Spirit-Anchor Stone** – A boulder where the first ancestor left the spirit world. *The stone is smooth. It is warm even in winter. Lethai-ar leave offerings of red ochre here – and sometimes a single knotted thread.* ‘[RITUAL]’
7. **Warden’s Watchtower** – A stone needle built into the canyon wall, with a signal mirror. *The mirror flashes in code. The code is the web-law. No outsider has broken it. The code changes when the spider dreams.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Hollow of the Unmarked** – A cave below the eastern bridge, hidden by a waterfall. *The cave has no silk. The Unmarked lives here, weaving nets from her own hair. Her hair is knotted.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
9. **Crimson River Ford** – A shallow crossing where the water is clear, not red. *The ford is sacred. No oath sworn here can be broken. The water would turn black – and the spider would feel it.* ‘[OATH]’
10. **Elder’s Cord-House** – A longhouse where the memory-knots are stored. *Each cord is a name. The cords are hung from the ceiling. They move in no wind. When a name is forgotten, a cord falls.* ‘[MEMORY]’
- J **The Spider’s Stall** – A Tulkani merchant’s tent at the valley’s southern exit. She sells silk to anyone. *The price is a story. The story must be about a thread that held – or a thread that broke. She never blinks.* ‘[TRADE]’
- Q **Bridge of the Ninth Strand** – A legend: a bridge woven from a single hair. *It appears only at dawn on the first day of spring. Those who cross it gain a new name – and a new thread to their web.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- K **The Cut Stone** – A boulder split by an oath-breaker’s fall. *The split is shaped like a human body. The stone weeps water when the oath-breaker’s name is spoken. The water tastes of rust.* ‘[DEATH]’

A **The First Bridge (Myth)** – Where the first Lethai-ar wove the first strand. *It is invisible. Only those who have witnessed nine true promises can see it. The spider sits at the far end, waiting.* ‘[MYTH]’

(**Warden/Cutter/Trader**) Silk-warden with a mask painted with the Ukwe’s roots; Mark-cutter with a needle of silk-fiber; Tulkani spider-trader with a bundle of oath-cords.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Silk-Warden** – Mask carved from crimson wood, painted with oath-names. *She never blinks when standing on the bridge. The bridge does not forgive distraction. She counts her breaths in eights.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
 3. **Mark-Cutter** – Hands stained red with ochre, eyes that measure skin. *She asks each client: “What promise do you want the world to remember?” The answer becomes a Mark – and a thread in the web.* ‘[CRAFT]’
 4. **Bridge-Keeper** – Old, grey-haired, missing three fingers from a snapped strand. *He carries a whistle made from a spider’s fang. The whistle calls the bridge to tighten – or to loosen. He never uses it.* ‘[WITNESS]’
 5. **Elder (Memory-Keeper)** – Bundles of silk cords hang from her belt. *She knows every name carved into every root of the Ukwe. She has forgotten her own. The cords remember it for her.* ‘[MEMORY]’
 6. **Tulkani Spider (Trader)** – Wears a shawl of crimson silk, speaks in riddles. *She pays for silk with stories. The stories become new strands. The bridge grows. She never closes her eyes – she says the spider does not sleep.* ‘[TRADE]’
 7. **The Unmarked** – A Lethai-ar without Marks, living in the hollow. *She whispers to the waterfall. The waterfall whispers back. No one knows what they say. Her thread is her own.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
 8. **Youth Seeking a Mark** – A young Lethai-ar on their first witness journey. *They carry a single strand of undyed silk. When they witness a promise, they will dye it crimson. The dye is their own blood.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
 9. **Oath-Breaker’s Ghost** – A translucent figure pacing the broken bridge. *It repeats the words of the promise it broke. The words are getting quieter. When they stop, the thread will snap.* ‘[DEATH]’
 10. **Sekogo Honey Trader** – A druid with a jar of dark honey, trading for silk poison. *He offers the honey as a gift. The wardens test it by feeding a drop to the bridge. The bridge sways if it is poisoned – or if the gift is false.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **Ngomebe Stone-Singer** – A mason with a tuning fork, here to buy silk for sledge-wax seals. *He taps the bridge with his fork. The note tells him how many promises it has witnessed. The note is always an octave below the spider’s hum.* ‘[CRAFT]’

- Q The First Ancestor's Echo** – A voice heard at the Spirit-Anchor Stone at midnight. *It asks: "Why did you leave the spirit world?" The answer must be a promise. The spider listens.* '[RITUAL]'
- K The Spider's Daughter** – A half-Lethai-ar child raised by the Tulkani trader. She has no Marks. *Her skin is blank. She is learning to read knots – and to spin her own thread. She never asks twice.* '[COMMUNITY]'
- A The Ninth Warden (Legend)** – A warden who cut her own bridge to stop an invasion. *She is said to walk the valley at dusk, carrying a coil of silk. She offers one free crossing – but the crossing leads to the spider's web.* '[LEGEND]'

(Strand/Challenge/Fall) A silk strand snaps – lose 1 Supply to repair; a Lethai-ar challenges you to recite the web-law; a traveler falls from the bridge – the party must witness their last words.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Snapped Strand** – A rope on a bridge breaks. Lose 1 Supply to repair. *The break is clean. Someone cut it with a blade. The blade was from Ashaan – or from a broken promise.* '[DISASTER]'
3. **Web-Law Challenge** – A warden blocks the bridge: "Recite the ninth clause." *The ninth clause is unwritten. Each warden carries a different version. You must guess. The spider knows the true one.* '[SOCIAL]' '[RIDDLE]'
4. **Fall from the Bridge** – A traveler slips. The bridge asks: "Who witnessed this?" *If no one answers, the traveler's name is erased from the Ukwe's roots – and the spider weaves a new strand.* '[DEATH]' '[WITNESS]'
5. **Oshiiran Surveyors** – Grain auditors arrive with a map, claiming the valley's water rights. *They carry a treaty stamped with the Widow's seal. The seal is a forgery. The bridge hums in warning.* '[AUTHORITY]' '[POLITICS]'
6. **Ashaani Scouts (Disguised)** – Veiled Sister agents posing as spice merchants. *They do not touch their left wrist when speaking a name. The wardens notice. The thread tightens.* '[STEALTH]' '[POLITICS]'
7. **Mark-Cutter's Witness Called** – A Lethai-ar's Marks begin to glow red. A promise is overdue. *The witness is not present. The party is the closest witness. The duty transfers – as does the thread.* '[WITNESS]' '[COMMUNITY]'
8. **Bridge Poisoning** – Someone smears a solvent on the silk strands. The bridge begins to fray. *The solvent is made from Sekogo honey and Ashaani dust. The Spider knows who sold it. The threads are weeping.* '[MAGIC]' '[DISASTER]'

9. **Elder’s Memory Fails** – The cord-keeper forgets a name. The knot unravels. *The forgotten name is an old promise. The Ukwe’s root trembles. Something is coming – or someone.* ‘[MEMORY]’ ‘[DEATH]’
 10. **The Unmarked’s Bargain** – The outcast offers to guide the party through the gorge. Her price is a promise. *The promise: “Do not speak my name after I die.” Refuse, and she leaves you to the spiders. Accept, and she ties a knot.* ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[WITNESS]’
 - J **Crimson River Floods** – Rain turns the ford to a torrent. The bridge is the only crossing. *The water is red. Faces appear in the foam. They are oath-breakers, still trying to cross. The spider watches.* ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’
 - Q **Warden Schism** – Two wardens disagree on the web-law. They cut each other’s bridges. *The valley is now divided. The party must choose which side to cross – or stay stuck forever. The spider waits.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[POLITICS]’
 - K **The First Bridge Appears** – The mythical bridge manifests at dawn. Crossing it gives a new name. *The new name is a promise. The promise is to the First Ancestor. The ancestor will collect – and the spider will weave.* ‘[MYTH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’
 - A **The Ninth Warden Returns** – The legend appears, offering a free crossing. *The crossing leads to the spider’s web. The Hollow asks: “What promise did you break?” Answer poorly, and you become a new strand.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[LEGEND]’
- (**Cord/Mask/Shard**) Silk truth-cord (enforce any oath); warden’s mask (safe passage on any bridge for one crossing); Ukwe root shard (one question about a forgotten promise).

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Silk Truth-Cord** – A braided strand dyed crimson. Use it to enforce any oath. *The cord tightens when the oath is broken. It will not stop until the promise is kept – or the spider releases it.* ‘[OATH]’
3. **Warden’s Mask** – A wooden mask painted with roots. Safe passage on any bridge for one crossing. *The mask has no eye holes. You must trust the bridge to see for you. The bridge sees through the spider’s eyes.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Ukwe Root Shard** – A piece of the tree’s root that grows near the river. *Touch it, and the Ukwe will answer one question about a forgotten promise. The answer is always true – and always a thread.* ‘[MEMORY]’
5. **Mark-Cutter’s Needle** – A silk-fiber needle. Use it to record a witnessed promise as a temporary Mark. *The Mark fades after one season. The story remains – and the spider remembers.* ‘[CRAFT]’
6. **Bridge-Keeper’s Whistle** – A fang whistle. Blow it to tighten any silk bridge for one scene. *The whistle works once. The bridge will remember the favour – and the spider will know.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’

7. **Elder's Memory Cord** – A knotted silk cord that contains a forgotten name. *Untie the knot to learn the name. The name is a promise. Fulfil it, or the cord will retie itself – and the spider will watch.* '[MEMORY]'
8. **Spider's Story-Strand** – A bolt of crimson silk bought with a story. *The silk is soft. It glows under moonlight. Trade it for safe passage through Tulkani camps – or give it to the spider.* '[TRADE]'
9. **The Unmarked's Net** – A net woven from human hair. *Throw it to catch a spirit. The net can hold a bound spirit for one hour. The spirit will bargain for freedom – with a promise.* '[MAGIC]'
10. **Crimson Ochre Pot** – A clay pot of red pigment. Use it to Mark a promise on stone or skin. *The ochre never dries. The promise remains witnessable forever – until the spider cuts the thread.* '[CRAFT]'
- J **Ninth Strand Fragment** – A piece of the legendary bridge. Once per campaign, cross any gap as if on solid ground. *The fragment crumbles after use. The first bridge will remember you – and the spider will ask for a toll.* '[LEGEND]'
- Q **The Cut Stone's Water** – A vial of water that seeps from the oath-breaker's boulder. *Drink it to remember a promise you broke. The memory is painful. The pain is the price – and the thread.* '[DEATH]'
- K **First Ancestor's Blessing** – A whispered promise from the Spirit-Anchor Stone. *Once, you may reroll any failed roll involving a witnessed promise. The ancestor watches – and the spider weaves.* '[RITUAL]'
- A **The Ninth Warden's Coil** – A coil of silk said to belong to the legendary warden. *Use it to cut a bridge without angering the web-law. The coil then unravels – and the spider's shadow falls on you.* '[LEGEND]'

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (cords, masks, shards) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **valley-omens** – silk cords humming in still air, the crimson river running clear, a bridge that sways without wind. The spider is near.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Web-Law:** The unwritten legal code of the Crimson Valley. Each warden carries a different clause in memory; together, they form a complete web. To cross a bridge, a traveler must answer a question about the web-law. The answer changes with each warden. On a successful roll (Wits + Lore, DV 3), you may bypass the challenge; on a failure, you must offer a promise instead – and the spider will witness it.
- **Marks (Skin-Tattoos):** Each Lethai-ar's Marks are a public record of promises witnessed. The Marks are cut from the skin after death and buried at the Ukwe's roots. To read a living Lethai-ar's Marks, one must know the phase of the crimson moon and the position of the valley's spirits. A character who studies a Lethai-ar's Marks for a scene may ask the GM one question about a promise that Lethai-ar has witnessed; the GM must answer truthfully – but the spider may also listen.
- **Spirit Ancestry:** Every Lethai-ar can name the specific spirit (mountain, river, grove) where their ancestor left the spirit world to become mortal. That spirit is their witness; they owe it a promise at birth, and that promise is never fully paid. Once per journey, a Lethai-ar may invoke their spirit ancestor to gain +1 die on a roll related to that spirit's domain (e.g., a river ancestor aids a crossing). The spider notes the favour.
- **Witness Economy:** Instead of tracking debt, the Crimson Valley uses **Witness** as currency. A character who witnesses a promise gains 1 Witness token. Tokens can be spent to: gain +1 die on a roll involving that promise, force an oath-breaker to reroll a successful deception, or demand a favour from someone who witnessed the same promise. Witness tokens are lost when the promise is fulfilled or broken – and the spider watches the exchange.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The First Weaver (Inaea):** The spider who taught the first knot; mercy is a strand, not a cut. Her web is the valley's memory.
 - **The Serpent Judge (Isoka):** The fang that decides; a promise kept is a skin shed. She watches from the river stones.
 - **The Crimson Witness (The Witness):** The flame that sees through silk; no oath hidden from its light. The bridge glows when it passes.
 - **The Bridge Father (The Traveler):** The road that crosses the gorge; every crossing is a promise. He walks the strands at dusk.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Crimson Silk and the Way of Silk:** The silk of the Crimson Valley is prized across the continent for vow-cords, well-contracts, and bridge-building. The Tulkani spider-traders are the primary merchants; a single bolt can buy safe passage from Fhara to Dhahara. A Tulkani story-seller may accept crimson silk as payment for a truth – but the spider will ask for a copy.

- **The Ukwe’s Roots and Sekogo:** The Ukwe’s roots extend into the Crimson Valley. The Lethai-ar bury their dead Marks at the riverbank root, creating a unique relationship with the Speaking Tree. The Ukwe knows every promise ever made in the valley. A Sekogo druid may ask the Ukwe to witness a new oath, binding it with the weight of the valley – and the spider’s thread.
- **Web-Law and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant judges respect the web-law as a valid legal system. A Lethai-ar truth-cord is admissible in a Covenant court. Some judges have learned to read Marks. A Covenant justiciar may offer to translate a web-law dispute into imperial law – but the translation always favours the spider.
- **The Unmarked and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** Lethai-ar who refuse all Marks become invisible to the web-law – and to the Hollow. The Hollow cannot track them. Some Aelaerem seek out the Unmarked to learn the secret of blank skin. The Unmarked charge a promise: “Do not seek me again.” The spider does not visit them.

Lethai-ar Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bridge:** Crumble a crust onto the first strand. Ignore the first *Snapped Strand* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a truth-cord. Cancel *Web-Law Challenge* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Root:** Whisper a dead warden’s name into the Ukwe’s root. Gain +1 Effect when crossing a bridge this scene, but mark Obligation to the First Ancestor – and the spider will know. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from Silk-Wardens or Mark-Cutters.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby bridge-keepers or Tulkani traders.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for Elders or the Unmarked.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you time or safe crossing.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local Silk-Warden or Bridge-Keeper becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to snapped strand or rising river.

- **Foe Appears:** An Oshiiran surveyor or Ashaani scout arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes Compromised/Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional Wardens, Mark-Cutters, or bridge guards arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes – bridge cut / web-law broken / First Bridge appears.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1**/**Harm 1**/**Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Elder, Ninth Warden, or First Ancestor's Echo intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically – **bridge collapses** / **river turns black** / **Ukwe root rises**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice – **omen appears** / **blessing lost** / **curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Crimson Valley (Web-Law):** Silk strands glow, truth-cords tighten, the Ukwe's root hums a name.
- **Crimson Valley (Marks):** Tattoos itch, ochre stains spread, a dead Mark appears on living skin.
- **Crimson Valley (Bridges):** Ropes whisper, the gorge echoes with footsteps that are not there, a bridge sways toward the Hollow.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Swaying Bridge*.
- **Cut the Strand (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a truth-cord is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Crossing (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Fall from the Bridge*, you pick who catches the fallen; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Silk & Promise)

- **The Unweaver (Nine Broken Strands) – Phases:** Snapped Cords → Orchestrated Falls → Bridge Coup. *Cracks:* repair a broken strand, expose a false witness, survive a crossing without a promise.
- **The Silent Warden (Oath of the Unmarked) – Phases:** Forgotten Promises → Procession of the Blank → Skin-Baptism of an Elder. *Cracks:* relic truth-cord, survivor testimony, the Marks turning against them.

Patronage & Power

Among the Lethai-ar, power flows through witnessed promises, silk strands, and the authority of the wardens. The web-law is unwritten, but every warden carries a piece of it. Marks are public, stories are visible, and the Ukwe remembers everything. The spider – Inaea – does not rule, but she watches. Her threads are the bonds between families, the knots that hold the valley together, and the silent witness to every oath. **For the GM:** Power in the Crimson Valley is measured in witnessed oaths and the trust of the bridge. Patronage often takes the form of truth-cords, masks, or root shards – each tied to a specific promise. To emphasise this:

- Tie rewards to objects that record or enforce promises (cords, masks, shards) that can be challenged, broken, or called in.
- Let rival wardens issue conflicting interpretations of the web-law, forcing players to choose whose bridge to cross.
- Use the bridges, Mark-cutter's studio, and the Ukwe's root as arenas for social contests, where a witnessed promise is a weapon and a broken strand is a death sentence.
- Remember that the spider is not a god – she is a presence. She does not speak, but the valley hums with her attention. When a promise is broken, the threads tremble.

In the Crimson Valley, the bridge remembers every step – and the spider forgets no promise.

Appendix A

Travel & Trade in the South

This appendix summarises the unique travel modes and trade goods of the Southern Realms. For core travel procedures (legs, clocks, roles), see the *Fate's Edge SRD or Player/GM Guides*.

Travel Modes

- **River Legs (Oshiira, Crimson Valley):** Canals, weigh-houses, and canal mothers. Travel clocks advance when barges queue at locks.
- **Desert Legs (Ashaan):** Water is the primary resource. A dry well hazard can end a journey.
- **Jungle Legs (Sekogo, Crimson Valley):** Navigation by smell and sound; hidden Leopard Society patrols.
- **Highland Legs (Taharka):** Thin air; breath-counting; passes that close for storms.
- **Stone Legs (Ngomebe):** Travel with a walking city; roller integrity and ancestor favour clocks.

Trade Goods & Currencies

- **Oshiira:** Grain ledger receipts, Vermilion Corps stamps. Accepted in all Covenant ports.
- **Ashaan:** Spirit-lamps (bound names), brass seals. Illegal in most Covenant jurisdictions.
- **Ngomebe:** Keystone shards, sledge-wax. Bartered for iron and Aeler engineering.
- **Taharka:** Pass-stones, horse-bonds, coffee measures. Honour currency in the highlands.
- **Sekogo:** Honey-jars, Ukwe leaves (witness tokens). Spirits accept them as offerings.

- **Crimson Valley:** Witness cords, warden's masks. Accepted as proof of oath in Covenant courts.

Regional Hazards (d6)

When travelling through the Southern Realms, the GM may roll on this table for a regional hazard:

1. **Dust Storm (Ashaan):** Navigation DV +1; mark Fatigue.
2. **Canal Lock Sabotage (Oshiira):** Delay 2 segments; bribes required.
3. **Keystone Crack (Ngomebe):** City stops; ancestor favour clock advances.
4. **Landslide (Taharka):** Pass blocked; detour adds 3 segments.
5. **Spirit Demands Toll (Sekogo):** Offer honey or a story; refusal causes spirit attack.
6. **Bridge Web-Law Challenge (Crimson Valley):** Recite a clause or pay a promise.

Colophon

This book was written on paper that had been a cargo manifest, a love letter, and a bandage. The ink is lampblack cut with salt water and the ash of a burnt confession. The binding is grey cord tied with nine knots. The ninth knot is not cut.

Kofi of the Salt Syndicate composed the preface under a borrowed lamp in a Mbaro weigh-house, though he admits he may have embellished a few tariffs. The almanacs were gathered from traders, spies, and the occasional honest farmer. The generator tables were tested in the field – meaning we ran them while a Oath-Keeper counted our breaths. They work.

If you find yourself in a market and a salt trader offers you a discount, check his seals. The ledger is open. The scales are balanced. The ninth page is waiting.

“The road is a ledger. Every oasis is a credit, every broken wheel a debt.” – Dusana of the Raven Road